honeyflower

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by cistus

Summary

Mydei is sent on a three-month expedition to find more information on the whereabouts of Castrum Kremnos. When he returns, it's with the knowledge of a growing problem he's desperate to conceal.

All Phainon wants is to understand why their relationship has inexplicably frayed, and yet, he only seems to make matters worse with each attempt to uncover the secret at the center of it all.

Chapter 1: devil's hand

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Before the Evernight blanketed the lands, and the foul Tide began its campaign, the city-state of Kios was once a bustling trading hub, welcoming hundreds of travelers each day through its open gates. A great temple to the fair Talanton stood proud in the city's center, around which a bountiful market flourished; balance coins oft traded hands, and at all hours of the day, the shouts of vendors peddling their myriad wares and shouts of haggling could be heard.

Diomede once minded the noise, all those years ago. She'd peer out the doors of her clinic, brow furrowed in anger, at those noisy merchants. A garden lay between the clinic and the market, and yet, the sound carried through the vine-draped trellises and flowering shrubs. What an annoyance, she thought, to have to listen to that din at all hours.

But Titans, dear Titans above, does she miss it now.

She still waits in the clinic, in the quiet remnants of the once-busy town, waiting for travelers. They don't come by much anymore, but enough do for her to stay.

Most of her time is spent reading at the clinic's front desk. A young man used to be her attendant, as she was far too busy to triage patients herself. He begged her to come along with everyone else who fled when the Tide first came, said that Kios's Council promised safety in the great city of Okhema and that if she stayed here, she'd surely die. Of course, she refused to follow.

Who else will tend to the injured if not her? So long as travelers continue to limp through her doors, broken and bleeding, she's needed here. If the Tide consumes her, so be it. Her sacrifice will not have been in vain.

Today, whenever that day might be on the calendar that she can no longer track in this perpetual twilight, she hears the slow, steady footsteps of an approaching dromas outside. She closes her book, but doesn't rise from the desk; she's placed signs outside the clinic and has the lights on to signal that she's here, so if these travelers need her, they can come to her.

A minute later, and the door is pushed open. A lone man enters. A heavy crimson cloak obscures his form, but from what she can see, he appears to be in good health. His blond, shoulder-length hair is kempt, some of it knotted in a neat braid that hangs by his neck. His features are sharp but not gaunt with hunger. His eyes are clear, unclouded by pain.

"Hello, do you require a doctor?" she asks, the words rasping in a throat rough with disuse.

"Not for the time being, no," the man replies. His voice is deep, and though he doesn't speak loudly, there is something about him that demands attention. "I'm on an expedition with a group of my soldiers, and we were planning to stop here for a day to rest. Is it acceptable if we set up camp near your clinic?"

"I don't own this city, you're free to do as you please."

"If you're the only soul left, doesn't that make it yours, in some sense?"

She sees something in those eyes when they meet hers, something powerful and terrified in equal parts. The sharpness of a warrior meets with royal self-assurance, and then beyond that is fear, well-concealed but not invisible, not to those who spend their lives reading others.

Who is this man? She will not ask, but she will wonder.

"Perhaps. But I don't claim ownership--truly, if you're concerned, then don't be. It's acceptable if you camp nearby, and if you need my assistance, I'm happy to offer it."

"If you're certain. Thank you for your generosity."

She's left alone for a quint, listening to the faint sounds of conversation as this man and his soldiers pitch their tents and settle down for their rest. A few come in, asking for medicine for minor ailments and bandages for small wounds.

The armor they wear is unfamiliar to her, as she's not the worldly sort, and she can only guess what city-state they may be from. They seem to be competent warriors, considering how few injuries they've sustained despite the ever-present danger of the Tide surrounding the city. Perhaps they're from Okhema and are on some sort of mission; she's heard recent travelers speak of some Chrysos Heirs, and the soldiers' leader seems authoritative enough to be a person of great import.

Again, she will not ask. Whatever happens beyond the crumbling walls of Kios is not her problem, not anymore. All she'll do is treat these soldiers and send them on their way.

Eventually, she presumes she's tended to all of them, as she's left alone once more. The sounds outside have quieted--they must've gone to rest. She takes inventory of her supplies, and then returns to her seat at the counter to read until sleep decides to come for her as well.

But then, just as her eyelids begin to droop, the man re-enters, this time approaching her instead of lingering at the entrance. The metal plating of his armor clatters with each soft footfall. He's gentler than she would've guessed. It makes her like him more; she's never appreciated the travelers who stomp around as if they own this place.

"You're more than a field medic," he notes, without greeting, after surveying the certificates on her walls.

She blinks back the sleep in her eyes before responding. "I am a doctor, yes. I received my training at the Grove. Just know that I lack many supplies out here, and there are surgeries I cannot perform."

"Can you test for pregnancy?"

The question, asked cautiously, gives her a moment's pause. She hasn't been asked for such a test since before Kios was abandoned--the travelers that come by here aren't ever in such a delicate condition.

"I believe I can, but allow me to check my storage."

On a bottom shelf, covered in a layer of dust, she finds the vial she seeks. A thin, clear liquid is inside, made from hollyhock sap and Aquila's purified tears. It still seems acceptable for the test despite its age; even if it weren't, she can't hope to make any more of it with her meager supplies, so it will have to do. She brings it back to the man, along with a sewing needle sterilized with pilfered whiskey.

"Lance a finger with this, and squeeze a drop of blood into the vial. Swirl it around for a minute, then let it sit for another. If the liquid turns green, it's positive."

The man accepts the items with a polite nod, and immediately turns to leave.

"Wait a moment," she says, before he can make it out the door. "Inform whomever this is for that they may come to me for assistance should the test be positive. I can provide some supplements or a termination, whichever is desired."

She's not certain, but based on the way the man's posture stiffens, she thinks it may not be for anybody but him. Despite her suspicions, she won't press. If he really is with child, he's free to decide his next move.

"... I will."

The man does not return to her.

She drifts off at her desk for a dreamless, dark sleep, and when she awakens, a peek outside reveals that the group has departed. They didn't stay for long, they must truly be on an important mission , she thinks.

It shouldn't matter to her, and yet, she finds that her feet have carried her to the remnants of the camp, prying eyes scanning the ground. Nothing has been left out in the open; they cleaned up well after themselves. So, she looks elsewhere. There's a small planter at the edge of the plaza, full of long-dead plants, that she bends down to inspect.

Just as she anticipated, she finds it there: the vial, discarded in secret.

The liquid contents are a bright, undeniable green.

After a journey of three months, one would think that the sight of the Holy City imminent on the horizon, promising long-awaited respite, would bring joy to the weary caravan of soldiers.

But the mood is somber. Their journey, and all their struggle along with it, was in vain.

As Mydei sits atop the back of his dromas, he's not sure what to focus on. The weight of failure sits heavy and uncomfortably within him, but ignoring it brings another issue to the forefront of his mind, which is currently manifesting itself as a persistent nausea. The swaying stride of his dromas does not make the latter any better.

He swallows thickly, and decides he'd rather consider his failure.

There will be much to brief Aglaea on when they reach Okhema's gates in the next quint, and he must be prepared. She had high expectations of them, of *him* especially. He is, after all, the Kremnoan prince. If anyone in this world could locate the lost Castrum Kremnos, it would be him.

So far, three months of constant searching offered nothing. Not a single hint, not the smallest of traces, no, nothing but dead ends. It's almost as if his birthplace has vanished off the face of the earth--which it hasn't, certainly not, but the level of elusiveness is not encouraging.

Okhema's Council is already at odds with the Chrysos Heirs, and if they continue this stalemate of inaction for any longer, Aglaea's command over

the city will begin to slip. She's promised much to the people, all promises insofar undelivered. At this point, having failed to find any of the remaining Coreflames, their inaction has become glaring.

"Young lord, what troubles you?"

It appears Krateros has finally decided to break the silence that has settled between them. Mydei hasn't been up to conversation for weeks at this point, and he knows he's been short with his master. Frankly, he expected to be reprimanded for his behavior much sooner.

But Krateros doesn't seem particularly upset, now that Mydei's looking at him. He seems almost worried--a rare expression to see on his face. For all of his master's strengths, he's never been the emotional type. He cared for Mydei in his own unique manner, which involved a lot of intensive training and gifts of weapons.

"I believe it is obvious what troubles me. We failed in our mission."

He thinks it's a suitable enough explanation on its own. Krateros is also upset, he must understand. The only reason he agreed to help lead an expedition sponsored by Lady Aglaea in the first place was for the promise of finding his homeland. Mydei being the other leader also helped, but in the end, his master has always longed for one thing: Castrum Kremnos.

"There is more to it than that, isn't there? You've been out of sorts since before we reached Kios."

Mydei tries, and fails, to come up with some explanation. He isn't out of sorts, he's been completely normal, he wants to insist--but that would be a blatant lie. Krateros is right, despite Mydei's best efforts to conceal what's been happening to him. There is so much to hide, so much to accept, so much pain to prepare himself to feel. And while everything else is still safely concealed within his mind and under his traveling cloak, his dour mood has been impossible to shake.

"... It's nothing that should concern you."

Being dismissive rarely works, but perhaps Krateros will accept it.

"Any trouble of yours is mine as well. Your mother charged me with caring for you, and I shall, even when you refuse my assistance," he replies, tone a bit sharper.

So he won't accept it, Mydei muses, unable to stop a scowl from twisting his features.

"It's not something you can help with, master."

"Nonsense. I'll decide if it's really beyond my reach, but you must inform me first."

Mydei opens his mouth to bite back a reply, but then closes it, contemplating. Now is not the time to tell him; however, he must find some way to get the matter dropped before then. If there's one person in the world more stubborn than himself, it's Krateros, so this will be a difficult task.

He gets two seconds to think before the dromas takes an uneven step due to a rock, and the jostling movement is enough to make Mydei's stomach lurch. His hand flies up to cover his mouth in a desperate attempt to hide his violent, full-bodied gag. Based on the look Krateros gives him, he fails.

"Young lord?"

Mydei wills the nausea away as he takes a deep, shuddering inhale through his nose. For a moment, it seems to abate, but then, his stomach lurches again, more insistent. *Shit,* he's going to be sick. There's no way for him to escape, to do this out of sight like he has been for the past two months.

"Young lord, what's wrong?"

His response is grabbing the nearest receptacle, which happens to be an empty bag of rations, and retching up bile until his throat burns.

How long does it take before the taste of his own acid-tainted saliva stops making him gag? It feels like hours. Krateros is there, saying things to him, rubbing the space between his shoulders, but Mydei can't focus on anything

but his misery. By the end, he's breathless, gasping for air as if he's been drowned.

"... That is what's wrong, master," he finally says, before tossing the ruined bag a distance away behind their caravan. "I'm ill."

"But you do not get ill."

"I *do,* on rare occasions, but they are not typical illnesses. I'll have to go to the Twilight Courtyard. As I said, there is nothing you can do about it--you are not a follower of Aquila."

It's not an outright lie, but is a lie by omission, he supposes. At least Krateros accepts it this time.

"I see why you chose not to inform me. You'd hate to admit weakness and hand more responsibility to me--but I wouldn't have minded, you know. It is not a weakness to be afflicted by an illness, it is simply an inevitable occurrence in life. Do heed my lesson, young lord."

"Yes, master," he mumbles, before falling silent once more. He doesn't have the energy to talk any longer, and thankfully, Krateros doesn't insist on furthering the conversation.

The last quint of their journey is entirely uneventful. He rests his eyes for a while, knowing he'll need the energy for what is to come.

When they finally pass through Okhema's gates, Mydei feels no relief, as his teleslate instantly buzzes. Of course, it's a notification from Aglaea, telling him to come to the Mamoreal Palace as soon so he can debrief her on the results of the expedition.

She must be able to sense his dejection through her threads already, but she wants to hear it from him in person for the formality. *Lovely.* He informs Krateros that he's needed urgently before leaping from the dromas's back in a fluid, easy move. It's off to the palace for him.

He expects to find Aglaea in the reserved baths, but riding the lift up shows them to be entirely empty, save for Castorice, who appears to have dozed off. She startles to wakefulness when he approaches, her hand moving to clear the curtain of hair that fell before her eyes.

"Lord Mydei, you've returned. It's nice to see you again."

"Likewise, Lady Castorice. Lady Aglaea says she wishes to meet with me for a debrief, have you seen her?"

"Ah... I believe she's in the meeting room with a few Council members who also wish to hear the summary of your expedition."

He swears under his breath. "The Council is involving themselves?"

"Unfortunately."

With renewed haste, he makes his way to the meeting room. To say this is *not good* would be an understatement. There are a few ways this could be worse--it could be Elder Caenis herself requesting a meeting, or it could be taking place at the Dawncoud--but the outlook is grim enough as-is.

When he steps into the meeting room, he represses his natural urge to scowl as the Council members turn their gazes to him, as snide and disdainful as ever. He doesn't recognize the three of them, which means they're not important officials. It's easy to draw a conclusion: Elder Caenis isn't *too* engaged in the results of the expedition, and she likely only cares because Aglaea sponsored it, not the reason for it in particular.

In all honesty, he despises these political games. Perhaps that is not the opinion a future king should have, but knowing his duty and wishing to carry it out are two very different things, and his wishes do not align with endless arguments concealed as *orderly debates*.

Stiffly, he bows, and takes his seat at the head of the table. The world doesn't care much for his opinions--he's here, ready to play this game once more. He'll even mind Okheman manners today. Will his efforts go

unappreciated? By the Council members, certainly, but Aglaea might thank him later, and he does assign some value to her opinion.

"Welcome back, Lord Mydeimos. What news do you bring from your expedition?" Aglaea asks, breaking the icy silence with her ever-impassive words.

He takes a deep breath before launching into his explanation. He details their entire expedition, including every place they went and curio they encountered. They went to abandoned city-states with previous ties to Kremnos, stumbled across artifacts and fragmented texts from long before the Black Tide claimed his birthplace, even found a lone Kremnoan soldier who escaped without joining the detachment, instead choosing to wander the Evernight.

But in the end, despite everything, it all boils down to a short sentence: *we found nothing*.

"... I see, that's unfortunate," Aglaea says mildly, once he's finished speaking.

One of the Council members, an older man, huffs. "Would you not describe this expedition as being an unnecessary use of supplies during a period of conflict? That would go against Okheman law."

"We couldn't have known it would be unsuccessful before it was conducted. The Chrysos Heirs have many abilities, but foresight is not among them."

As always, Aglaea is an expert at handling the Council, and the man can only huff once more before quieting.

"If you have no questions regarding the contents of the expedition itself, then I shall dismiss Lord Mydeimos and allow him to recuperate after his difficult journey."

When no protests are made, Mydei graciously accepts Aglaea's offer. She must be able to sense his exhaustion through her threads, or perhaps his

appearance is evident enough. He manages another bow to the Council members before egressing.

It takes the last of his remaining energy to march through the palace with his posture intact; the instant he's reached his chambers, he slumps, all tension leaving his body in an instant. Titans, he can't remember being so tired in all his life. There was much he did not include in his explanation of his trip--none of it was pertinent for them to know. His own personal *issues* were more taxing than any single experience.

When did the trouble first begin, but the morning--or what they knew by their pocket watches would be morning were they not basked in constant darkness--he awoke to find the familiar haze of pre-heat had not yet settled upon him as he had anticipated.

He was never thrilled to welcome his cycle until he reached Okhema a few years back and was finally given the miracle of suppressants to completely quell any of his body's natural urges. So, while his estrus cycle happened to line up with the expedition, a few days shy of being a month into it, all he had to do was take a week's course of suppressants at his cycle's advent to soothe the beast.

If only that advent arrived. Perhaps it was stress, he reasoned, as the constant exertion and somewhat slim rations they had been afforded could certainly mess with his hormone levels, though his estrus had always been like clockwork in the past, even during his days in the detachment, when stress was a near-unbearable constant at all hours. Poor sleep, lack of nutrition, the threat of Eurypon's fury crashing upon them at any moment, terrible grief, and the imbalance of his adolescent hormones had not disturbed that clockwork.

Strange, yes, but no reason for disconcert, not yet. Then an entire two weeks had gone by, there was still no trace of pre-heat, and it dawned on him, as insidious and forceful as a riptide, that mere stress was not the reason. A new reason for its absence was presented to him, one that was not as easy to swallow.

The next day, the nausea began, and afterwards, there was no more denial, only a resigned hunt for confirmation that he found in the derelict city of Kios.

As he's mused on his misfortunes, his body has already gone through the motions of disrobing--pointedly done with his eyes trained upwards, not looking down at what is becoming of his physique. Now, he slides into bed, eyes squeezed shut with determination, mind forcing all of those unpleasant thoughts out to allow him to rest peacefully.

Tomorrow, he'll face it. For now, he craves nothing but the darkness behind his eyelids.

Chapter End Notes

> back on my bullshit. whatever happens next in the amphoreus story quest is going to ruin me so i'm going to pretend like everything's okay here and nothing bad happens to phaidei (ignore the angst tag).
>
> also i made an alt twitter account @cistusv3 to talk about phaidei and provide fic updates since i am notoriously bad at keeping to a schedule. world's slowest writer reporting for duty
>
> *@cistusv3*
>
> idk how long this fic will be i'm putting 6 chapters but out of the two i have written idk if it'll progress that quickly. i can hope.

Chapter 2: papaver

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was another brutal action hour in the Month of Everday, which is to say that Phainon is utterly miserable. He forwent wearing his cloak in the morning, but it hasn't done him much good. Sweat has entirely soaked his back, and he is infinitely glad that Aglaea decided his undershirt would be black when she designed this outfit; already red-faced and panting, he doesn't wish to imagine how much worse he'd look trudging through Okhema if the sweat-stains were visible.

Now that it's parting hour, Phainon can *finally* take a break. And how desperately he needs that break with the weight of his exhaustion now bearing down upon him.

The baths are only a short distance away, he reminds himself, as he walks up the sloping path to the Mamoreal Palace. He's already made it to here from the training grounds, he can manage another few minutes.

He doesn't register who else is in the Heroes' baths, only strips down and lowers himself into the coolest one with an abject sigh of relief. Dear Titans, this is *exactly* what he needed.

The reason for his exhaustion is, as usual, the exercises he just completed. Without Mydei around to spar, he's been forced to do boring, repetitive sets that do nothing to improve his swordplay, only make muscles he didn't realize he had ache terribly.

Would he get overheated sparring with Mydei? Of course, but at least he would be having fun, and getting riled up enough would inevitably lead to a later tangle in the sheets. That made it worth it--to have a purpose for his suffering.

Mydei will be returning tomorrow, or so Aglaea promised, way back when he was first sent off on that long expedition. Phainon penciled the date onto his calendar and has checked it religiously each day in anticipation of his return, as devout as any worshiper.

"Snowy!"

Phainon's broken out of his reprieve when Tribbie and Trianne flutter over to him from Aglaea's side--he didn't notice she was here either, though he's not particularly surprised--Trinnon close behind.

"Decided to enjoy the baths at this late hour? You must've had a long day," Phainon greets with as much vigor as he can muster.

"Honestly, **we** weren't too busy today. **We** wanted to speak with Agy for a bit, but afterwards, Trianne wanted to play, so **we** stayed for a while longer."

"And it was a good idea!" Trianne crows.

"Excellent to hear. It certainly sounds better than what I've been doing," he mutters. "Oh, how bored I've been..."

Tribbie cocks her head. "You're bored? **We** thought you'd be spending time with De."

"He's not yet returned, how could we spend time together?"

"He returned a day ahead of schedule," Aglaea provides, "I met with him last quint to discuss his journey before sending him off to rest."

Phainon barely manages to grab a towel to preserve his dignity in front of the Tribios as he shoots upright. He's never felt as motivated as he does at this moment, drying himself so quickly his skin feels raw and then forcing himself back into his sweat-soaked clothing.

He'll finish his bath later. Right now, he has a *much* greater priority.

He just barely remembers to call out a goodbye as he hurries away, and he catches the high-pitched giggles of the Tribios in response, along with Aglaea saying something he can't quite make out, but sounds like her scolding him for his impatience.

How can he be impatient when he's been so patient already? It's been ages since Phainon walked the path to Mydei's chambers--three months, actually, but ages to him. The path is as familiar as ever, and then there it is, the door to his chambers, unremarkable at first glance due to its similarity to all the other doors in the hallway, but significant because it's *Mydei's.* Phainon knocks thrice, perhaps a bit too forcefully from his excitement, and announces himself.

Yes, he has the spare key, and can let himself in at his leisure, but barging in while Mydei is still recuperating would not be very considerate. So, he waits patiently to be granted permission, long enough to wonder if he may be asleep. An impatient itch goads Phainon to knock once more, though he resists the urge.

And after a pause, his patience is rewarded.

"Come in."

Phainon unlocks and pushes open the door, a beaming smile easily settling on his face as he takes in Mydei's scent. Oh, how he missed it. It's sharp, spiced in a manner reminiscent of myristica, and ineffable in its nature, much like the man himself. Above all, though, it reminds Phainon of home.

He allows himself to bask in it for another moment, to take another inhale--and then the confusion arises, because there's something different.

What about Mydei's scent has changed? Phainon's never had the keenest nose, and he can't tell exactly what it is, all he knows is the presence of something new has inserted itself into the notes, something deeper and richer, almost recognizable, but just out of reach.

He approaches the bedside, hoping that perhaps scenting him directly will provide some more clarity, but looking at Mydei shows that he is not so

open to the affections he would normally accept without explicit permission. His neck, and scent glands by extension, are covered by the thin sheets he's drawn all the way up underneath his chin. He lays on his side, back to the door, face presumably staring at the other, mostly barren wall.

This is not how Mydei rests. He may have been asleep earlier, considering how the night-curtains are drawn, but he hasn't been for a while. There's an alertness in his body, an almost unbearable tension strung up in the air around him, that would suggest he's on guard.

"What's the matter?" he asks carefully, maintaining some distance between the bed.

"... Our mission was unsuccessful. We couldn't locate any trace of Castrum Kremnos."

Phainon sits on the edge of the mattress, taking his willingness to answer as an invitation. "It's eluded everyone, don't be too hard on yourself. If we all keep working at it, we'll stumble onto it eventually, I'm certain."

He reaches out to pat Mydei's covered shoulder as a gentle reassurance, but he flinches so violently the moment Phainon's fingertips brush against it that he immediately draws his hand away while his vocal chords, without his input, produce a terribly pathetic whine. He can't help himself--this is too strange, and some alpha part of him reacted on its own instinct-driven accord.

Are they mates? No, but that never mattered in the past. Mydei would prefer to call them lovers--that's probably the best word for it. They're not bonded by anything formal or biological, but Phainon still thinks of him as his mate. Lovers, after all, feels too vague to him, and much too fancy. He called him his boyfriend once, which made Mydei wrinkle his nose in distaste and remark that the term is too juvenile. So, mate will do.

And to some deep-rooted, instinct driven part of his brain, this is as real as a mate's rejection. The sinking feeling in his gut, the tightness in his chest, the chill prickling across his skin--it's an amalgam of shock and embarrassment that has him debating if he should rip open the night-curtains so he can fling

himself out of the window. He has to make this right, he can't bear to watch Mydei suffer.

"There's more to it than that, isn't there? Did something bad happen? Please, you know you can tell me anything," he tries again, but to no avail.

"Nothing bad happened besides the obvious," Mydei insists. "I failed, and that is all. It's unimportant."

"But it clearly *is* important."

"Stop asking."

There's a dangerous edge to his tone that makes Phainon's skin crawl. Pushing further seems like a bad idea.

Mydei's here in front of him after so many months, and yet he's still untouchable. It's too much, Phainon needs to make him crack, needs that vulnerable part of Mydei to bear itself to him.

"Mydei, please--"

"Just leave me alone!"

Phainon only begins to process the words shouted at him until his feet have carried him out of the room. They ring in his ears and slam around the inside of his skull, as confounding as they are painful. He finds himself sitting on the nearest bench, head cradled in his shaking hands, eyes burning with tears threatening to fall.

He doesn't understand. After so many weeks apart, he thought their reunion would be joyous. He expected Mydei to smile with one of his hard-earned grins, to welcome him into bed alongside him to rest together once more. He didn't ever expect to be kicked out like an unwanted stray--because why would he?

Mydei's never acted like that before, *never,* not even when they first met. And over the years, Phainon's become a close confidant. When Mydei's troubled, he'll tell him without hesitation. They trust each other. They're

comrades in arms and lovers in private. In body and mind, secrets come undone, revealed by lips and hands.

If Mydei won't tell him what's wrong, then it can mean only one thing.

Mydei doesn't trust him anymore.

And that revelation hurts worse than death itself.

The rest of the quint passes with him in a daze, wandering around Okhema like a spirit on its way to the Netherworld. He doesn't know what to do with himself anymore. The tightness in his chest does not fade, and he can't breathe properly, no matter how hard he tries to force it. He feels as if some crucial part of his machinery was ripped out; without it, he's a husk of himself.

Somehow, he makes it to a tavern. Other patrons are starting to file in as action hour comes to an end, but there's still an open seat at the bar. He collapses onto it and orders to his heart's content.

Phainon doesn't drink, not in any regular frequency. He'll have a glass of wine when the situation calls for it, but beyond that, he has no interest in the intoxication of alcohol. It dulls his senses and makes him vulnerable in more ways than one.

But right now, he *needs* it. Each shot of whiskey and cup of mead soften the edges of reality, distancing himself from the pain of his mistakes in the most efficient manner.

He still doesn't understand what those mistakes may be, but it's certainly his fault. Why else would Mydei reject him so plainly?

Godsdamnit, he doesn't want to think about Mydei, but now it's all he can think about. He's started crying, a thoughtless stream of tears staining his cheeks and landing upon the bar, joining the droplets of condensation from his half-empty water cup. The bartender gave it to him, said something about being worried about him, but he hasn't finished it.

Drinking was a terrible idea, why did he think it would make this better? It's only made his mind too sluggish to work through the battering waves of emotion, allowing them to overwhelm him entirely. Perhaps he hasn't gone far enough--if he drinks himself into unconsciousness, then it won't be his problem anymore, not until the morn. He raises his hand to flag down the bartender, when--

"By Zagreus's balls, what the hell is wrong with you?"

Suddenly, the seat next to Phainon is occupied by perhaps the last person he wants to see right now: Cipher.

Is the universe just toying with him?

"Leave me 'lone, I don't... *ugh*... need your mockery," he moans, weakly attempting to push her away but completely missing. His palm slaps against the bar counter and Cipher, unimpressed, stares back at him.

"I'm not gonna mock you when you're like *this.* Kick a man when he's down and all that. Did your boytoy break up with you or something, why do you look like a lost widower?"

"He's--he's not my 'boytoy'... don't call 'im that."

She gives an exaggerated eye roll, but relents. "Fine. Did your *boyfriend* break up with you?"

"Maybe? I dunno... dunno what happened. He came back from his expedition today, and-and he... He just wouldn't talk to me, he... pushed me away, I don't... Didn't even..."

"You're not making sense right now, Titans above. Your liver's barely hanging on. Hey bartender, get me a cuppa Georios's tonic, and make it quick!"

"No, nono... I don't want-t that," he slurs, but is powerless to stop as Cipher forces his mouth open and pours the foul liquid down his throat. The awful

taste does bring him back to himself, coughing and spluttering as it carves a searing path down his throat.

He's not sure what sort of remedy the Grove formulated to dispel intoxication so quickly, but they need either an award or to be punched.

"There we go, now start from the beginning, tell me what's up."

Venting to Cipher seems like the worst idea possible--who knows what sort of ammunition that would give her--but since she's been so attentive, he decides to tell her a very brief summary. It's not as if there's much to say in the first place.

"Hmm... Yeah, that's a puzzler," is Cipher's intelligent reply. He resists the urge to smack her.

"Is that all you've got? Seriously?"

"Woah, why's Okhema's Deliverer yelling at me? I didn't do shit, I'm just a pretty kitty giving some advice--"

"You didn't give any advice! You just shrugged!"

"Okay, maybe I didn't, but you gotta cut me some slack. Whatever you and Mydei have going on is weird."

"You're one to talk, you and Aglaea always--"

"That's not the topic of the conversation!" she sing-songs. "C'mon, tell me more about your boytoy. What's he like, what sorts of valuables does he have, how much gold is in that necklace he wears--that kinda stuff."

He sighs heavily and pinches the bridge of his nose. If there's one thing Cipher's good at, it's making one so annoyed that they forget all their other troubles.

"I'm not telling you that... Just give me *some* sort of helpful advice, please?"

He already knows he's erred by begging her. The shit-eating grin she gives him is indication enough that he'll never live this down.

"I dunno, I wouldn't place all the blame on yourself, I don't think you made a mistake. He was cagey the moment he returned, yeah? So, you couldn't've done anything."

"But what could have happened on such a perilous expedition? He spent all of his time fighting and investigating, as far as I'm aware."

"Maybe he cheated on you and feels guilty? Look man, I gotta head out, you can puzzle over this yourself."

Cipher's gone in a quantum flash, leaving nothing but a coupon on the bar stool for some sort of event--there's a picture of a shirtless man with oil dripping off his chest, which is enough to prompt him to rip the thing in half. What use did she think he'd get out of *that?* It's certainly not a consolation after what she said.

She's lucky she left so quickly; if she lingered after suggesting that Mydei, of all people, cheated on him, he would've actually throttled her. Mydei would *never.* Such an egregious breach of trust goes against his very essence.

So, it's impossible. Whatever is going on must be more complicated, and if Phainon just tries talking to him again, after he's had more time to rest, it'll go better. There's no need to blow this out of proportion.

Tomorrow, Phainon resolves, he'll get this all worked out.

Finding Mydei is an escapade that takes almost the entirety of lucid hour, as he doesn't respond to any of Phainon's messages, and isn't in any of his usual haunts. After walking halfway across Okhema, asking random Kremnoans if they've seen their prince, examining the training grounds top to bottom, and even pleading with Aglaea to use her threads--which she refuses to do--he finally stumbles across him looking at one of the artifacts in Theodoros's shop.

Phainon is in such awful shape at that point that he debates just turning around and trying again when he isn't sleep-deprived and sweat-soaked. But after all that effort, he can't bear to give up right when he's managed to succeed, so he works up the courage and marches over, willing himself to act more composed than he feels.

"Mydei!"

He whips around upon hearing his name, instantly on edge. It hurts Phainon to see, but he forges ahead, closing the distance between them until they're mere paces away. Mydei doesn't seem to be in better shape than himself, with sleeplessness haunting his eyes and an almost sickly pallor. He's not dressed in his armor, instead draped in a loose chiton that doesn't appear to fit him. Again, Phainon wonders what's actually the matter, but shelves his curiosity.

"... Deliverer," he greets stiffly, "why are you here? Aren't you busy?"

"Aglaea didn't give me any assignments, so I thought to patrol Okhema for a while. I'm glad to have run into you! I wanted, uh... I wanted to apologize for how I acted yesterday."

"You wanted to apologize? For what do you have to apologize?"

"Well, you'd just returned from a grueling journey, and I barged in asking you all those questions. I should've waited until you were feeling better, but I was impatient. So, I'm sorry."

"You were simply showing concern, as you are wont to do. Though I feel it's unnecessary, I'll accept your apology, and we'll put this matter behind us."

If Phainon didn't know Mydei as well, he'd be content. The matter's resolved, and all should be well--but something's still wrong. *Deeply* wrong.

"Is it alright if I ask what happened during the expedition to upset you?"

The shift in Mydei's already tense demeanor is instantaneous. Any vulnerability is gone. His jaw clenches and he breaks away from Phainon's gaze, eyes darting around as if searching for an escape route.

"... It wasn't anything important, just an issue with my master. It will be resolved soon enough. Frankly, it's none of your business. It doesn't involve you."

Mydei's never been a good liar--he never bothers with it. So, Phainon knows every word of his excuse is nothing but a poorly-constructed attempt at deception. But he doesn't comment on it. There's no need, not when they're both aware.

What matters to Phainon is the delivery.

Though he's speaking quietly, he's using the same forceful tone as yesterday--and now that Phainon can see his expression, it's obvious that it's not anger, but *fear* driving his response.

Mydei is *afraid* of him.

And perhaps Phainon stares at him in silence for a moment too long, because Mydei jolts, taking a large step back as one of his hands flies up to grasp almost desperately at the side of his neck.

"What?"

"Nothing, I just..." he trails off, at a complete loss. His words, the most useful tool in his arsenal, fail him, and he's left to scramble for footing when the floor's been pulled out beneath him.

How could Mydei be afraid of him? Mydei isn't afraid of anything, not war or blood or death--or *anything.* But Phainon knows how to read people better than he knows himself. He knows what fear looks like.

And it doesn't make any sense.

"... Why are you scared?"

The question slips out before he can bite his tongue, because as much as he wants to bury this mess so he doesn't have to deal with the discomfort of trying, letting it fester will only make it worse, and the consequences would certainly destroy him.

He needs Mydei, doesn't know what his life would be reduced to if Mydei wasn't in it. If he had to beg for forgiveness at his feet, prostrate himself in front of the entire city, bear the slings and arrows of scorn for even a chance, then he'd do it in a heartbeat.

But he doesn't get a chance. Mydei takes another step back, and Phainon knows it's all slipping through his grasp. It's more than the physical distance--it's the chasm yawning between their hearts.

"You're being ridiculous, I'm not *scared.* Perhaps you should go to the Twilight Courtyard to check if you have any screws loose. And I myself have business elsewhere, so I'll be off."

Even when Mydei has long since vanished from his sight, Phainon stands frozen in place, eyes trained at the horizon, a part of him hoping that maybe he'll come back, will admit to all his troubles so that Phainon can put it all back together, will let him give him the kindness he's missed for the last three months.

Gods, he still doesn't understand--understands even less than yesterday. The only certainty is that he keeps making things worse with each word he says.

Maybe this is all he's ever been good at, ruining things. He's haunted by something unknowable, some specter that rips and tears and bleeds people dry, that burns villages to ash and ash to dust, that brings life to wither into ruin, and even the person he thought would weather the storm of himself is drifting away.

And he can't bear the thought. He needs it to go away--if it lingers any longer, it may just burst from his skull into reality. He has to run from it, hide where it can't reach him, and then he won't lose him, everything will be okay and it *has* to be because he can't take the pain anymore and--

He finds himself sitting on a secluded bench in a public garden when his mind manages to process his surroundings again. He doesn't remember a second of his walk here, though it's a nice spot to have a crisis; a fountain bubbles away happily to his left and the leaf cover blocks out the worst of Kephale's light.

Breathing is difficult. Seeing is difficult. But he forces himself to exist again, piece by piece, until the world doesn't feel like it's closing in on him.

It's progress, though not much. His legs feel like lead and any attempt at standing would likely fail. How long will he be stuck here until his body starts functioning again? Perhaps the rest of the day, perhaps an eon--

"Mama?"

Something, *someone*, is tugging on his pant leg. He glances down to find a young girl, no older than four, looking up at him expectantly. She's dressed in the Kremnoan style: simple and functional, with robes cut at the knee to not impede running. Her auburn hair is neatly braided in the back, with a golden hair clip keeping some fly-aways from drifting in front of her dark brown eyes. The hand not gripping his pants is clutching a plush lamb to her chest. "Oh. You're not my mama," she says quietly, before he can respond.

No matter how terrible Phainon might feel, he's not going to ignore a child who's obviously gotten lost. He takes a deep, painful inhale, blinks his stray tears back, and gives the girl a bright smile.

"I don't think I am, young miss. Do I look like your mama?" he asks, mouth feeling like he's been chewing chalk.

She gives him a thorough appraisal before shaking her head. "No... But your shoes are the same color."

"Ah, I see how that might've been confusing. But fret not, I'll help you find your mama."

With a new mission to tackle, he bullies his legs to cooperate and gets up with a huff. He offers a hand to the girl, not really expecting her to take it, but to his surprise, she's quick to latch on.

"Alright, where should we start... Were you in these gardens with your mama, or somewhere else? Do you remember when you last saw her?"

"I was in the garden wit' mama... She was sitting on the bench like you 'cause her feet hurt real bad, and I was sitting wit' her, but then I saw a purple butterfly and... umm... I chased it even d'oe she told me not to run away from her... She's gonna be mad..."

"I think she'll just be happy to see you! Maybe she'll scold you, but only because she's worried, not because she's mad."

That seems to placate the girl, and she doesn't voice any more concerns as they make their way through the garden in the direction she came from. It's not a particularly large garden by any means, though it must feel like a vast forest to her. He makes sure to walk slowly, letting her take in the surroundings at her leisure.

It's more peaceful than any other time he's returned a lost child, considering how often refugee caravans approaching the city get attacked and separated. Though a harrowing mission is rewarding in its own right, he appreciates the downtime. He's not in the right headspace for anything more intense than a brisk walk.

When the girl eventually slips her hand from his grasp, he nearly has a heart attack, but turning in her direction reveals that she's running towards a woman sitting on a bench, one who bears a striking resemblance to her. She's wearing similar clothing, though altered to accommodate for her obvious pregnancy, and all her features match up; additionally, the relieved smile on her face when she catches sight of the girl acts as confirmation enough.

"Iris, there you are! I was about to call mommy to help look for you," she says, while reaching out to ruffle her hair. "And look at who you stumbled

across on your adventure. Greetings, Lord Phainon. I can only assume you found her?"

"She found *me,* honestly, but yes, I supported her on the last leg of her adventure."

She huffs out a laugh. "Of course. I hope it wasn't too much trouble for you. I'd have gone looking myself, but... Well, you can see the state I'm in. I believed I could handle a short trip to the gardens, but I've overestimated my current abilities again. My life as a warrior is behind me, yet I can't seem to shake it."

"I'm always happy to help, don't fret! And for a member of the Kremnoan detachment, doubly so. Whatever goodwill I can extend to your people is well worth my while, Lady...?"

"Otonia. Let us drop the honorifics, just call me Otonia. After all, you're good friends with our prince, aren't you? That makes us comrades."

Phainon valiantly ignores the pang in his heart as he responds; if ever there was a time, it isn't now. "Good friends, rivals... Both are apt descriptors. He's a very honorable man in every sense."

"... Prince Mydei gives me candies sometimes," the girl--Iris must be her name--adds quietly, "and he found Sheepie when I dropped her in the market. He's nice."

Dear Titans, if this keeps up, Phainon's heart is going to give out, though from sadness or longing or affection, he's not sure. All three, probably. He's not sure how he's able to love one person so ferociously.

"Indeed he is. I've always worried about the Kremnoan children, even before I had my own, but as long as I've been a part of the detachment, I've seen him keep watch over them. Compared to old Eurypon..." Otonia waves her hand dismissively. "Well, I don't think they're comparable at all, that's the sort of difference between those two. But that's enough about our prince--you must already know this yourself. I'll let you get back to your duties."

"Though I'd love to chat, I should be getting back to the Mamoreal Palace, you're right. I'm honored to have helped you, Otonia. Farewell, I do hope we meet again!"

He musters up his most convincing smile for the pair--the moment he's turned around, it cracks.

Godsdamnit.

Everything hurts and he's so, so tired. These last few days have been an endless gauntlet of torment that he's not meant to endure. He can't keep running--the memory of Mydei is inescapable.

What is he supposed to do with himself now?

He just barely manages to return to the bench, knees buckling the moment it's underneath him. His body slumps. A wheezing breath sighs from his lungs. A shaking hand rises to catch his head.

He's such a mess. He can't even think straight anymore; Otonia’s words loop insistently, echoing, drilling into his psyche. They only made small-talk, it shouldn't be so significant, but a strange sort of heaviness blankets his mind, like a fractured memory is trying, yet failing, to claw to the surface.

He can't shake the feeling that he's missing something.

Chapter End Notes

> first time writing phainon pov... what an experience. this guy is such a weirdo why do i love him so much. can't dress himself, broke loser, won't shut up about mydei for even 0.001 seconds, flattest ass in amphoreus, doesn't know shit. i'll pull for him even if his kit is dogwater. he could buff the enemies for all i care.
>
> anyway 3.3 is imminent and i live in fear. who knows when you'll next see me. i could be in mourning after the update. and i mean that

genuinely. the attachment i have to mydei... i dont think it's normal anymore.

Chapter 3: hollyhock

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Two weeks.

Two long weeks have passed since he returned, and Mydei isn't sure if he can take another minute of it.

The latest target of his frustrations--an already-brutalized training dummy--is punched so hard that its head goes flying across the training grounds. A guard practicing footwork has to duck out of its way. Mydei would typically offer some apology for interfering with another person's training, but the thought of trying to talk is currently unbearable.

He's mad. About what, exactly, he's not sure. It's probably hormonal, but he's not going to go to the library to read up on his current condition. He's already experienced his condition enough for the day considering he spent a quint hunched over in his washroom vomiting.

The next dummy explodes when he uppercuts it, its straw innards spilling onto the sand. He gives it another punch for good measure, and hardened shards of blood spike from the site of impact, shredding what remains of its body into tattered ribbons.

It's somewhat satisfying, though it fails to scratch that itch in his mind that begs for a real opponent. He'd like to find a sparring partner, but he's not in control of himself. Losing himself in battle is too easy when he's in a bad mood. Battle is how he calms himself, as once his body is exhausted, his mind lets go of the day's troubles, though the more troubles have piled up, the more intensely he must fight to banish them.

Who could manage to keep up with his myriad frustrations today? Phainon. No matter what Mydei throws at him, he'll always raise his blade to parry, and then riposte. Who else would dare to lower their guard against the great

Prince Mydeimos? Who else would have the strength to not just block the most devastating of blows, but to fearlessly return them, with a smile no less?

It's addictive. It's always been the nectar that tempts Mydei back to him, chasing that high again and again. Phainon is more than his equal--he's valiantly fought his way right into Mydei's heart and made a home for himself. They are one. The movements of their bodies in the heat of battle are extensions of the other, complimenting without flaw, ascending them to some peak that can only be felt, never named. There is no greater honor, and no greater intimacy.

Godsdamnit.

With a growl, Mydei kicks a hole through another dummy's chest. This is ridiculous. He already thought about Phainon plenty last night when he brought himself to climax twice with just his imagination, only stopping because he fell asleep. The twinge in his gut at the memory tells him that he'll probably be repeating the process soon enough.

Mydei is torn between desperately craving Phainon's presence and cursing his very existence. That idiot somehow managed to do what he thought was impossible.

How could he sire a child with him on accident, outside of a heat or rut, while they were unmated and both taking suppressants? How astronomically low is that chance? And now, Mydei's the one reaping the consequences, as sick as a dog and caught in a war with his own conscience.

Ridiculous.

He has the distinct feeling that he's losing his mind, which he tries to ignore by eviscerating another row of dummies. It doesn't bring him any clarity. Each strike only allows the clouded mess of emotions brewing inside of him to fester.

Training isn't going to get him anywhere, he finally decides. He's not sure what to do instead, but if he stays here any longer, he'll destroy all of the training dummies, and there won't be anything left to entertain him. So, after drying his face of sweat, he sets off to wander the city.

It's rare that he has such an abundance of free time to waste on an aimless walk. It does calm him down, he supposes, to spectate Okhema's beauty. Of all the places he could've settled down, this is probably the nicest; the citizens may not be fond of him and his people, but the cityscape is easy on the eyes with such verdant greenery, the food is palatable, and the training grounds are above satisfactory. Mydei's simple wants are easily met.

But no matter how breathtaking the city may be, it's boring to stroll around by oneself. He can only stare at flowerbeds for so long before he becomes restless from inaction. His only current desire is to fight something, fight *someone,* and he knows that isn't going to happen.

The main issue is that Aglaea still isn't sending him out on missions. She must assume he wants a few more weeks to readjust to his normal life after such a grueling expedition, but he, at least, doesn't think it was particularly grueling. He's endured *much* worse, after all.

However, it may be for the best; if he's to go out on missions, he'll likely be paired with Phainon, and that sounds unpleasant, to say the least. It would be terribly awkward. Neither of them would be able to focus. Their performance would be subpar. Aglaea would ask questions, and Mydei wouldn't be able to answer to her satisfaction.

Is all of that hassle worse than boredom? Right now, it seems to be, but if he reaches his breaking point, he may just cave and do it anyway. It would save him from--

As if on cue, his teleslate buzzes. Another message from Aglaea, informing him that his next meeting is scheduled two quints from now.

It's nearly enough to tip him right over the edge. He's already nauseated, hungry, fatigued, uncomfortably aroused, aching all over from training, and

he's going to be stuck in another godsdamned meeting, the fourth in as many days.

He has time to deal with at least one of those problems. A bath would be heavenly, but he's not sure if it's safe for him to do while pregnant--only the high-temperature baths will help with the knots in his muscles. A meal would also suffice, but his stomach lurches at the suggestion.

In that case, he'll take a nap. It's not ideal in these circumstances, but a rest will do him some good, he supposes.

After marching to his chambers, drawing the night-curtains, doffing his armor, and lying perfectly still in his bed for some undetermined amount of time, he concludes that even a nap is beyond his capabilities. That begs the question of what the hell he's meant to do instead.

He feels a distant shame as he undoes the clasp of the loose, full-body chiton he's taken to wearing. There may not be any other matters for him to attend to until the meeting, but is *this* the best use of his time? His body is truly, embarrassingly insatiable, and he's beholden to pleasuring it if he'd like to maintain his sanity.

"This is your fault, Deliverer," he mutters to himself, before allowing his hand to drift slowly downward, over his tender chest and swollen abdomen, finally reaching the waistband of his briefs. He hesitates for one final moment before giving in, pushing them down his hips enough to allow him unrestrained access. It's far too tempting, he's too excited for it already.

Phainon would delight in how easily he now arouses, he thinks, as his fingers press just above his clit, testing. He gasps at the shock that instantly shoots through his core. He never imagined he could get more sensitive, but pregnancy has brought a new fire to his nerves. Every touch stokes something deep within him, more primal than even the wanton nature of lust.

Like this, he thinks could bring himself to orgasm in a minute, though that would do nothing to satisfy him. He forces himself to go slow, one hand rubbing languid circles against his clit while the other teases apart his folds.

"Fuck," he hisses, as he feels just how much slick has collected at his entrance. It's smeared all the way to the junction of his inner thigh, and he can only guess that the crotch of his briefs is completely soaked through.

He slides two fingers in up to the knuckle with ease. They barely register, nowhere near the sort of fullness Phainon's cock would bring. His fingers are long, but not long enough, and certainly not as wide. Adding another only makes it awkward. There's none of the satisfaction he needs to sate his desire, just the sense that he's missing something.

Perhaps he can make it work. He doesn't need Phainon, he's always been able to tend to himself in the past. Rhythmically, he begins to thrust his fingers in and out, cringing a bit at the loud, wet noise it makes. He's only produced this much slick while in heat--*ridiculous.*

Even more ridiculous is the fact that, despite how eager his body is, his touch isn't helping. He rubs against his clit desperately, hips bucking up and legs tensing from the pleasure it brings, yet the peak still feels a thousand miles away. It's not enough, won't be enough, no matter how hard he works away at himself--

He makes a shameful, pathetic whine that he's glad will only grace his ears. Dear Titans, he's frustrated. Why does his body suddenly have such impossible demands for him? It's insistent-- it'll only accept Phainon, the damnable alpha himself, and that's the one thing it can't have. If he were to see Mydei now, his naked body swollen and soft, gently rounded with life, he already knows what would happen.

Perhaps, then, he can just imagine. Imagine a Phainon that feels only adoration, whose face would beam with pure happiness at the sight of his willing mate, who would feel great pride at having bred him well, whose reverent hands would please the parts of him that ache so desperately for his touch.

It's easy, too easy to lose himself in. With his eyes shut tight to ignore the lonely reality before him, his own hands become Phainon's hands at his crotch.

He'd probably be too careful, Mydei thinks, treating him like delicate glass and not a hardened warrior. They'd start slowly, with Phainon straddling him, kissing him, whispering honeyed words of praise. Mydei would push him for more, unable to wait through any sort of foreplay while so riled up. In these circumstances, Phainon would obey--this is *his* fault, after all. He'd reach down to stimulate him only to find him already slicked and ready, and he'd tease him for his eagerness before finally pushing in to his aching cunt--

Mydei's body seizes as he comes suddenly, a ragged moan torn from his lips. He draws out his orgasm as long as he can manage, rutting against his fingers until he's trembling from overstimulation and he has to pull away, gasping for air.

That was... *quick*. He hadn't even gotten anywhere in the fantasy and he'd fallen apart. He'd be embarrassed if he weren't so relieved to have managed it.

He wonders if he'll have to go for another round or two, but he feels exhaustion blanketing him as he comes down from his high. That was enough to completely tire him out, it seems, to the point that even getting up to wash himself off is too arduous of a task. His legs are leaden and the persistent ache in his back has worsened.

There will be time for a rinse before he's meant to go to the meeting, he thinks, before his eyes slide shut and he's lost to sleep.

The meeting is just as unpleasant as he anticipated.

Even if he were in a good mood, this would be pushing it, and unfortunately, he's not any happier than he was earlier, even after managing to sleep for a quint. The sunlight is too bright. Everybody's clamorous scents are making his head ache. Aglaea's speaking too loudly. He has to restrain himself from throwing his goblet at Anaxagoras's head every time he interjects to argue.

For all of her talk on letting him recuperate after his mission, Aglaea has insisted he attend every single one of these meetings, which consist of little more than informing people of their failure.

This time, it's with the members of the Grove. He's not surprised they want to be informed--it is the Grove, after all. He's been over there enough to get a sense of the unimaginable amount of knowledge they've accumulated, and how much more they continue to pursue. Frankly, he doesn't mind them, though he himself isn't the academic sort. Of all the factions he's met with, they're probably the most pleasant, possessing some sense of decorum and not glaring daggers at him like the Council.

But this meeting is the worst one yet, because *Phainon* is here.

This shouldn't come as a shock; as hard as Mydei may try, there's no way to completely avoid him. Phainon hasn't been at the other meetings, but this one is somewhat important, so of course his attendance was mandatory, and of course Aglaea decided the two of them would sit right across from each other, because neither of them have suffered enough, apparently.

Mydei knows what he's been doing to Phainon. All of the others have remarked on how terrible he looks, how quiet he's been, how many days he's spent locked in his room--how he isn't himself anymore. But Mydei hadn't seen it for himself until this moment.

It's for the best, he reminds himself desperately, as he takes in those sad, sleepless eyes. Phainon has always tested his resolve, but he *cannot* break now.

What a pointless exercise. The truth is unrelenting, uncaring of his denial and avoidance. The days of their relationship are numbered; Mydei cannot hide his pregnancy forever, no matter how determined he may be. He'll have to figure out what to do before that point, and he *can't.* It just won't work, he knows he can't have Phainon and the child both, but he wants to believe that there's *some* way to manage it, that some perfect solution will fall right into his lap if he just stalls for time.

Life is unfair. This was his very first lesson, taught to him through the burn of salt water in his infant lungs, the wordless begging for his mother with pure, instinctive feeling in a mind that had never learned any language beyond terror, the weak strikes at shapeless beasts that would drag him under each time he fought to surface--how could he ever forget?

But his wanting for a family of his own shouldn't be beyond reach. It's a simple wish, so simple that when he first expressed it to Krateros many years ago, his master scoffed, and said that he'd certainly have it once he reclaimed his crown. It almost goes without saying.

So, why must it be impossible? He doesn't wish to dwell on Phainon's rejection, which still stings as fresh as it did when he first heard it, though at this point, he can't banish it from his mind, not when the man himself is meters away, sulking, acting like this isn't his fault as well.

Gods, he feels sick.

"Lord Mydei, could you tell us again what you saw in Tretos? A great core of--"

"I must excuse myself, Professor Anaxagoras."

It's a miracle he makes it to the washroom sink before he vomits. There's not much to lose, he hasn't eaten all day, but his body insists on choking up the water in his stomach.

This, by far, is the worst symptom of pregnancy. Nothing brings him such abject misery as watching himself steadily wither away as each day without proper nourishment passes by.

And it only gets worse when somebody enters the washroom while he's still hovering over the sink, gripping the basin so tightly he's left gouges in the stone with his gauntlets. He must fetch the Tribios to rewind it or find some way to pay for the repairs; however, he must field some questions first.

"I'm sorry for following, but the others insisted I check on you," Hyacine says gently, once he's stopped retching. "Are you alright, Lord Mydei?"

He debates what to say while he rinses his mouth out. An answer of 'nothing' would be quite foolish, considering who's asking him. Hyacine is a doctor, a brilliant doctor at that. He's not surprised she was sent to help.

If he's being honest with himself, she might just be the best person to tell. She'll probably be able to help with these troublesome symptoms, and he knows anything he tells her will not pass through her lips, no matter who asks.

Now that he's being offered the opportunity on a silver platter, he supposes he should take it.

"... How long is 'morning sickness' supposed to last?"

It only takes her a second to piece things together. Momentary shock ghosts across her features, quickly overtaken by her usual composure.

"In what sense?"

"I'm in the second trimester, which is when it is meant to abate. It has not."

She hums in thought. "Well... It varies by person, though if you've used suppressants for an extended period of time, it can be worse. The nausea is caused by elevated hormone levels typical in early pregnancy, but an imbalance *can* result if hormone level has been low for many months. I would guess this is such a case."

He's not pleased to hear that, but it's an explanation. He sighs, then draws back from the sink. For now, at least, his stomach has settled.

"Is there any way to suppress the nausea?"

"Certainly! I normally wouldn't be able to prepare a prescription for you so quickly, but considering the severity of your morning sickness... It troubles me. Excuse me for my bluntness, but you look rather gaunt. I can only guess you've not been eating properly for many weeks now."

"You're correct--but don't trouble yourself for my sake. I can endure for longer."

It's more of a lie than he'd care to admit, but the promise of a cure should tide him over for at least a few days. Hyacine doesn't accept it regardless.

"It's a simple medicine to make, it's really not any trouble, especially when you're suffering so greatly. I know how much you value your physical health. By the end of the day, I'll have it ready for you, and I'll personally drop by your chambers to deliver it!"

"Thank you, Lady Hyacine," he says quietly, "and do let the others in the meeting know I won't be returning. I need to lie down for a while."

"I will. Rest well, Lord Mydei."

Feeling the confrontation has concluded, he makes for the door, but she clears her throat as he brushes past her, stopping him.

Her voice is scarcely a whisper, words a secret meant for his ears alone. "If you want any other assistance from me, just send me a message. Certain *procedures* are outlawed in this city, but that will not stop me from caring for my patients. The Council should not have control over your body."

"... I will keep your offer in mind."

He does consider it--he's been considering such an option since he first suspected his pregnancy. Unlike the close-minded elders of Okhema, his own people have never seen the termination of pregnancy as something taboo. If he, their crown prince, were to deny them the continuation of their legacy, he knows they would not care. If Mydei were to have told Krateros back on their expedition, even he, with all his expectations, would've made him an abortifacient himself.

But that's not the outcome he wants.

As Mydei retreats to his chambers, he cannot stop a hand from resting upon the swell of his abdomen.

The circumstances may be far from ideal, but he will not be deterred. This is *his* child, and he will protect them as long as he is able. He will birth

them, raise them, and guide them in a kinder world, one much gentler than the horror he's known.

His only regret is that he must do this without his mate by his side. He always imagined himself celebrating each moment of pregnancy with another, sharing in the joy a child brings. To bear life is a great honor, and the ability is a strength like no other. Such an undertaking is not to be done alone, or with uncertainty--it should be done freely, with purpose, and above all, with happiness.

Oh, how he wants to be happy.

What a pathetic wish that is, one of a sad child more than a warrior. But a part of him has never grown up, left eternally as a fledgling life thrashing within a sea of death. He can't fault that boy for his wants--he deserves far more than what he got.

It's a shame that Mydei can't grant wishes. No matter how hard he fights, there are many things that are out of his reach.

What a sorry state of affairs.

The moment he's laid upon his bed, he curls on his side, once again allowing his imagination to wander, to dream that Phainon is beside him, draped over him in that endearing way he does, like he wishes to fuse their bodies together. His face would be buried in the scent glands on his neck, arms wrapped around him to cradle him and the child both, legs thoughtlessly intertwined, skin pressed against skin.

He plans to allow himself but a moment of weakness, and yet now that he's at rest, the memory prods at his conscience once more, demanding his attention. More than a year has passed, and yet, it is as clear as glass, preserved in full despite how little he wishes to remember.

And without his nausea to distract him, he has no choice but to recollect.

Up until action hour, it had been a perfectly fine day, pleasant but not notable by any means. He'd had a simple breakfast, trained with Phainon,

soaked in the baths, then gone out for a stroll in the market. They'd just finished up a difficult mission a few days prior, which meant Aglaea had granted them a rather indulgent week of rest. Mydei, of course, was already getting bored with no assignments, so Phainon had been spending his days dragging him around to entertain them both. That particular day, he wished to look at a pottery stall with some alleged quality goods.

Mydei knew nothing of artifact appraisal, and he had no way to verify if they were authentic. Phainon seemed to think they were, but after staring at the same amphora for twenty minutes, he'd given up, and said he wanted to ask his mentor for advice. So, they'd gone to Theodoros's shop, only to find it closed for the day.

"Huh... He's on a trip to the Grove, I forgot he told me that last week... whoops. Guess I'll just have to buy the amphora and hope it's real."

Mydei had scoffed. *"This is why you never have any funds, you're always so quick to spend them, on suspect goods no less. Curb your impulse and hold off on the purchase."*

"And this is why your chambers are so barren--you never buy any decorations," Phainon shot back.

"They're not not barren, they're organized. Your chambers are so cluttered I need a map to navigate them."

"It's not that bad and you know it. They're charming. Cute. Pleasing to the eye. A work of art, even."

"Lady Aglaea would have a conniption if she saw what you--"

Before their argument could progress any further, Phainon was nearly bowled over when somebody ran into him. It was a young Kremnoan boy--Mydei instantly recognized him by his distinctive red hair.

"Crap--oh my gods, Prince Mydei, Lord Phainon! I'm so sorry!" the boy, Sostias, had said, instantly falling into a bow. He was ten at the time, and rather short for his age, but very determined to become a warrior regardless.

His fathers were both accomplished fighters in the detachment and former members of the Godshield brigade, so his ambitions weren't surprising.

"There's no need for such formality," Mydei had insisted. *"Regardless, do be more careful where you're going, and don't roughhouse in the market. You could fell a weaker warrior with a single blow if you don't mind your own strength."*

"Yes, Pri--... uh, Mydei! I'll be super careful next time, I promise. Hey, Cory, get over here, he's not mad!"

From the shadows, Sostias's friend slunk out, looking a bit frightened. *"I'm very sorry..."*

"Do not cower, young Corydon. Both of you have great strength, there is no shame in that--but there is a time and place to show it. The best warriors know when to sheath their blades. Now, if you wish to spar with each other, do it at the training grounds in the Kremnoan district. If they refuse you entry due to your age, tell them Mydeimos said you may enter. Just remember to be careful, stay away from other trainees, and use the wooden practice weapons."

The boys both nodded enthusiastically, and then scurried off, presumably to the training grounds. Phainon had chuckled, though he didn't say anything on the matter until they'd begun walking back toward the Mamoreal Palace.

"You really like kids, don't you? You always make time to talk with them, and you're actually nice, too."

"I have responsibility over the Kremnoan children, of course I'm attentive. I would be a horrid prince if I wasn't. I must greet each new arrival, grant them Kremnoan citizenship, ensure they're raised to be honorable members of society with all the necessary resources at their disposal--these are my duties. Though we may never return to Castrum Kremnos, our culture will be preserved, I will ensure it."

"That's noble of you... But it doesn't answer my question. I mean, you'll play with the Okheman children too."

"I do on occasion, only because I'm roped into their games."

"Really?" Phainon pressed, one eyebrow quirked, clearly not believing his denial.

Mydei had finally acquiesced--there wasn't much point in pretending anyway. *"I am rather fond of children, I suppose you're correct. Raising them properly is an undertaking that is duly rewarded. I've always wanted some of my own, I'd like to have that experience myself."*

It was an easy admission for Mydei to make--not insignificant, but not unnatural, either.

"... Some of your own? With... with me?"

"Of course. You are my equal, and the only mate I will take. I've always envisioned this as our future--"

"But it isn't," Phainon suddenly interjected, almost breathless. Mydei glanced over to him and felt something in him lurch.

The face he was making was familiar but so unwelcome. A dreadful sort of fear had seized him, obvious in the hang of his jaw, the paleness of his skin, his blown-out pupils--and the glaze in his eyes, like he was looking a thousand miles away, not at the man right in front of him.

He only looked this frightful when he was having an episode, when the grief of his past became too great to ignore and dissociated him from his body and mind, to the extent that he wouldn't even recognize the other Chrysos Heirs. He'd lie in his bed, chest heaving, whimpers of terror slipping past clenched teeth, body caught in some intangible battle.

It had been years since he'd last suffered one, but Mydei's innocuous comment had brought him back there in an instant.

And for once, he was at a loss for words, for action, for *anything.* All he could do was watch.

"You can't have--... Not with me, please no, you..." Phainon managed to gasp, before fleeing, actually *fleeing* from Mydei's side.

Where Phainon went afterwards was not something Mydei tried to uncover. He instead returned to his own chambers and spent the rest of the day reading over the latest Council decree regarding the detachment, noting down sections that he'd have to negotiate with them later. He'd been putting off the task considering how little he enjoys political dealings, but not wanting to be idle with his thoughts spurred him into doing it.

Phainon did not just *run* from things. When faced with armies of Titankin or Tide-twisted abominations, civilians with horrific injuries he hadn't the skill to mend, Council members shouting at him with all the venom they could muster--Phainon would step up and do what needed to be done. The word 'retreat' did not seem to be in his dictionary, even if it was ill-advised.

But Mydei had scared him off. Scared off the man he'd quietly hoped would always stand by his side, who wouldn't be taken from him like all the others. The last thing he'd wanted to do was think about the damage he'd done to his most cherished partner.

Had he actually ruined their relationship?

To his utmost surprise, Phainon arrived at his door while he was still working, smile looking only a bit awkward, with a peace offering in the form of a fresh plate of golden honeycakes.

"Hi... Sorry about that," was all he said. He'd obviously been crying, but Mydei didn't comment on that, only sighed and let him inside. He was too relieved to see him return, nothing else mattered.

"I'll clear off my table, we'll share the meal."

Phainon's smile brightened at his words. He tentatively launched into a story about something that had happened at the diner as he was getting the food while Mydei packed up the scrolls littering his dining table that was seldom used for dining.

The meal was awkward at first. Mydei prepared himself for a confrontation, and yet, he just couldn't find the words, not when Phainon seemed so eager to put it behind them.

So, they did not speak of the matter again.

Mydei knows he should've followed him that day, should've asked what, exactly, the problem was, should've done anything but pretend as if it never happened while it ate him up inside. But with his rejection of the idea so plain, Mydei decided there was, indeed, nothing left to say.

It's quite clear: Phainon doesn't want children with him.

At the time, he was alright with the prospect. Children didn't, and still don't, have much of a place in their lives, so rife with danger and packed with work. Mydei had long since tucked the dream away in the lockbox of his mind, knowing that it would have to wait until the Era Nova was upon them.

With such odds stacked against the chance of conception, it's a miracle that it happened now--a miracle in his mind, anyway. Phainon might not think the same.

Mydei believes in the strength of Phainon's character, but in this matter, he's not proven himself. He'd much rather flee than confront even the possibility, and offered no chance of discussion regarding it. An unnecessary retreat is a shameful thing to any warrior worth their salt.

Or is it?

Quite suddenly, he thinks he has a viable plan.

Chapter End Notes

> um. so 3.3 was uh. haha. that sure was something. totally normal not at all life ruining world ending. i am holding on by a thread and the thread is my delusional theory about the scepter. fuck amphoreus i need 3.4

in other news, through an extremely long series of unfortunate events in my life i got serotonin syndrome. so yeah the chapter took a lot longer to get out than i wanted. i'm also not sure how good it is considering i felt like i was going to die while i was writing it, i will definitely be editing this again when i feel less like i'm going to die. but i'm kinda fine now?? and it shouldn't happen again. thank you for your patience!

Chapter 4: aspen

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Many, many years ago, before Phainon was Phainon, before his heart knew pain and his body knew strife, he was still not an ordinary boy.

His golden blood, of course, was one thing, and that was of great interest to the town elders, but that was not what endeared him to the other townsfolk. The fact that he was an alpha was far more interesting to them.

Aedes Elysiae did not have many alphas, or omegas for that matter. Nobody knew the reason, and nobody bothered to find it. They were simply a village of betas, no need to waste any time pondering the matter beyond that.

But then, Phainon was born, an alpha in a long line of betas. A surprise, to be certain.

His mother recounted the tale of his birth to him once, how the midwife had gone ghostly white when trying to determine his sex, thinking that he had some sort of physical malady, before she managed to piece things together, and had told his mother, with apologetic relief, that she had a healthy alpha boy, to both of his parents' shock.

The midwife was not the only one unaccustomed to encountering alphas. The town's doctor had only a faint understanding of how to support his secondary sexual health, offering only a book titled *Alpha Physiology* that was so old the back cover had fallen off. It wasn't a riveting read for a teenager who'd just reached the age of his first rut, and he'd awkwardly returned it after it failed to help him in any way.

And the other townsfolk--well, they had all sorts of strange advice for him, none of it impactful. They certainly knew nothing of alphas themselves, so despite their fascination in him, they couldn't offer him much. He

eventually stopped paying attention to what they had to say, and he tried to figure things out for himself, which also didn't get him anywhere.

It was a shame, since his parents didn't know what to do about his ruts either. They tried to find some way to help ease them, but the concoctions of healing herbs they would prepare for him didn't do a thing, as the recipes were mostly archaic nonsense. After a few failed attempts, they decided they'd just give him cold compresses to help with the fever and some painkillers for the aches that would spring up. It was better than nothing, but not good.

Phainon wasn't violent during his ruts--far from it, in fact. He would lay listless in bed, body burning up, mind a slow, sludgy mess for the better part of a week, and then, when his senses cleared up, he'd go right back to his ordinary life. Besides that interruption every three months, Phainon scarcely thought about his secondary gender.

He'd reckon that's why he's never been a *proper* alpha, at least compared to what Okhemans think he should be. Whatever natural instincts he's meant to have are lacking. All of that drivel about how he's meant to view omegas as *conquests* or *prizes* and should covet *power* and *fame* has always seemed foreign to him. He'd reckon that such behavior isn't really natural at all, and it's all due to nurture, not nature.

Well, that was what he thought until today, anyway. It seems some of those urges have decided to rear their ugly heads.

Dear Titans above, he thinks he's losing his mind. The moment he walked into the meeting and saw Mydei, *smelled* Mydei, he wasn't able to focus on anything but him. He's had multiple quints to piece himself back together and it's only getting worse the longer he thinks about it.

What about his scent has changed? He still can't name it, all he can recognize is that it has changed further, becoming even richer, even deeper, even more intoxicating. During that stupid meeting, the urge to clamber over the table and bury his nose in the crook of Mydei's neck was near overwhelming.

And it wasn't just the scent, either. Phainon tried his best to stare at him discretely, and Mydei seemed so much *softer.* Such a descriptor is so foreign to him that it almost feels wrong, but it's the only one that comes to mind. All of the sharpness of his well-toned body was muted, rounded at the edges, gentle where it was once imposing--at least from what he could see. Mydei's not been wearing his rather revealing outfit since his return, he's taken to hiding his wonderful physique under a rotating cast of conservative chitons and even a himation that Phainon wasn't aware he owned.

Does he know the reason for any of this? Certainly not. In the end, all of this contemplation has led him to a single conclusion: he *wants* Mydei.

Now that he's alone once more, that desire has only become more potent. He's spent the better half of curtain-fall hour pacing a hole in his carpet, a low growl thrumming in his chest, jaw clenched tight in agony.

He wants Mydei here, wants to touch him all over, wants to sink his teeth into his waiting flesh, wants to drown in that delectable scent until it's a part of him, wants to--

"Quit being ridiculous," he scolds himself, hoping the sound of his own voice will ground him. It does not. Nothing seems to help this overwhelming restlessness, and his thoughts have only grown more tempestuous.

What he *really* needs is some fresh air, he thinks, though he's not keen on leaving the safe comfort of his chambers. Another minute of pacing later, and he decides he'll risk it. He worries he'll lose his wits if he has to stay here any longer. It's curtain-fall hour anyway, he should be afforded some privacy. Nobody will witness him in the throes of this breakdown.

But after mustering up the courage to step outside, he only makes it a few paces before he's stopped dead in his tracks by a rather unexpected sight. It's Lady Hyacine, a large basket cradled in her arms, walking down the hallway with her back to him.

She may be a Chrysos Heir, and she may come to Okhema for frequent visits, but she doesn't live in the Mamoreal Palace like his peers. As far as he knows, she doesn't have any reason to be milling about here. He thought she would've returned to the Grove already--he's relatively certain that Anaxa did, he's not sure why she wouldn't join him.

Even stranger than all of that is the fact that she stops in front of the doors to Mydei's chambers. Why is a *doctor* seeing Mydei?

His mind races, considering every possibility for why she's visiting him. Is she delivering his next dose of suppressants? Since they both use medication to halt their cycles, Phainon never really paid attention to the schedule of Mydei's heats, though he should be due for one quite soon, if memory serves. But suppressants don't need to be delivered in such a large basket, it's just a little case of pills.

Perhaps she has some other medicine for him? He looked--rather inexplicably--unwell during the meeting, so unwell that Anaxa insisted she check on him when he ran off suddenly and failed to return. But what sort of medicine would Mydei need? Unless the nature of his immortality has suddenly changed, he shouldn't be getting sick. Though, there *was* an instance when he got cursed by an old artifact they stumbled across a few years back--perhaps something similar happened on this mission? It could explain a few things.

And then, the more irrational thoughts flood in, brought upon by some part of his alpha hindbrain that has suddenly become quite overactive.

Does she desire him? Is she courting him? Does she think she has a chance to rival Phainon's affections?

Truly ridiculous things for him to think, and yet, he thinks them anyway. He's not sure why he's suddenly become so territorial. Mydei is free to do what he wishes, far be it from Phainon to try to dictate the life of a man who could end his own in a heartbeat. Of course, letting himself be courted by Hyacine isn't one of the things he'd entertain, and Hyacine herself wouldn't dream of such grossly unprofessional behavior.

But even so, all of that logical thinking can't counter the jealousy snared in his heart or soothe his racing mind.

What's *wrong* with him?

He practically sprints down the hallway before Hyacine can reappear, desperate for escape from her, from Mydei, from *everything.* His legs pump underneath him, thoughtlessly carrying him through the palace until he's finally made it outside, to a mercifully empty balcony.

Kephale's light is a smidge dimmer at this late hour, enough to cast the city before him in a gentler light. The view is always majestic from the palace, as the high vantage point lets one see the tops of the grandest temples and the low, sloping hills packed with quaint homes.

He braces himself against the balcony railing, panting despite the lack of exertion, eyes burning as he stares out at the vast sky. His fingers dig into the marble hard enough to ache. He forces himself to breathe, each shuddering inhale feeling like he's forcing water into his lungs instead of air.

Slowly, his body stills. The commotion within him quiets to a simmer, leaving confusion in its wake.

Nothing about *any* of this makes a lick of sense.

Mydei isn't the avoidant type--far from it, really. When he has issues, he works them out immediately. So, why is he so determinedly avoiding *just* Phainon and nobody else?

At this point, he's fed up with all of it. He's been a mess for weeks; if he doesn't pull it together soon, he can only imagine how cross Aglaea will become as his performance suffers, and how many people might suffer in turn.

How will he fix this?

It seems impossible when everything's already in shambles. Hoping for a solution may be foolish--or perhaps not. All he needs to do is quit wallowing in the shame of his mistakes and look at this with a clear head.

What did he do to Mydei to prompt this in the first place? He doesn't know. He still doesn't think he's done anything wrong. So, he'll do exactly what's worked in the past when he's had questions: ask Mydei directly.

It's been exceedingly difficult to catch him at an opportune moment, but with some determination, Phainon's sure he can get him in the right setting for a conversation. He'll be blunt, in the exact manner that Mydei appreciates, and he'll get his answer. Whatever worries he has will be properly assuaged, Phainon will make sure of it.

By the gods, he swears going to get this all worked out--he's not going to fail again.

Two days later, Phainon marches over to knock on Mydei's door, and receives no response.

He'd hoped that waiting to talk to him would've increased the likelihood that he'd be in a better mood, but his patience is meaningless if he can't even find him. Still determined, he prepares himself for another hunt across the city.

Unfortunately, searching his usual haunts, once again, leads him nowhere, and unlike before, he doesn't stumble across him at the market in a stroke of luck. Lacking any other guesses, he contemplates the matter for a while, and finally decides to go to one of the people who knows Mydei best.

"Lord Krateros, good morning!" Phainon cheerily greets, giving the man a smile he's sure could melt even the coldest of hearts.

Krateros is, as always, completely immune to his charms, and he barely acknowledges his presence, only offering a grunt as he continues to polish his blade. He's definitely not allowed to have a sword unsheathed in the

Mamoreal Palace, but he's never minded the rules in the past, and Phainon certainly isn't going to report him for disorderly conduct.

"Can I ask you a question?" he says, after a beat of awkward silence passes.

"You already did. If you have something to say, boy, then say it."

"I was just wondering if you'd seen Mydei today, or if he told you where he might be at this hour."

Krateros finally bothers to look at Phainon, his stern expression morphing into thinly veiled concern, and gods, is that the last emotion one would ever want to see him express.

"I don't know. He promised to meet with me two days ago to discuss some matters regarding the Kremnoan detachment, but he never showed. I figured he was off gallivanting with you, wasting his time."

Phainon would be offended if the sickly twist of dread brewing within him wasn't so prevalent. As it is, his focus isn't directed at the slight against him.

"He'd never miss a meeting with you."

"Which is exactly the problem," Krateros huffs, "and he's not responding to my messages, either."

"Umm... Well, in that case... I'll try asking around some more. Thank you, regardless."

Krateros's words are troubling, to say the least. Phainon's selfish motivations to find Mydei have suddenly become much less selfish, if the Kremnoan's crown prince really is missing. Avoiding Phainon is one matter, but to avoid his own people--well, that goes from strange to something else entirely.

It's surely fine, just a misunderstanding, he tells himself, trying to keep the panic at bay with middling success. It's all he can do to not sprint to Aglaea and beg her to find Mydei--she won't obey his whims, he's already well aware.

The Tribios, however, might help him, so he hurries over to the Garden of Life, correctly assuming that he'll find them playing with the chimeras at this time. At entry hour, the gardens are sparsely populated, with only the keepers and a few scholars milling about, and the chimeras themselves have yet to start their work.

Tribbie is cooing over a little red one who seems to be new addition to the Garden, Trinnon is quietly stroking a black one resting peacefully on her lap, and Trianne is setting up what looks like a race with a few rambunctious ones, having them line up at the far end of the small courtyard.

It's pleasant. Familiar. The dread in Phainon's heart ebbs as he takes it all in, and he lets out an even, measured breath.

"Snowy!" Tribbie cries, before he has a chance to greet them all himself. She leaves her place by the chimera's side to flutter his way, one of her tiny hands waving enthusiastically.

He can't quite muster the same energy as her today, but still offers a wave in return. "Good morning, Lady Tribbie. I have a few questions for you if you're not too busy?"

"Of course **we** can answer... Oh, Snowy, is something troubling you? You look so sad..."

Though he's not told Tribbie most of his woes regarding Mydei--it feels a bit odd to discuss with her--she's noticed his low mood, and offered him consolation in that gentle manner of hers. Her sisters have given him support too, in their own unique ways. He always appreciates it, but this time, he'll need something a bit more substantial than candies or head pats.

"I am a bit troubled, unfortunately... Hopefully it'll all be resolved soon enough. I was wondering if Mydei's been sent on a mission? I can't seem to find him today, and he's not responding to my messages."

"Hmm... **We** don't think he's on a mission, no. Agy doesn't think he's ready to go on one yet, she wants him to rest more. **We** definitely didn't request

for him to leave the city. There's nothing **we** need in Janusopolis for the moment, and **we** agree that he could use a break. He doesn't seem to be feeling the best."

"So, you don't know where he might be?"

She shakes her head resolutely. "**We**'re sorry, Snowy. There's not much **we** can do... **We** can try sending him a message if you'd like!"

"It's worth a shot," he replies, shrugging. If he's not responding to Krateros, he's not sure why'd he'd respond to Tribbie, but it's better to cover all of one's bases.

Twenty minutes later, with no response to be had, Phainon's about ready to continue his search elsewhere when a somewhat unexpected visitor gracefully makes her way into the courtyard.

"There you are, Cas!"

Apparently, the Tribios were expecting to see Castorice here. They crowd around her--or crowd as close as they're able. Phainon makes his way over to find that she's carrying a large bag in hand, which he recognizes as the one that holds all her crafting supplies. It's easy to guess what they're planning to do together.

"Greetings, I brought the right hooks this time... Oh, Lord Phainon," she says, noticing his approach. "I was going to teach the Ladies Tribios how to crochet. Are you here to join in?"

"I don't think I'm cut out for crocheting, and I'm short on time, anyway. I'm currently on a hunt for... Hold on, can I ask if you've seen Mydei anywhere since the day before yesterday?"

The abrupt question gives Castorice some pause. "Have I seen him? I don't recall... Is there a reason you're asking?"

"I'm trying to find him. Nobody's heard from him since the meeting with the Grove."

"A few days ago..." she muses, eyes closed in contemplation. Phainon expects another dead end, but then, she perks back up with a quiet *aha.*

"I did see him on a side street near one of the city walls on the night of the meeting, though I'm not sure where he was going. He seemed to be in a hurry... I couldn't determine anything else, I only saw him briefly at a distance. I'm aware that's not very helpful, my apologies."

"It's very helpful," he assures her, "I'll go check the area you saw him if you'd put it in my teleslate."

With a location marked down to check and his spirits lifted, Phainon rushes out of the palace with a hurried goodbye to the others. Now that he has an actual lead, he's certain to find Mydei soon.

He hopes so, anyway. His hopes are dashed after he spends far too much time milling around in the side street of note, finding it to be completely ordinary and not at all helpful. It's in the Kremnoan District, which seemed promising at first, but clearly, Mydei must've just been passing through, and his destination wasn't in the area.

After asking every nearby Kremnoan if they've seen their prince and crawling around like an idiot on the ground searching for clues, he leans against the closest wall with a sigh, feeling the energy ebbing from him.

He's defeated. Trying to find one man in the sprawling city of Okhema, even one as notable as Mydei, is like finding a needle in a haystack. Giving up sounds more unpleasant than continuing his search, but perhaps he should take a break.

"Hey, golden boy, pick your head up!"

Or not. Of course, his most devoted tormentor is here at another one of his lowest moments. She waltzes up to him with all her usual swagger, tail swishing and hips swaying, with a balance coin dancing across her fingers.

"... Cipher, I'm not in the mood for this right now."

"I'm giving you encouragement, but alright, if that's how you're gonna be, suit yourself," she scoffs, before tossing the coin into subspace.

"I don't feel encouraged. It's just... *ugh*, you don't even come to Okhema that frequently, and you're choosing to bother me while I'm busy instead of doing... whatever it is that you do," he mutters. It's a bit rude, and yet, he can't find it in him to play nice. He already knows she won't care if he's snappish.

"I've got *very* important business, but right now, I'm here to help you!"

Her words alone are enough to make him recoil. The wide grin on her face doesn't make it any less unnerving.

"You're going to *help* me? What sort of extortion is this?"

She waves a hand dismissively. "Oh, I already got paid. Princess Homebody *begged* me to help you, she sent me this long, heartfelt message about how she's *so* worried, and you've been *such* a mess lately... I didn't read the whole thing, I dunno all the details. But she promised to make an adorable crochet doll of yours truly if I did you a quick favor, and that's a deal I couldn't refuse!"

He's not sure if he should feel touched that Castorice was so worried about him, or disconcerted that she turned to Cipher for aid before anybody else. Right now, Cipher doesn't seem particularly nefarious, no more than usual, anyway, so he supposes he appreciates it.

"That's surprisingly considerate of you."

"I know, right?" she preens. "But enough about that, what sort of favor do you want from me? It has to be *quick*, like less than three minutes kind of quick, or I'm going to ask for more payment."

He's not exactly sure what sort of favor Castorice expected from her, but Phainon knows exactly what he'd like. "Could you do a lap through the city and find Mydei for me? Just tell me his exact location, that's all I want."

"You want me to stalk your boytoy? That's kinda weird, honestly... I've got a lax moral code, but this goes against it, buddy--"

"I'm not stalking him, I'm trying to find him so I can talk to him! He's not responding to anybody's messages and I'm getting worried."

"Oh, so he's just playing hard to get. If it'll make you feel better, then fine, I'll track him down. I'll be back!"

She's gone in a flash--but she doesn't return as quickly as he expected. Two minutes later--which is an eternity for her standards--she blinks back into existence in front of him, a new furrow to her brow.

"Huh. I couldn't find him anywhere."

"... What do you mean?"

"I mean I couldn't find him. I don't think I can put it in simpler terms for you."

Phainon's legs give out underneath him. The wall behind him is his only support as he sinks to the ground.

Cipher makes a muted exclamation that he can't quite hear past the ringing in his ears. Her face seems to waver before him as she bends down and starts vigorously shaking his shoulder.

"--non, Phainon! What the hell? Do I need to call the doctor or something?"

"He's missing, Cipher."

"Mydei's missing? I wouldn't say that, he's just not in the city. I mean, that little prince goes on mission all the time, he must be off on one right now, yeah? Go ask the Goldweaver if you must, I'm sure she knows. There's no need to freak out."

"But he's not--" he stops himself immediately, not wanting to raise his voice. He forces himself to take the deepest inhale he can manage, lets it out slowly, and then pulls himself back upright.

There's no need to freak out, as Cipher put it. That won't help anything. What he needs to do is ask Aglaea.

"Lady Aglaea, greetings."

Aglaea does not react to Phainon's approach, but when he speaks, she dips her head in silent greeting. She's not in the baths as she'd usually be at this hour, instead seated at one of the palace's circular dining tables, a pot of tea forgotten before her. She's not relaxing either, she's checking the golden threads; her hands are raised, and he can see the faint, thin sheen of them glimmering betwixt her splayed fingers.

He's not sure if she's doing a regular survey or if she's actively searching for something, but whatever the case may be, he feels a twinge of guilt for interrupting her work. Perhaps she senses his hesitation, as she lowers her hands to rest in her lap, and gives him her full attention.

"Yes, Lord Phainon?"

Suddenly, he's not quite sure what to say. "Umm... I was just... I was wondering if you could, uh, check the threads for me? I know you don't like to do it for no reason, and you said you wouldn't do it last time I asked--I'm sorry if it's a bother, but I'm really worried this time. I can't find Mydei again, and he's not answering anybody's messages--not mine, not the Tribios, not Krateros--"

Aglaea clears her throat sharply, cutting him off. "Calm yourself. I can sense your anxiety, and I understand your concern. However, it is also unnecessary. I was just checking for Lord Mydei's presence myself, as I've also noticed his absence.

"He is not in Okhema, and I cannot locate him. It appears he has gone missing, and likely has been since our meeting with the Grove."

Her tone is even as she delivers the news. Not impassive, but careful. She knows it's an issue, and yet, she's still planning how to act. This is how she's always been since the day Phainon first stumbled into Okhema, skin

streaked with ichor and psyche nearly broken, and she took him under her wing. If she weren't so prudent, she wouldn't have made it all these hundreds of years.

She's imparted the same nature onto him as she's helped guide him toward his destined future as their leader. It's what is best for both him and the future of Amphoreus. The Flamechase needs sagacity and care. If his emotions get the best of him, he'll make mistakes in his haste to act, and he may just ruin a millennium of effort.

Years of training, of affirmation, of honing--he has been tempered to a perfect, controlled edge.

But the confirmation does not affect Phainon in the way he'd imagine, and any control he has left over his mind has snapped.

All of his earlier dread remains at a simmer. His breathing is even, his body stays upright, his strength does not wane. Instead, he begins to feel anger, a great wave of anger that wells up steadily, mounting, burning fiercely within his chest. It turns his blood to fire and his will to iron.

If Mydei has gone missing, then somebody must be at fault. Somebody's done something to him--perhaps even *hurt* him.

And he is going to return that hurt tenfold.

He's walking away from Aglaea without a farewell, ignoring whatever she says in his wake. She cannot stop him. If she's disappointed in what he's about to do, he doesn't have the hindsight to regret it.

Only one thing matters in this moment.

He's always known who might dare to hurt Mydei. Those Council bastards--they've always hated him. He's a foreign prince of a once-rival nation who controls a considerable faction in their city, and whose power as a Chrysos Heir oppresses their own. Aglaea may be the main target of their ire, but he's next in line.

And right now, he's vulnerable. He's returned from a difficult expedition that failed to bear fruit, one that the Council has vocally opposed as a waste of the city's resources.

Of course they chose to strike now.

A sliver of restraint is what keeps Phainon from charging into the Dawncloud with his broadsword drawn. He forces himself to walk slowly, with measured strides. His expression is neutral, revealing nothing of his intentions. But even so, he knows his countenance radiates with his anger, so great is its power. The aides in his path flee. Council members cower. Civilians stare, transfixed.

Let them watch, he thinks. The world can know of his devotion, it matters not.

Elder Caenis is certainly about to know of its force.

She's talking with a few of her lackeys, smiling without warmth, acting as if she hasn't done anything. Phainon approaches without a moment of hesitation. He's not going to tread on eggshells; if they won't play nice, he has no reason to keep up the veneer of peace.

Perhaps the force of his glare is enough to make her turn his way before he can say anything. She seems mildly surprised and, as always, displeased, but she cools her expression before speaking.

"Oh my, what brings a Chrysos Heir to my doorstep without invitation? Do you require the Council's aid?"

"Certainly not," he spits. "You know why I'm here."

"I don't, actually. I believe our relationship is rather amicable at the moment, I cannot understand this sudden ire."

"What did you do to Mydei?"

"What did *I* do to Mydei? I did nothing but send a new draft of the Okheman-Kremnoan peace treaty for him to look over. It's very important

to us both, as his people have many demands that we try to accomodate--"

"I don't care about your terrible attempts at diplomacy," he interrupts, "and your lies disgust me. I'm going to ask you again: what did you do to Mydei?"

"You seem to think I have a reason to... *harm* him, or whatever it is that you're insinuating, and I fail to grasp why you'd accuse me of something so utterly ridiculous--and so unsubstantiated."

Caenis has the gall to feign confusion. Phainon grates his back teeth together in a desperate attempt to redirect the tension in his body. One more lie from her mouth, and he's going to close the distance between them, wrap his hands around her neck, and send her right to the gates of the Netherworld.

She deserves it, not just for this, but for all the harm she's done in Okhema. Her ploys to cling to power, to oppose progress with all the willpower left in her hate-riddled, decrepit body, to hinder the Flamechase for no real reason; if she were gone, and the Council were dissolved, their entire world would be much better off.

It would be so easy. There's nobody around besides a few spectators. The nearest guards are at least a fifteen second sprint away, which is more than enough time to wring her neck until the bones are nothing but shattered fragments under crushed muscle--

And then, the air around him constricts.

The feeling is not quite familiar, but he recognizes the source regardless: Aglaea's threads. He's seen her use them for more than just communication; they are insidiously lethal when she desires to fight, garroting Titankin and Tide-corrupted beasts with ease.

Now, they tighten without ensnaring him, acting as a slap upon the wrist with the looming threat of something much more terrible should he take another step forward. After all, she can sense his intentions, and can read

the darkness dredged up from deep within his mind that just threatened to show itself; she knows *exactly* what he was poised to do.

He's frozen.

As he listens to the sound of approaching footsteps, he dares not turn to face the woman he knows is behind him. It isn't out of defiance. His violent fantasy has vanished, and in the aftermath, he's shocked at himself.

"Elder Caenis speaks the truth. The Council has nothing to do with Mydei's disappearance," Aglaea says without greeting, tone steely.

Her words linger. Nobody speaks, not even Caenis, who looks at Phainon with undisguised anger. At this moment, he feels he deserves her wrath.

He was about to doom them all, and for what reason, but an unsubstantiated accusation against her because he wanted somebody to blame, some outlet for his instinct-driven anger that was too potent for him to handle on his own. It's incredibly foolish--and confounding. He cared deeply for Mydei, but not in the manner that he'd act so irrationally for his sake.

What's gotten into him?

Once it's clear that he isn't going to try anything, the threads fall away, and in their place, Aglaea's hand rests lightly upon his shoulder, perhaps attempting to ground him. It helps, somewhat.

"I must apologize for Lord Phainon's actions. He's currently unwell, and isn't in his right mind. I assure you, this will not happen again."

"If it does, be aware that I will not hesitate to take significant action against him and your little Flamechase. Now, I believe you've long overstayed your welcome in the Dawncloud, *Lord Phainon."*

Her sneered words linger in his mind as Aglaea leads him away. He cannot muster up the strength to speak--doesn't know what he'd say if he could. Shame burns a hole in his chest. What he just did is unforgivable, and he

knows Aglaea is disappointed, even as she brings him back to the tea table and pours him a cup of his own.

"... I know there is no apology for my actions. Bring whatever punishment you wish upon me," he murmurs, after emptying his cup. Its warmth doesn't do much to soothe him, but a facsimile of comfort is better than nothing at all.

"I'm not going to punish you."

He almost can't believe her, and yet, she has no reason to lie to him. For a moment, he's quiet, considering the weight of her forgiveness and wondering what he's done to deserve it.

"Why not?" he finally asks.

"It is as I said: you're currently unwell. The way you just acted was not natural to you, but instead driven by a hormonal response and made worse by your fraught emotional state. All of this became evident the moment I directly touched you with the threads.

"Additionally, considering the severe self-deprecation you're prone to exhibiting, I can only assume that such an incident will not occur again. No matter what I say, you will blame yourself entirely, and will close yourself off once more."

Her analyses of him are frequent enough for him to be resigned to them, and he can only sigh. "If something like that happens again, and you're not around to stop me, what might the outcome be?"

She contemplates his question as she tops up his cup. Frankly, he doesn't want to be here any longer, but he's not so foolish as to run from Aglaea. To believe he could in the first place would be a folly.

"Repression will only make matters worse," she finally says. "There is a time and a place for everything, including expressions of anger. Perhaps I can provide you with a suitable outlet by sending you out to search for Lord Mydei?"

Any protest immediately dies on his tongue, and he allows Aglaea to continue uninterrupted.

"Considering that he was in the city just two days prior, I cannot imagine that he's gone too far from Okhema. I'd recommend checking the refugee camps first, and then, if that proves unfruitful, you should move onto Janusopolis. I wish I could prove more specific instructions, but there are simply too many unknowns."

"That's enough to work with, thank you--and thank you for the opportunity as well. I know you don't want my apologies once more, but... I truly am sorry for my recent behavior."

Aglaea's lips tilt up into a slight smile. "I am aware that you care deeply for Lord Mydei, and I understand. I would be a poor bearer of my coreflame if I did not. It's evident that you've found great strength in your bond, and will achieve more yet. Love is a powerful force, one that will motivate you more than any other that could search for him."

"Of course. I'll bring him home, Lady Aglaea. You have my word."

Chapter End Notes

> i've given up on having any sort of consistency in my upload schedule. who give a shit. whatever happens with this fic will happen. i don't want to spoil anything but i promise it has a very happy ending so don't worry. we don't need to suffer any more than we already do. canon has put us all through enough.
>
> speaking of canon. i do not concern myself with 3.4 leaks (that is a lie i very much do and i cannnot handle them WHYYY WHHYYYYYYY I HATE THIS GAME). i am so so very worried for this update but i'm sure it'll be fine 😊

Chapter 5: socotrine

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Before the Calamity war, before the Black Tide, and before the Titans abandoned their mortal charges, Amphoreus was a glorious world. No living soul can recall that time of boundless prosperity, but even in ruins, the remains of great city-states stand proud, a testament to what once was. One can easily imagine how they might look bathed in the light of Aquila's gaze, dotted across the vibrant, teeming canvas of grassy hills and limestone cliffs, overlooking the blue-green oceans of placid temperament, surrounded by fertile fields. What did it all seem to promise but peace everlasting, as none dared suggest the boons of their gods could be finite.

But they were, of course. That wellspring has dried, and the dreams of their world have long since withered into clinging buds of hope. Outside of the warm cradle of Kephale's embrace, Amphoreus is naught but a stark, cold wasteland.

Being stuck out in such unforgiving conditions only makes Mydei more eager to point out the Evernight's bounty of flaws. It's storming again, and he's watching it from the shelter he scrambled into when it first started pouring down.

Somehow, the sky darkens even further than before with the cloud cover; the lack of visibility is disconcerting. Though his body aches and his eyelids are drooping, he knows he cannot rest here. He remains vigilant, listening for the sounds of shifting Titankin amongst the pattering of raindrops on the wooden roof above him.

For those without a warrior's inclination, the plethora of monsters is an issue, but for Mydei, they're of little concern. In Janusopolis, at least, there's only Titankin, which are so easy to dispatch he'd wager he could very well do it in his sleep.

Of course, he won't risk it; regardless, there's multiple reasons he shouldn't rest, not here. Like most things in Janusopolis, this house is falling apart, and progressively more water is beginning to leak inside as the minutes pass. He can't imagine it'd be very comfortable to stay here for more than a quint.

At least he has a himation to cover himself, one sturdy enough to hold up to the weather. Ptolemy got it for him many years ago, and despite all Mydei has been through, the himation has remained intact, save for a few sewn-on patches. His friends would all be pleased to know the thing has lasted so long.

It hasn't gotten much use since those days in the detachment--not until he first started showing and realized he needed some way to conceal his body, that is. Now, it keeps him warm as he braves the wilds of Janusopolis.

He has more comforts in the safe room he cleared out, tucked deep within an old temple on the city's outskirts, but he hasn't been spending much time there. There's far too much to do outside of it. Countless Titankin populate this dead city, and he has made it his job to clear them out. Beyond completing his resolution, he'll bide his time, awaiting the day of his return.

When he first suspected his pregnancy, he was already quite certain of the circumstances of the child's conception, and meeting with Hyacine on the evening of his departure provided confirmation.

It was an action hour four and a half months prior to this day, when the two of them had a rare gap in their schedules and had, in a moment of pent-up desperation, slipped away to the privacy of Phainon's chambers. Mydei was not normally so needy as to seek out sex in the middle of the day, but it had been far too long since they'd laid together.

Phainon had shared his impatience, forgoing all his usual flirtations and pressing him down into the mattress with insistence. Neither of them undressed, just undoing their pants enough to allow access, uncaring of the mess they'd make of themselves. Sweat clung uncomfortably to them both and glittered in beads on bare skin. When Mydei's armored legs squeezed around Phainon's torso, it only seemed to goad him on. He came abruptly--

almost embarrassingly--and then eagerly lowered his head to lap at the mess he'd made until a gauntleted hand was fisted in his hair and Mydei was coming too, just as quickly.

In short, it was brief, rough, and unromantic, more of a stress reliever than anything. If his memory wasn't as good as it is, he probably wouldn't even remember such a brief tangle.

But somehow, it had been the one to defy nature.

Knowing that, it's easy to predict when the child will arrive. There's no need for him to keep track of the days until then with a pocket watch and calendar--the changes in his body are indication enough--but he brought both tools along anyway, just for some sense of normalcy. In these conditions, he reckons it'd be quite easy to lose his mind, and madness is one of the few afflictions his curse cannot mend.

Thankfully, maintaining his sanity isn't a challenge, as there is much to occupy him beyond combat. Survival is the most pressing, and though he has a fair amount of experience, the arduous tasks of hunting and gathering take up a fair portion of his waking hours.

It isn't all difficult, at least. The nearest source of fresh water is a fast flowing creek a short walk from the temple, and after thoroughly cleaning a dusty amphora he scavenged from the ruins, collecting what he needs to drink and bathe is a simple matter.

Getting food requires more effort, as the wildlife is limited and difficult to hunt. At least his skill hasn't degraded in the years since he came to Okhema. All he must do is lodge a long shard of crystalized blood at the space between his quarry's eyes, and so long as his aim is true, it is felled without pain.

Butchering is less familiar to him, and he made a mess of his first kill, a small deer. The smell of its blood, something he believed was unable to bother him, suddenly turned his stomach, and he took far too long quartering the thing, not to mention the shaky cuts made by his unsteady hands.

In the end, he managed to salvage most of the kill. Beyond a portion of a fatty cut that he used while it was fresh to make a stew, he salt-cured the venison in strips, which has insofar lasted him. Berries, nuts, figs, root vegetables, mushrooms, and olives make up the other portion of his diet. He'd make do with less, as it's time-consuming to forage, but he isn't sure if the child within him shares his resilience. It gives him something to do, anyway, and he does appreciate the variety.

Still, his provisions are far from luxurious, and he finds himself daydreaming about the city's delicacies in idle moments. *This is temporary,* he often reminds himself, so often that it's almost become a mantra.

For now, all he has to do is wait. His plan is rather simple, as he had very little time to come up with it, and he didn't consider anything beyond the logistics, which consist of giving birth in secret and returning with a babe he'll claim he found abandoned in some Tide-stricken village, or something along those lines. He has plenty of time to construct a perfect lie and practice it until he no longer falters.

In moments like these, mired in misery and shivering quietly as the rain thunders down, a part of him wonders if this plan is realistic, or if he has the strength to maintain a lie so heavy for the rest of his life.

Truthfully, he doesn't know. Truthfully, he's more afraid than he's been in a very long time. Truthfully, he's found himself doubting his own resolve, and it has only been a fortnight since his departure.

Was it right of him to run in the first place? The Kremnoans will do fine without him for the next few months--Krateros will step up in his absence--but there is more to his life than watching over the former detachment. He is a Chrysos Heir. Though the Okhemans once shunned him as a savage, the years have changed that perception, and many now look to him for protection. By clearing out Titankin in Janusopolis, he's certainly *protecting,* but this by no means guarantees the city's safety.

If something drastic were to happen, he wouldn't even know. The resultant casualties--whose fault would they really be?

Damnit.

Thoughts in this vein are harder to ignore. He tries, desperately, to think of something else, *anything* else, but the guilt makes it impossible.

At least the rain's stopped for the time-being. He can run from his doubts for a bit longer.

The nearest Titankin is mere paces from the broken door--he launches out to meet it, fist breaching the thin stone of its head and turning it to shrapnel. Its limp body hits the ground with an echoing thud, hairline fractures forming across its broad chest.

His satisfaction is only momentary; when he looks up from the kill, he sees the courtyard full of Titankin now staring him down, alerted by the sound. A half-dozen archers raise their bows in greeting, golden arrows already nocked to taut bowstrings. He lunges forward, the first few shots whizzing right above his head, and the next, aimed lower, narrowly missing his flank out of sheer luck.

Three bounding strides take him to the first archer, sideswept with a gauntlet hard enough to topple it, and a foot stomped through its chest. He falls into a messy side roll to avoid another barrage, landing awkwardly on the corpse's arm in the process--the pain makes him gasp, but he pushes forward, reaching the second archer and throwing it into the third, dispatching both.

The other three are farther away, on the other end of the courtyard, already preparing their next round of arrows. *Shit.* He sprints five paces before a shot finds its mark in his thigh, causing him to stumble. His legs try to correct course, but he's falling forward, exposed, about to land on his stomach--

He twists in midair, all of his weight driven into his left shoulder instead. He feels the joint shift as he lands, a *popping* sensation that brings an agonizing surge of pain shooting down his arm. Next is the familiar, nauseating wave of heat, of shock--but he can't let himself feel it. Ignoring every instinct in his body that urges him to remain in place, he forces

himself back up with his good arm. All he needs is a breath to ground himself and he's running ahead once more, right fist clenched, winding back, and then thrown forward, obliterating the fourth archer.

The final two have no defenses left with the distance closed. The same number of punches have them joining the rest of their ranks, now all lifeless heaps of stone. He stares down at them, chest heaving with exertion, sweat trickling down his brow.

That was more difficult than it should have been, he thinks.

Then, his legs give out beneath him, and he sinks to the ground.

Only his awareness of his own lightheadedness is what saves him from completely collapsing. He's able to control his descent until he's crouched, knees and right hand pressed against the cool pavement, left arm dangling uselessly by his side.

The issue with it--a dislocation--is obvious from the sensation alone. He'll need to reset it before it can properly heal, he's already aware. In this sense, he's like an ordinary person, accelerated healing aside. Usually, he'd have somebody else around to help, but he'll have to manage alone.

It's a tall order, certainly. Perhaps an impossible one.

He rocks back onto his haunches to assess the injury, and after delicately pushing his himation down his arm, he finds confirmation of a dislocation. The shape of his shoulder is flattened, with his arm pressed strangely into his chest, and he can see the head of the joint jut out below his collarbone. Unmistakeable, really, even to one without medical training.

Beyond a few scrapes, this and the arrow wound are the first injuries he's sustained since his departure. He's surprised it took so long, considering how many Titankin he's been fighting, though he wishes the streak could've lasted a bit longer.

He tries prodding at his shoulder, and swears aloud at the sudden jolt of pain, more intense than he expected. He's aware his pregnancy has

weakened his physical capabilities, but it has enhanced them in other, mostly unwelcome, ways. His senses were sharp before, he doesn't need them to be sharper, and he certainly never wanted his pain to hurt worse. Before, he could easily push it from his mind, but now, the twin throbbings in his shoulder and thigh slash his concentration to ribbons, reducing his world to nothing but his labored breathing, his thick swallows, the burn of shock fading away, and of course the rhythmic agony in his tired body. Fixing these injuries is the last thing he wants to do with exhaustion weighing on his mind, but he has no other option.

The arrow will go first, he decides, as he secures his hand against his thigh. Over the course of his life, he estimates he's removed hundreds of arrows. He's so familiar with this sort of injury that he should be able to handle the pain no matter the circumstance.

Or so he thought. When he pulls the arrow from his flesh, the burst of pain is so intense that he has to turn his head to retch violently. Nothing comes up but a bit of acrid saliva he spits onto the pavement; however, the nausea lingers, simmering in the back of his throat. The smell of his ichor in the air does not help. He pulls out his waterskin and douses the area once the puncture has healed over, doing his best to wash away the blood so it can't irritate him anymore.

He knows he's mostly just stalling. His resolve is already weakening. Setting his shoulder will be a hundred times worse than the arrow, he's well aware. If he doesn't do it right this instant, he doesn't think he'll ever manage it, and he *has* to manage it.

With a shuddering inhale, he closes his hand around his left bicep. Two motions, that's all he needs; he'll pull the top of the bone out from where it's lodged and do his best to push it back up into place. His body isn't too picky, it just has to be close enough to the socket for healing to commence.

Just close enough.

After another steadying breath, he yanks *hard.*

Immediately, a terrible lance of pain cleaves through his body, so terrible it batters against his mind, rips at the edges of his consciousness and his sanity itself, consuming each piece of him in sequence as he falls apart. It's almost too raw to process, a sensation--if such a word can even describe how *much* it is--that reaches to extremities and tangles itself up like a trapped animal.

And it's not yet done. With the last dredges of strength left in his body, he pushes his arm up, wordlessly praying to whatever Titan might be listening for it to take, for whatever force that allows his flesh to mend itself to work its magic and finish the job. Each second that passes is a small eternity, and he almost loses his willpower, *almost*, but then he feels it, that deep twist and shift of tissue inside of him, pulling the head of the joint back into place.

But there is still no relief. His vision is static. His blood roars in his ears. He feels each desperate thud of his heart racing away in his frozen ribcage. Forcing himself to breathe is near impossible--he begins to cough, to gag, choking on the air itself. The muscles are weaving themselves back around the socket, and though it's welcome, it all hurts, he can't think, he can do nothing but writhe helplessly in the face of this merciless pain.

He isn't sure if he truly faints--the darkness is impossible to parse in the throes of agony. All he knows is that, eventually, the pain is nothing but a dull ache, and he's lying flat on his back, staring up at the darkened sky.

Slowly, he sits up. An experimental shift of his shoulder reveals it to be a bit stiff, but it seems to be properly healed. A few hours of rest should bring it back to normal.

That, at least, is a relief. Everything else about his current situation is displeasing. He's entirely sapped of strength, to the extent that he doesn't think he has the ability to make it all the way back to his safe room. Though the mere idea makes him grimace, it seems he'll need to recover his strength in one of the nearby houses. They're all rotting away and are certainly dirty, not to mention the danger of sleeping in an area he knows hasn't been cleared of Titankin.

"Whatever, you can handle it," he mutters to himself, mostly for the comfort of hearing his own voice. He's been doing that a lot lately. Perhaps it's not good for his psyche, but the prospect of complete silence feels more daunting.

He continues to mumble things as he surveys a few of the houses, pointing out the flaws as he pokes around. Most of them are entirely unsuitable, but eventually, he finds a promising one; the roof doesn't seem to be leaking, and on the first floor, there's an intact kline with a few worn pillows laying atop it. They're rather dusty, but simply shaking them out does the trick.

It's far from luxury, but after a final look around, he deems the place acceptable. He can stand to sleep here.

Before he settles down, he musters up the willpower to drag a large wardrobe in front of the door, just in case a wandering Titankin detects his presence. The blockade won't do much to stop it, but it'll make enough noise in the process of breaking through that he'll have time to get his bearings.

He briefly considers securing the door with additional furniture, but exhaustion drags at his body, and he can do nothing but lay down upon the kline, slipping into a dreamless sleep the moment his eyes slide shut.

"Hey, look! There's Titankin corpses over here."

Mydei is roused some indeterminate amount of time later by the sound of faint conversation. His sleep-addled mind is quick to dismiss it as the chatter of passing travelers, and he closes his bleary eyes, intent on resting for a bit longer.

"Whoever dispatched them is quite strong. An ordinary person isn't capable of destroying their bodies in such a way... A trained warrior, then?"

"Perhaps, though any old warrior also couldn't do this, I'd reckon... But there's no red crystals around, so I don't think it was *him."*

"You were hoping this was Lord Mydei's doing?"

"Yeah, I was. I know I'm... ugh, I'm being stupid about all of this. I'm sorry, Castorice."

Suddenly, Mydei is fully awake. He wants to deny what he just heard, but he can't ignore the familiarity of these two voices, not with the confirmation of a name.

Phainon and Castorice are here. They're here, and they're coming closer.

"You don't need to apologize. I miss him as well, we all do," Castorice says softly. Mydei does his best to reign in his mounting panic. He needs to stay calm, stay *still.*

"But I feel like I'm not focusing on this mission. We're not here for Mydei! We're here to help people," Phainon exclaims, and dear gods, does hearing that voice make him feel weak.

"Technically, locating Mydei is the goal of every mission Aglaea's been sending out, no matter what the official reason may be."

A pause. Mydei strains his ears, listening to their distant footfalls and hoping beyond belief that they don't come any closer while knowing that they likely will. Two of the Titankin he felled were positioned right outside this house.

"You're right. I feel so selfish, but it's not very selfish to want to find him."

"Even if it was selfish, it would be okay."

Another pause.

"... Thank you."

Phainon sounds so broken, and something in Mydei breaks too. All his uncertainties claw at his mind, asking him if he thinks this is really okay, if he should just push his way out of the door and show himself, if he should finally put an end to this deception--

--but he stamps it all down as quickly as it arose by simply recalling his rejection. He can't risk anything, not with Phainon.

The fear of losing him is one so terrible that it often robs Mydei of sleep, instead lying supine and tensed in his nest of blankets, anxiety gnawing away at his insides. After a life full of loss, he never thought he'd take a person for granted again, and yet, Phainon's presence became a constant so steady that he found it impossible to imagine himself without his other half.

If there is a selfish one between the two of them, it is Mydei. All of this is for his own benefit, just so he can birth this child, bring them before Phainon while lying about their origins, and raise them on his own without his lover feeling any sense of obligation to help.

In his mind, the child will always be theirs, but Phainon doesn't need to know, not if fatherhood will hurt him.

Mydei has to keep hiding.

The footfalls get louder. He grits his teeth together and bites back a string of curses. Of course they're coming to investigate the corpses, *godsdamnit.*

He doesn't dare move. His breathing is slow and painfully shallow, just enough to keep himself conscious. Even blinking feels like a mistake.

He's done everything to avoid this, though he should've known from the beginning that his efforts would be futile. If he could just lay low, hide out deep within Janusopolis where no souls dare venture, clean up the Titankin he leaves behind, and not utilize his more conspicuous abilities, he believed he could stop the other Chrysos Heirs from investigating--but why wouldn't they? If another of their rank is missing, they'll search for them everywhere, even in the most unlikely of places.

"The force used for these kills... Maybe it wasn't done by a human at all. Aren't there beasts that'll target Titankin when provoked?" Phainon asks, startling Mydei. They're mere meters away from him now, separated only by the worn stone wall. He can hear them shifting around as they presumably investigate the corpses.

"Griffins, manticores, and basilisks will, if the accounts I read are accurate. I've not seen them do it myself, but all of them are certainly capable of such violence."

So long as they don't lapse into complete silence, there should be no chance of them hearing him; as for smelling him, he thinks they would've mentioned it by now if they could. The stale air hides most scents, he's come to learn, and any lingering traces are quickly gusted off by the sporadic, strong winds.

"Yeah... It just seems awfully convenient that some wandering beast swooped in and killed Titankin in the exact area we were meant to clear. The Fates work in mysterious ways, I suppose."

The footsteps restart, slowly proceeding whence they came. Relief courses through him.

And then, something inside of him moves.

It is a miracle he doesn't make much of a sound. One hand clasps over his mouth while the other flies down to grasp at the swell of his abdomen, at the place where he feels it, that utterly foreign sensation immediately recognizable as his child's tiny movements.

Something that should fill him with joy instead fills him with terror. He knows he gasped, just slightly, and the pair must've heard it, as their footsteps have halted. It's far too quiet in the aftermath; his own heartbeat thunders so loudly in his chest that he fears it must be audible.

"... Did you hear something?"

Castorice's question is the nail in the coffin. Dread rises like a tide within him and he can do nothing but wait for the sound of their re-approaching, for they'll surely investigate the sound.

"I didn't, but you've got better ears than me. Do you think there's an enemy nearby?"

"I don't know..."

Her words linger heavily in the air, and the silence stretches on, each passing second a small eternity. Mydei isn't certain if he'll survive it. He's never been a pious man, but he prays to each Titan in quick succession, knowing that only a miracle will save him now.

Castorice has spent a millenia honing her senses; now that she has reason to suspect a living being may be nearby, it's certain that she'll detect the quiet hum of his biological machinery, of pumping blood and contracting muscles, the barest traces that are impossible to suppress.

It's over, he thinks, already resigning himself to whatever fate is about to befall him. Most of what he feels is regret, and he's used to its sting by now. It's his own fault for running with such a hasty plan. If he spent more than a quint hashing it out instead of caving to his desperation to flee Okhema, he would've anticipated this, and then he wouldn't have to lose--

"Never mind. It was just the wind."

The relief from her words is so unexpected that it doesn't quite register, and Mydei waits for the miracle to collapse, for what could it be but some twisted mirage--but it holds steady.

"My apologies for startling you, Lord Phainon," Castorice continues, "I've just felt a bit strange since we got to Janusopolis."

"It's alright, I've felt strange as well... Good to know I'm not the only one. It just seems too quiet. Something must be up here, what with the lack of Titankin and the lack of their corpses, I mean..."

Finally, they egress out of earshot. Mydei doesn't dare move, not yet, not until his muscles burn from the discomfort of staying in place for so long and he lets himself slowly adjust to a sitting position, feet planted solidly on the ground.

Fuck.

Even now, he doesn't feel relieved. That was far, *far* too close. Sheer luck saved him, and he's never liked leaving things up to chance.

He needs to leave this courtyard; loitering any longer is just begging for trouble, as Phainon and Castorice could easily double back. He can only hope that they won't travel so deep into Janusopolis that they'll stumble across his safe room, though that seems rather unlikely.

With some trepidation, he pushes the wardrobe away from the door and eases it open. Of course, the child chooses this moment to move again, startling him enough to let go of the handle. He's unsure if he'll ever adjust to the sensation. It feels almost like a muscle twitching, but deeper in his body, moreso as if one of his organs has acquired a mind of its own.

It's strange, yes, and it makes him smile. His child is thriving within him, growing stronger by the day. What a gift it is to have been born an omega, so he can carry this blossoming life within his own womb. They may not have picked the best moment to make their presence known, but that's no fault of their own.

He feels no other movements as he quietly makes his way back to the safe room, nor while he prepares himself a quick meal, not in the mood for laboring over the fire for a quint. Checking his pocket watch informs him that this is a late dinner, and he'd typically turn in afterwards, but having just napped, he doesn't yet feel sleepy, just mentally exhausted.

So, he makes the climb up to the slanted roof of the temple to stargaze. There's a sizable hole at one end, and the exposed joists are large enough for him to sit upon, offering an excellent vantage point.

The light pollution from the Dawn Device is bad enough to block out most of the stars, but off in the distance, a smattering can still be seen through the gaps in the clouds. He's spent many of his idle moments up here, letting his mind wander, sometimes thinking of consequential matters and sometimes of nothing much at all. He oft did the same on the rooftops of Okhema; it has always helped him to gather himself.

Today, he has much to consider, yet his traitorous thoughts drift elsewhere, to a thing he shouldn't: his fear.

"You will naturally have fears in your life, but you should never let them fester in your mind--grab them by the neck and toss them away the moment they appear. Ignore them entirely. Let them know they shall never have any power over you. One day, the part of you which conjures them up will shrivel up from disuse, and your body will no longer know fear," Krateros had advised him many years ago, soon after he'd clambered out of the Sea of Souls. The lesson has always stuck with him, as it is the one he has always failed to follow.

He has tried, of course. Still tries every day. How lovely would it be if that frightened part of him *had* withered away, but he doesn't think it will. For a man whose first memories are not the terror of dying endlessly to the violent sea, perhaps it could, but for Mydei, he has known fear too intimately to ever lose it.

And there is a new fear, a terrible one. It has quickly taken root as his pregnancy has become more obvious, and the concept of fatherhood solidifies in his mind. He's desperate to reject it, to assure himself that such a thing is entirely impossible, but it only seems to entrench itself deeper, like some insidious toxin.

How could he ever fear that he may become like his father, knowing the full extent of his treachery? No twisted prophecy with a demand to slaughter his own child weighs on his mind, no corruption has infested his heart, and yet, a voice tells him that it *could*, that he *could* lose himself just as Eurypon did, that he very well *could* shun the life he carries.

His child deserves better than him, a prince born from a legacy of death.

Or perhaps he will make a fine father, and he's overthinking the entire matter. Though the latter is more likely, no amount of reason can satisfy him.

If Phainon were here, he might just manage.

But he isn't. Mydei watches the stars alone, carrying a child unwanted by its other father.

Chapter End Notes

> 3.4 was the most insane shit in honkai star rail history. i would like to offer my sincerest apologies to phainon for calling you lame and stupid and an idiot all those times. i was joking but i still feel bad about it.
>
> the next chapter's a big one so it might take me a while. maybe i'll get it out before 3.5 but i unfortunately have other things to do in my life that aren't writing yaoi like moving out of my mold-filled apartment. i hope it'll be worth the wait

Chapter 6: nightshade

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon's head *hurts.*

As he eases into wakefulness, he wishes he could return right back to sleep, if only to hide from the relentless throbbing in his temples. It's not just his head; his mouth is impossible dry, his stomach pangs with hunger, and every muscle in his body aches from overexertion.

Dear Titans, he feels *awful.* A sad whimper is torn from his lips before he can stifle it, and he can only hope that there's nobody around to hear it.

He's not even sure where he is right now--his mind is addled by both sleep and discomfort, too muddled to think past the pain. Wherever he decided to rest is far from ideal, though he doesn't wish to open his eyes and find out. Kephale's light shines harshly against his closed eyelids, exacerbating his headache as is. He manages to flop a limp hand across his face to block it out.

At some point, he'll have to get up, he's well aware. He doesn't really want to think that far ahead yet, not until he's remembered how to be a person.

Unfortunately for him, the world isn't going to wait for him to be ready. Something--or someone--has removed the hand over his face and begun poking his cheek.

"Snowy, are you awake now? Open your eyes!"

He thinks Lady Tribbie might be speaking to him, but he's not quite sure. Her voice sounds tinny and dreamlike in a way that makes it hard to understand.

"... What did you say?" he mumbles, words slurring together into mush despite his attempts to annunciate them. His tongue feels less like a muscle and more like a packed wad of clay. He swallows hard, trying to get some saliva back into his mouth, and determines that he's quite dehydrated.

"Uh, well... **We** didn't understand what he just said, but he seems to be waking up!"

"That's a relief. Thank you for your assistance, Lady Tribbie."

Is Castorice here too? It seems he might have an audience wherever it is that he's ended up. He finally manages to crack open his eyes, and finds that indeed, both Lady Tribbie and Castorice are staring at him, with the former hovering right over his face, and the latter barely visible in his periphery.

It seems he's lying on a stone bench in a secluded courtyard, which is far from the most comfortable place to take a nap. That explains why the back of his skull aches worse than the rest of his head, at least.

With the confirmation, he decides to shut his eyes again. Kephale's light is way too bright, just as he thought it might be, and his vignetted vision doesn't take well to it.

"No, don't go back to sleep!" Tribbie cries.

"I'm awake, just resting my eyes," he assures her, this time managing to speak more clearly. "I've got a headache."

Castorice hums in acknowledgement. "I see. It's good to see you're finally conscious. Thank you for your help, Lady Tribbie. You can return to your errand now."

"He still seems... Well, if you're certain. Call **us** back if Snowy needs a few more pokes. Bye bye, Cas!"

Phainon listens to Tribbie flutter away, which he laments. He can feel the weight of Castorice's gaze on him now that it's just the two of them.

"Lord Phainon."

"I know. I know I need to take better care of myself."

He immediately regrets how snappish his tone is. There's no reason to be confrontational.

"... I'm sorry. I'm not trying to upset you, I'm simply worried."

"Ugh, no--*I'm* sorry, I'm not mad at you," he groans, opening his eyes to find Castorice wearing a tight frown. "I really do appreciate the concern, it's nice to know you care so much about me!"

Thankfully, her frown eases up a bit, and her expression turns contemplative. "Alright. Shall we get some lunch, then?"

The sudden change in topic gives him pause; although he's automatically poised to reject the offer, his hunger is gnawing relentlessly at his midsection, and it's difficult to ignore.

When was the last time he ate, anyway? He had dinner the previous evening, but today, he was so preoccupied by tracking leads in the Kremnoan district that he only had the time to eat a pomegranate somebody gifted him. That may be part of the reason why he passed out on this random bench, though the compounding lack of sleep definitely hasn't helped.

His life is falling apart, dear gods. He needs to get his act together before his body gives out on him entirely.

So, they end up at the nearest diner--a place that Phainon's not been to before--seated at a spacious table. It's empty enough that Castorice doesn't have to worry about her proximity to others, and they're also afforded a fair amount of privacy once the waiter leaves with their orders.

The silence between them settles, rather uncomfortably, as they wait for their food. Phainon drains his water cup to occupy himself, and then, once his thirst is slaked, he looks awkwardly around the restaurant, hands twisting together in his lap. He wants to say something, *anything* to dispel the tension, but nothing comes to mind. There's nothing left for him to say

that Castorice doesn't know. She's watched him work himself to the bone for the past few weeks, and he's ignored her and everyone else trying to reign him back.

For whatever reason, being here, in this little diner, with Castorice staring him down, has brought him a fair amount of clarity. He's not sure if he's happy to have it. Now, he's just embarrassed.

"Have you found any leads recently?" Castorice asks, before he can bow before her and profusely apologize for his recent behavior.

"Still nothing. None of the Kremnoans know anything. They all want to help, of course, but they can't offer more than conjecture on where Mydei's gone or why he left in the first place."

"Then perhaps you should pause the search for a while. Information can passively gather while you rest."

It's the last thing he wants to do, and based on her wariness to suggest it, he presumes that Castorice can sense his reluctance. The concept of relaxing while Mydei's out there somewhere, certainly alone and possibly suffering, is unbearable. The fact that the search has drawn on as long as it already has is unbearable enough. He doesn't want to prolong it.

But what use is he while he's like this? He's in no shape to fight; he's barely well enough to manage a walk around the city. Only an idiot would press on in this condition.

"You're right. I'll pause the search."

Castorice's eyes widen. "Oh, I... I didn't expect you to agree. I'm sorry if I was too insistent, you shouldn't feel pressured to do anything."

"You were far from insistent. You just spoke the truth, and I'm finally tired enough to listen. Frankly, I should've listened weeks ago. I should be the one apologizing for... for everything, really. I know I've been short with all of you, and impossible to work with, and absent more often than not, and... I mean, just awful all around."

"Please don't be so hard on yourself, we all understand why you're upset."

"Me being upset doesn't excuse my behavior."

"But this goes beyond just being upset!" she says, her voice as emphatic as he's ever heard it. "I know I've understated how you must feel--Lord Mydei is very special to you. He's not your mate, but you're as close as a bonded pair, and the pain of losing someone you treasure so dearly isn't ignorable."

"... I know. It's just... It feels like this is all my fault, somehow. How can I mourn something that I caused?"

Castorice's brow scrunches. "No matter the circumstance, it doesn't preclude you from mourning his absence, but what do you mean?"

"Before he disappeared, he was avoiding me, and really only me. Maybe there's no connection and I'm blaming myself for nothing... I just can't shake the thought."

"I suppose it's a possibility, though you said yourself that he was acting strangely the moment he returned from the expedition, so I can't imagine what you could've done," she replies. At this point, the repeated attempt at comfort fails, though it's not any fault of her own.

For weeks, he's felt as if he's teetering on the brink of realization, felt that he's surrounded by evidence and if he pushes just a bit more, he'll stumble his way right into the answer. What happened, and why--shouldn't he know by now? After all he's seen Mydei do since his return, he should've learned enough to piece it together, but he just *can't.* The clues don't fit together so neatly.

There must be something he's missing, some possibility so obvious yet so impossible that he's not yet considered it, not even allowed it to cross his mind. His own ignorance goads him onward just as it torments him, and he can't take it.

Phainon buries his head in his hands and makes a frustrated noise into his palms. "This is too complicated, I can't handle it right now. I feel sick."

"Ah, I'm sorry. Is there a specific reason for your malaise beyond a lack of rest that I didn't consider? Perhaps your, uh, cycle?"

"No, it's not pre-rut, I've just exhausted myself. I'd know if it was my cycle, I mean, I..."

Wait.

When was he last due for a rut?

"Then perhaps we... Lord Phainon, are you feeling alright?"

"I, uh, realized... Give me one second, Castorice," he mumbles, as he yanks his teleslate from his pocket and flips to the calendar. He's never been the best at tracking his cycles, but he tries to note down each time his pre-rut starts, just in case something were to happen--and right now is that *something*.

He hopes he's just mistaken, that his last rut wasn't more than a few months ago and he's completely misremembering things. After all, he's been so busy lately, it's only natural that his memories would get scrambled up--

"I was due for my last rut almost a month ago, and it never happened."

"Oh. Oh my... That isn't good."

They stare at each other for a moment that seems to stretch into eternity. Phainon's mind, made sluggish by overwork, can't quite process the realization. Something terrible might be happening to him, and he doesn't know what to do other than stew in his unease.

His rut has *never* been late. It's as reliable as clockwork, coming at the same time every three months like an unwelcome but familiar acquaintance. No matter how grief-stricken, stressed, or upset he's been, it has never once wavered.

"... I should probably go see Lady Hyacine," he manages, voice coming out shakier than he'd like.

"You should eat your food first, though. I don't believe skipping a meal will make it better."

He's not sure how much of an appetite he has left, but Castorice *is* right. When the waiter finally arrives with their meals, he manages to stomach most of it with sheer hunger motivating him despite the tightness in his throat. Only a few bites remain when he finally gives up.

"I'll pay for us both, you can go to Lady Hyacine," Castorice says as he sets down his fork. "Please don't worry about paying me back right now." For once, he doesn't insist, and after a rushed farewell, leaves Castorice behind at the diner.

By some stroke of luck, it appears that Hyacine's infirmary in the city is open. Phainon breathes a sigh of relief when the doorknob yields under his hand. He's not sure why she's in Okhema, but he won't look a gift dromas in the mouth. He doesn't trust another doctor with such a personal issue, and not having to travel all the way to the Grove is a blessing.

However, when he steps into the clinic, he finds the waiting room and the space behind the front desk vacant. His heart immediately sinks. It doesn't bode well, but since the door was unlocked, he can only assume Hyacine's here. With some apprehension, he rings the service bell; a second later, Little Ica pops up from somewhere behind the desk with a disgruntled trill, presumably awakened from its nap.

"Ah, Ica! It's good to see you, my friend. Is Hyacine available to see me today? I've got an urgent problem."

Ica makes a noise that, at the very least, sounds affirmative, and flies off into the clinic. Phainon's not sure what to do in its absence. He takes a seat in the nearest chair, assuming that it may take a while for it to reappear.

That assumption ends up being untrue, as only a few minutes later, Hyacine emerges from the back with Ica fluttering behind her, looking a bit frazzled. "Are you alright, Lord Phainon? Ica seems worried for you."

"Lady Hyacine, it's... Well, I'm not sure how big of an issue it might be. If you're busy right now, I can wait," he assures her, to no avail. He must look unwell enough for his words to fall flat.

"I was packing up to return to the Grove, but I only just started, I can still see you today. Come to the examination room, please tell me what the matter is."

He waits until the door of the examination room clicks shut before he finally opens his mouth to speak. "It's about my rut. It was due to start almost a month ago, but I still haven't had my pre-rut."

Her reaction to those words is not what he expected, mostly because she *has* a reaction. Her stoic, unshakeable expression cracks, and though she reigns in her surprise only a moment later, he's still taken off-guard by the widening of her eyes.

"Lord Phainon, you're aware that..."

A pause. Again, Hyacine's expression morphs, her mouth parting in something that seems like realization.

"Oh... I see. Is it alright if I exam you quickly? I'd like to check the scent glands on the sides of your neck, please."

He's confused by her actions, but he turns around and cranes his neck to allow her access. Her hands are ice-cold against the sensitive skin; he fails to suppress a shudder.

"I know it's uncomfortable, but please keep your neck still... Thank you. You've never had a mating mark, or been mated, right?"

"No, Mydei and I are just partners. I was planning to mate with him, but... I can't exactly do that right now."

"I'm very sorry about that, by the way. I do hope Lord Mydei returns soon," she says quietly, as she continues to prod at his scent glands. "It's possible that he may have something to do with your absent rut."

"How so?"

"Well, even though you're not mated, sometimes you will respond to your partner's own body as if you were. Mydei emits pheromones that are detected by your nose and vomeronasal organ, and this sends signals to your body to respond in certain ways. A mating bite would change the profile of the pheromones released by his scent glands and therefore change your body's response, but even without the bite, an alpha's body still has sensitivity to an omega's existing pheromones. With enough time spent around the same omega, the body will learn and adjust to their unique chemical profile, both mentally and physically.

"All of that is to say that you are pseudomated. That is my belief, anyway. If you'd allow me to swab your scent glands, I can run a test to confirm."

"Please do."

It seems a bit complicated to someone like him, who knows so woefully little about dynamics, but plausible enough. He puzzles over it while Hyacine runs a cotton swab over his neck and sticks it into a small vial of liquid. He and Mydei have spent a lot of time together in the last few years, that is true, and they certainly act like a mated couple with how they scent and nest.

Phainon isn't sure why they never took the leap and bonded with each other. He has always hesitated when the opportunity presented itself. Mydei never seized the chance either; honestly, Phainon was waiting for him to do it. Perhaps there's some Kremnoan cultural significance to it.

It's not like it matters much anymore, if Hyacine's right. Their bodies decided they'd be mates, regardless of how their minds acted. And if they're mates, then what does that mean for Phainon?

"If we *are* psuedomated, why would that delay my rut?" he asks, while watching Hyacine swirl the vial lightly in one hand.

"There are a few different reasons. I can run some bloodwork to see if it's due to a hormonal disorder, but I strongly suspect that isn't the case, since

your scent doesn't have any atypical qualities. I believe it's stress related, as there is a level of physiological stress one endures when their mate is absent for a prolonged period. Therefore, I don't have any concerns for your health."

"Alright, I trust you," he replies, nodding as if he fully accepts the explanation.

But he doesn't.

Hyacine's lying to him about something. The way she flinched, ever so slightly, when he asked his question was indication enough. The way she wouldn't meet his gaze while talking was the nail in the coffin.

He's so taken off guard by it all that he doesn't bother to press, even though he definitely should. In a daze, he listens to her give him a clean bill of health and send him out of the clinic with a cheery farewell, too lost in thought to properly focus.

That entire conversation was bizarre. Somehow, all Hyacine did was confuse him further. Lying aside, she offered him none of the answers he sought--really, she just gave him a new question to add to his ever-growing pile.

"Lord Phainon, you're aware that..."

Is he aware of *what?*

Gods, this is driving him insane. He needs to go to the baths and relax for a while before his skull cracks open from the stress.

At this time of day, the main floor of the Mamoreal Palace is far too busy for his liking, and he makes a beeline to the Heroes' baths. Hopefully, the divine waters will help with his pounding headache. He's pleased to find it empty, and after informing the nearest attendant that he'd like to be left alone today, he casts off his clothes and reclines in the deepest section of the pool.

His headache eases quickly, much to his relief, but unfortunately, his emotions must be too volatile for the water to soothe. Perhaps he needs to wait longer than half of a quint for that effect. Aglaea had some sort of warning about not staying too long in the baths, but she's not here, so he can probably get away with--

"Lord Phainon, you seem awfully troubled."

Or perhaps not. The water's tranquil surface is disturbed as Aglaea lowers herself in a respectful distance away, just close enough to carry out a conversion. He should've known she'd arrive around this time; her schedule is quite busy, but it's also predictable.

"More troubled than I've been the last few weeks?"

She hums. "Troubled in a different matter. You're trying to figure something out, yes?"

"Yeah," he confesses, knowing there's no reason to keep it from her. "Perhaps you can lend me your ear? I think you might be able to give me some advice."

"Go ahead, I'll see if I can."

"It's just that... My rut is extremely late, and it's never been late before. I mean, I'm stressed out right now, and that could be the reason, but still, it doesn't feel right to write it off like that. Something else is going on, I'm sure. So, I went to Lady Hyacine, since I thought she'd probably know. And, well... I really think she knows why, but she won't tell me. She just said it was due to stress... A lie of omission, I suppose."

"You're certain she lied?"

"Quite so. You've taught me well, Lady Aglaea, I know how to read a person's tells."

"Curious. Lady Hyacine would not typically lie to a patient, and not to a friend, either. For her to do so must mean something very important is on

the line, perhaps involving another patient's confidentiality."

Aglaea says nothing else for a while, perhaps sensing that Phainon is deep in thought, and perhaps knowing that she may not need to say anything else. All she really needed to do was give him a nudge to jump-start his thinking.

Something very important, huh.

It involves Mydei's confidentiality; of course, it always comes back to him in the end. Phainon watches the placid ripples on the surface of the water, mind working to lay out all the pieces of the puzzle as neatly as he can manage, starting at the beginning.

Mydei returned after his expedition and began acting strangely. That's the impetus for everything. Something must've happened during it, or so Phainon assumed, but he might be thinking about it the wrong way. The other clues don't necessarily suggest that. He shouldn't take it as an absolute.

What does he know without any conjecture? *That* is where he should start. It has been quite a few years since his time at the Grove, but he remembers a fair portion of what he learned, and he'd never forget something that Anaxa was relentless in correcting.

Unfortunately, there aren't many facts to establish. Mydei suddenly began wearing different clothes. He left a meeting due to what seemed to be some sort of illness, despite the fact that, by his own admission, he's immune to disease. He acted cagey around Phainon for a few days before he ended up avoiding him completely. He spoke with Hyacine and then promptly disappeared from the city.

The wardrobe change is the strangest fact; it's certainly important, but it's still hard to fathom. Why would Mydei hide his body when he was perfectly content to flaunt it in the past? Perhaps there was some change there that displeased him, or a change that he believed might displease others. His scent, too, had changed, but not in an emotional way. There was no harsh tang of anger, no subtle stink of depression. What can be conveyed through one's scent beyond emotion? Phainon's unsure, but--

Could it relate to that mysterious illness of his? What condition might cause illness--without being an actual illness--while also changing one's body and scent in a distinct way? What condition could affect one's mate as well?

And what condition would get more noticeable over time, unknown to everyone at first but slowly appearing, *growing* over the course of months? What condition might incubate for long enough as to not be at all evident upon departing for a long expedition, instead revealed later in its duration?

Is Mydei--

Oh Titans.

Oh, dear Titans above.

Phainon thought it would be more satisfying to realize the truth, but no, it is a terrible thing, slowly blanketing him, crushing him underneath its suffocating weight.

He thinks there's only one question left to ask, and he barely has the strength to ask it. His stomach is beginning to ache. His chest burns with the air of his last inhale. His heart hammers nauseatingly. His eyes lock onto Aglaea's unseeing gaze, flailing for any sort of comfort that he's already aware he won't find.

"... What's the main reason that an alpha would miss their rut?" he asks, almost inaudible. There's a tremor to his voice. Aglaea hears it all, knows his fear in an instant. Her tone is as even as always when she replies.

"For an unmated alpha, there's a plethora of reasons... but if they are mated, and they don't have any health problems, it would be due to their mate becoming pregnant."

"... Aglaea."

"Yes, Phainon?"

"Aglaea," he says again, more insistent, more desperate, as he tries to force the words out. "Mydei's pregnant. And he--he thinks... He thinks I don't

want it. That's why he left. I told him--oh gods, Aglaea, I told him I didn't want kids with him but it wasn't because I didn't want that, it's because I was scared of--of what might happen and I--"

"Phainon, breathe," she commands, firmly enough to slow the cascading tide of his thoughts, but just barely. He tries, *damnit,* he tries so hard to calm himself. Panicking won't fix it. Panicking feels like the only thing he can do.

More than a year ago, Mydei suggested that they have children, and Phainon refused point-blank. He wanted a family so badly that it frightened him. To love somebody that wasn't Mydei--the one thing that death could not take from him--was dangerous.

More than a year later, Phainon no longer feels that same fear, and yet, he failed where it mattered the most. He never bothered to explain to Mydei exactly how he felt back then, never assured him that he'd finally beaten down that part of him that refused comfort out of the belief that he'd lose it all in the end, never promised him that he'd remain steadfast by his side.

The consequence of that? Mydei *fled.* He must've been so worried about how Phainon would react to the news, having seen how he managed the subject in the past, that leaving seemed to be a safer option.

How did Phainon fuck this up so badly? Mydei's pregnancy should've been a celebration, not *this.*

"I have to go find him *now.* He's out in the Evernight *alone* and he's *pregnant* and it's *my fault!"* he cries, already clambering from the bath with frantic movements and splashing divine water all across the tile.

"You're in no shape to leave the city," Aglaea insists, "we'll send a search party in your stead, you need to rest."

He ignores her in favor of toweling himself off.

"Phainon, stop," she insists, more forcefully this time, with a dangerous edge to her tone. He does stop, and he whips his head around to glare at her,

because there's something in her words--a too-composed calmness--that makes anger spark up within him.

"... Did you know?"

Her expression does not change. She doesn't shift an inch. Phainon may have learned to read others well, but she remains impossibly out of reach. Still, despite the impeccable facade, he can discern enough for the anger to burn brighter.

"You knew, didn't you--and you didn't... You didn't tell anyone!"

"I had my suspicions, but that is not enough evidence to work on."

"But you should've--"

"Should've done more than I did already? Allowing you to search for him was all that was in my capabilities, no matter the information available. Would you have done anything differently if you had known he was with child? I suspect you'd have only worked yourself harder."

"And it would've been my right to do so!" he shouts. After facing down his exhaustion just an hour prior, he knows he should be much more rational about this, but the sudden surge of protectiveness has him throwing away all logic.

"I will not allow you to work yourself into an early grave, no matter how much you insist upon it."

"I know my limits, I won't."

It's a ridiculous thing for him to say when it's so obvious that he doesn't. His own petulance sobers him up a bit; he shouldn't act like this in front of Aglaea, somehow who knows so much about him and how his mind ticks.

Her quiet sigh is a good indication that he's exasperated her. "Phainon, I'm not trying to act as your enemy right now. I'm trying to prevent you from making a mistake. Mydeimos will not be helped by poor planning, none of us will."

"I... I know," he acquiesces, "I understand why you didn't tell me. But you can't stop me from searching right now. This is my responsibility. Send out a search party if you want, but I'm going."

She considers his words for a long moment. If she really wanted to stop him from leaving, she and her golden threads could certainly stop him. He probably should've been less confrontational with her, but she can sense the depth of his conviction regardless of what he says.

"Please, just be careful," she finally says. "Don't search anywhere that's excessively dangerous, not alone."

"Don't worry, I'm not going to take risks. I'm going to find him. We're both coming home safe."

He can only hope that his determination will be enough.

Chapter End Notes

> somehow i got this chapter out in a reasonable timeframe despite the fact that my laptop broke (this happens to me a lot unfortunately). thank you my dear university for letting me loan a laptop to write abo mpreg on, this chapter is dedicated to you.
>
> i am going to try so hard to get the next chapter out in the next two weeks before silksong releases because that game is going to consume my life. i don't want to make you all wait super long for it since it's the most important one. hopefully i can manage it??

Chapter 7: amaranth

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Mydei wakes, he's nauseous.

Of course, the feeling is now all too familiar. It would almost be strange to wake without its sickly chill lingering in his gut and clinging to the back of his throat, though that isn't to suggest it's welcome.

He truly thought it would've vanished by now, so far into the second trimester. Taking a pill of Hyacine's medication every other night still eases it enough to prevent him from vomiting and allows him to forget his nausea for most of the day, but the supply in the bottle is dwindling. At this rate, it seems his morning sickness is bound to outlast the medicine.

His future seems unpleasant, to say the least. Nightmarish may be more apt of a descriptor. Certainly, imagining it does not make him feel any better. Even *with* the pills, his mornings are far from pleasant.

As is routine, Mydei lays on his back for the first few minutes of wakefulness, staring up at the temple's ruined ceiling and doing his best to breathe evenly through his nose. The child is squirming around inside of him, which isn't helping; since they first moved two weeks ago, they've begun a constant assault on his insides.

In hindsight, he should've anticipated this. Any child with two accomplished warriors for parents will be a feisty one. He supposes he prefers the movement to a lack of it, even if it sometimes bothers him.

Eventually, they still, and the nausea eases enough for him to clamber to his feet and properly start his day. He doesn't have much of a schedule to adhere to out here, but even so, he doesn't want to stall. Idle hands are his worst enemy.

A quick soak in the creek by his safe house is first on the docket, helping to shake off the last dredges of groginess and also dispel some of the nausea. It helps a fair amount, though his stomach still feels a bit touchy as he prepares a small, simple breakfast. Not eating will be worse in the long run, he reminds himself, as he chokes it down. He'll need abundant energy for what he has planned.

Clearing the Titankin from one of the largest temples in Janusopolis is the next great undertaking, and he's planned for it carefully. Now that he's reached the fifth month of pregnancy, he's been more fatigued and become less agile; the longer he waits to do this, the more weighed down he'll be.

Thankfully, after thoroughly scoping out the temple, he thinks he has a plan that won't require too much work or risk on his part. All it will take is some quick effort.

With a bag of supplies slung over his shoulder and a round of stretching behind him that does little to help the persistent twinge in his lower back, he begins the trek through the city. The decrepit streets once bustled with Titankin activity, but they're peaceful now; over the past month, the results of constant hunting have gone from negligible to unmistakable. Inevitably, monsters will move back in, but until then, passing refugees should be able to find some safety.

If even a single life is saved from his efforts, it will have been worth it. And for now, he enjoys the moment of calm before the inevitable storm.

Before he's even stepped through the broken-open doors of the temple, he's faced with a sizable group of Titankin loitering on the steps outside. Unfortunately--or fortunately--these ones will have to be dealt with by hand. He flexes his fingers, then allows them to curl into tight fists as his body falls into the dance of combat.

The single archer standing by the outskirks is his first target, grabbed by the arm and tossed into the main hoard, felling a few warriors and confusing the others. They're still hesitating, examining the archer's corpse, when Mydei descends upon them, crushing them with well-aimed punches.

It's a quick, brutal fight. Only one warrior even managed to swing at him, and they missed by a mile. Triumphant, he marches over their ruined, ichor-soaked bodies to where the temple awaits.

For once, he needs to employ some amount of stealth, lest he want to turn this simple mission into an arduous bloodbath. It will be a bloodbath regardless, but he doesn't plan on being an active participant.

It begins at the temple's center, where a massive brazier, still brimming with coals, lays cold and dead. Mydei passes through a network of side hallways to reach it, avoiding the Titankin he sees and silently dispatching the ones in his way. It's remarkably easy to behead them, he's found, so long as one pulls at the right angle and twists with enough force.

This temple has remained mostly intact, including its maze-like interior; despite coming through here multiple times, he still gets lost, stumbling across prayer rooms, vaults, and libraries he's never before found. It's more of a struggle than he'd like to admit, but he stumbles upon his destination eventually.

The central room is cavernous, and in the darkness, it seems to be endless, shadows stretching infinitely outward. From that yawning void, the sounds of shifting Titankin echo unnervingly, allowing one's mind to run wild in imagining just how many hundreds might lie in wait.

Mydei's afforded very little room for error in this endeavor.

His first, and only, goal: light the brazier. With the flint packed in his bag, it's theoretically an easy job, but there's no way to walk over to the brazier, not without drawing attention. So, the obvious--and tricky--solution is to light something on fire and toss it inside from a distance.

He trusts his aim, suboptimal conditions or not. The darkness isn't too much of a hindrance; a skylight over the brazier allows in just enough of the weak Evernight light to illuminate its metallic exterior. By his estimate, it's about fifty meters away, which his practiced arm can easily reach, so long as he has something solid to throw.

In his safe room, he found a crate of prepared torch heads, dusty but still functional. He's not sure what exactly constitutes them, but whatever tar is in the center of the cloth covering is weighty, and makes it excellent for this task. He fishes out the one he stowed in his bag along with the flint.

There's no use in hesitating. Striking the flint against a sharp edge of his gauntlet casts a shower of sparks across the torch head, which begins to smolder after some gentle exhales against its surface. He waits until a proper flame takes root--and not a second later--before cocking his arm back and sending the fireball sailing through the air, aim true, to land square in the brazier.

Much like insects, Titankin are drawn to the alluring glow of fire, seeking both its light and motion in darkness. As the flames in the brazier steadily grow, the beasts march from all corners of the room to the center to crowd around it.

And in the wavering light, with minds degraded by the Black Tide and many thousands of years of waiting, it takes very little for a packed crowd of Titankin to turn on each other. A sword pokes a back, a foot stomps on another, a fist knocks into a chest, and suddenly, everything is an enemy. Violence is slow to overtake the group, but confusion and the eagerness to fight after so much dormancy win out eventually. Soon enough, their blades cut friends like foe with the same programmed brutality. Ichor spills across the floor, gleaming in the firelight like molten gold. The cacophony of battle echoes up to the ceiling as prayers once did within these hallowed walls.

All Mydei needs to do is spectate, completely silent and still, making sure that no Titankin sees him as a target. Participation would be more interesting, but in these circumstances, he's perfectly fine with watching Nikador's creations reduce themselves to rubble.

He's not sure how long it takes for the bloodbath to end. The brazier still burns bright once silence overtakes the temple once more, revealing a mess of carnage across the floor and the last few stragglers--the victors. Mydei, of course, is the real victor, and he finishes them off in a few decisive strikes.

A satisfied smile tugs at his lips. That plan worked out even better than he could've imagined, and a glance at his pocket watch informs him that it's not even action hour yet.

He turns to the entryway, ready to return to the safe room--and instantly freezes.

Somebody's approaching. *Quickly* approaching.

"--Hello? Who's there?" the person shouts, and gods, oh dear gods, it's *Phainon.* Mydei scrambles back into the side hallway and locks himself in place, unwilling to attempt an escape when he could so easily be heard. He should be safe here; the brazier's light doesn't make it to this corner, and the acrid smoke covers up whatever traces of his scent he's left.

Of course, none of that will help if Phainon begins a thorough search.

"Hello? *Hello?"*

His voice is getting louder. He'll be in the central room in seconds. Damnit, why is he back in Janusopolis again? The others should be searching for him elsewhere, they must've ruled out this area by now. Was he just passing through the city when he saw the brazier light up? The temple is elevated and open to the outside on one end, it might be visible from miles away--and godsdamnit, why didn't Mydei consider that risk?

It's too late. There's no point in regretting the mistakes he's already made.

Mydei hears the entryway doors slam open. A moment later, Phainon appears from the darkness, sprinting full-speed toward the brazier. The vast room feels infinitely smaller now. Closer and closer he draws, millisecond by millisecond. Time itself seems to slow. Adrenaline burns through Mydei's limbs like wildfire. A hand rests atop his abdomen, guarding the secret he may have failed to keep.

Is it over?

"*Hello, who's*--what in the--"

Before Phainon can finish his question, he trips on a Titankin's corpse.

It's not a terrible fall; he knows not to break it with his hands and lets himself land on his chest instead. Mydei hears his breath get knocked out in a loud gasp. And that should be the worst of it, beside some possible bruising later on.

He's fine, he shouldn't even be phased.

But he doesn't get up.

Instead, he slowly drags his knees under himself and braces his forearms against the ground, putting him in a low hunch. He remains there at the foot of the brazier, trembling slightly, heaving for air. His breaths start to sound shaky, then hitching, and he's suddenly sobbing.

One arm raises enough for him to slam his fist against the ground. "... Godsdamnit... I'm so... I'm so fucking useless, I can't do it, I can't fucking do it..."

Mydei grits his teeth.

"... Mydei... I'm so--... so fucking s-sorry," he chokes out, barely able to speak through his sobs, "I failed you... failed and... should've..."

Again, his fist slams down. This time, the tile cracks.

"I love you so much, *please--"*

An inhale so rough he gags--

"--come back, I'll explain everything, I didn't mean to scare you, I love--"

Slam--

"--both of you--"

And Mydei's world stills.

Both of you?

He must've misheard. Phainon doesn't know, he *can't* know. He must mean something else.

Mydei's ears strain, waiting for more, *anything* to save him from the precipice of collapse.

The fire crackles, and Phainon just sobs, choking on air, broken and raw, a heap of white on the dirty ground, Titankin ichor soaking into his sleeves and staining his hands, face smeared with tears and snot, reduced from a Deliverer to a man, just a man, desperately begging for what he's lost.

Mydei can't breathe. It's too terrible, and it's his fault, all of this suffering wrought for a lie that may have been pointless.

"... Our child... I failed you, too."

And there it is.

Phainon knows.

What is there left to do?

Perhaps he should just step out and end this farce. It's a terrifying thought. To face Phainon now--he doesn't think he can bear it. What he wants to do is run, hide, bury himself in the ground so he doesn't have to face the consequences of this terrible and meaningless thing he's done to the person he loves so dearly.

But he isn't afforded a choice. The universe makes one for him, because from the darkness a furiae praetor emerges, presumably alerted by Phainon's noisiness or the burning brazier. Phainon himself is unaware of its approach, still hunched over and lost in his own grief.

Its sword begins to rise, prepared to fall upon Phainon's unguarded back.

Mydei leaps forward to meet it.

In bounding strides, he crosses the room, reaching the praetor in a second. His forearms brace together, raised to catch the broadsword's downswing--the crash is deafening, the blow forceful enough to crack the blade and send Mydei skidding backwards.

Phainon makes a sound behind him, some sort of strangled gasp caught in a sob. Mydei forces himself to ignore him and begins his assault upon the Titankin, lunging forward to strike its body. It blocks with its free arm; the entire forearm is blasted off from the force, but it seems unbothered by the loss.

Its broadsword swings again, this time at Mydei. He ducks under and dives to its backside, aiming an uppercut at the vulnerable junction between its legs. Unlike a living creature, it has no sensitive organs there, but it's still a good way to throw it off-balance. It stumbles, barely managing to remain upright, and Mydei strikes again, fist punching through its lower back. He lingers inside for a moment to send a burst of crystal out from his palm, shredding through its internal stone structures.

Of course, such a large Titankin can't be felled with just one hit. When Mydei yanks his hand free, the gush of ichor that follows isn't nearly enough to bleed it dry. He manages another strike at its upper back before he has to dodge, easily sidestepping the slanted arc of the broadsword. As it attempts to recover, he takes the opportunity to kick at one of its legs; he doesn't anticipate it falling, but it seems he nailed it at the right angle.

Cracks streak across its body as it slams against the ground. He stomps through its back with one foot, and it fully shatters, the broken pieces of its body and its lifeblood joining the carnage of its comrades around it.

But Mydei isn't looking at it anymore.

Phainon has risen from his hunch. His eyes are no longer downcast; he stares up at Mydei with a slack jaw as if he's one of the Titans themselves descended from the heavens, shock and awe and something unreadable all mixing together in his expression.

The distance between them is less than ten meters, but Mydei cannot force himself to cross it. He can't move at all, even when Phainon gets to his feet and the wild part of his mind once again screams at him to run.

But Mydei doesn't want to run anymore. Under the stink of ichor and coal, he can smell Phainon, and he knows he's home.

He counts the paces that Phainon takes to reach him, keeping his gaze fixed at his approaching boots instead of his face. Footsteps ring in his ears. And then, those boots are right in front of him, and he has to look up, look into those searing blue eyes, look at that beautiful face he's missed so dearly.

"... Mydei," Phainon whispers, almost as if he's afraid. A hand darts out tentatively, and Mydei doesn't shy away as it rests upon his left shoulder. He's wearing his himation, but through the thick fabric, he can feel the heat of his palm.

"You're here, you're okay."

And something about the way he says it, with so much care, like nothing else in the world matters--it finally breaks the dam. Mydei grabs him and Phainon's grabbing him back, two sets of arms desperately tangling and squeezing them together so tightly it hurts, but neither of them try to pull away. Phainon's face is buried in the side of his neck; Mydei feels his shuddering inhale against his own chest.

"Phainon, I'm sorry," he manages, eyes burning with tears he'll never be able to shed, "I shouldn't have left."

"Don't apologize, it's not your fault. I should've... done it all differently," he chokes out. "I made you think... Titans, I don't know what I made you think, exactly, but you thought I wouldn't care for them--for our child."

I was just so scared to lose you, he wants to explain, but it lodges in the back of his throat. He still can't say what matters most.

"You said you didn't want to have a family with me," is what he says instead. It sounds accusatory and he hates it. He can only hope that Phainon

will read between the lines like he always has in the past.

Because how could Mydei risk losing the one person who has dealt with him, in all his bluntness and stubbornness and roughness, and loved him not in spite of it, but because of it? However small that chance might've been--how impossible it really was--he couldn't allow it.

And gods, does he know how stupid it was. It's hard to feel relief when the guilt is busy gnawing a hole through his heart.

"I was afraid back then, just afraid," Phainon shakily assures him, "I wouldn't have been angry, and I'm certainly not angry now, not about our child. I can't say I'm not upset with you for not telling me, but... I think I understand why you did, and I'm sorry."

"... You know I trust you. The blame doesn't lie with you," he murmurs.

Phainon sniffles, and hugs him a bit tighter. "I don't want to blame you, either. The world has been so cruel to you. I want to be at least one good part of it, if you'll let me. Just tell me when you're hurting and I'll help you, *always."*

"Even when I make it difficult?"

"Of course," he insists, "loving you is never difficult. You're the easiest person in the world to love, Mydeimos."

And Mydei doesn't have another argument left. They'll need to talk about this more, so much more, but he can't, not right now. The adrenaline's worn off and exhaustion has settled not just in his bones but his mind. Discussing consequential matters is beyond him.

So, he kisses Phainon instead, slow and gentle. It has been far too long since the last one and Mydei can only regret the wait. He melts into the touch, the warmth and wetness of it, the *realness* of Phainon's mouth against his own, and Phainon eagerly accepts him.

It feels just as it did before, not stilted or forced. Their bond remains strong, shaken but not irreparably, and what a comfort it is to know that, despite all his terrible flaws, Phainon will still love him the same. Perhaps he doesn't deserve such forgiveness--he feels that he doesn't--but he's selfish enough to accept it.

Phainon deepens the kiss. Mydei wants to reciprocate, but a part of him, newly awakened by hormones, aches for so much more; going further will ruin him, and he knows he shouldn't. Instead, he pulls back to breathe, though he slots their fingers together as a promise, assuring him that there won't be any more running.

"Let's go back to Okhema."

In the darkness, Phainon's smile shines as bright as the blazing sun.

They stop by Mydei's safe room first to gather his things. Phainon helps, though not much, as he keeps stopping to stare at him and the surroundings. Mydei doesn't care enough to berate him; it's not as if he has much to pack, the lack of aid is inconsequential. Phainon does insist on carrying his bag, which Mydei allows without protest.

It's clear that he has something else to say, but he doesn't voice it until they're well on their way back to Okhema.

"Do your feet hurt, or your legs?" he first asks, a bit awkwardly.

"Not enough to bother me."

"You're certain? We can slow our pace if you want, I don't mind. I'll even carry you."

Mydei can only sigh at Phainon's pleading, wide-eyed stare; he'd be frustrated if anybody else was so persistent, but somehow, he finds this all quite endearing.

"It really is fine," he insists. "I only care about reaching Okhema as quickly as possible."

"Okay... I just want to take care of you, and I know being pregnant is hard..."

"It isn't so taxing for me. I must imagine that my body lessens the strain, just as it eases my other aches and pains. On that front, there isn't much to be done."

A pause.

"You were going to spend the whole pregnancy out here, weren't you? And you were going to give birth alone?"

The sudden question catches him off-guard, so much so that he almost refuses to answer. But he considers it for a moment, and decides to offer a nod, nothing more, to let Phainon process it on his own.

They lapse into comfortable-enough silence, though for the rest of the journey back, Mydei's expecting him to say something else on the matter. He doesn't, and his mouth stays shut until they're approaching the city gates, when one of the guards--Mydei recognizes him as Kebes, one of the younger Kremnoans--breaks from his post to run toward them.

"Prince Mydeimos! You're back!" he cries. His youth combined with the amount of time spent in Okhema means he's not very stoic, and his discipline is somewhat lacking, though Mydei has no current desire to scold him. Just this once, it's fair to let it slide.

"Indeed, all thanks to the Deliverer himself."

"All thanks? There's no need to be facetious," Phainon protests.

"I'm being serious, though I'll take it back if you don't believe me."

Kebes laughs in delight. "I see you're both in good spirits! What excellent news this is! I'll go tell the Kremnoans, we must throw a feast to celebrate your return, perhaps even a festival."

"I appreciate the enthusiasm, but you must attend to your post. I'll see the Kremnoans myself."

"Ah, of course, of course..."

Mydei bids the young guard farewell, and he and Phainon pass through the gates into the city proper. A month is not a particularly long time to be away, but it feels as if eons have passed since he last walked through these streets. The hustle and bustle of ordinary life is just as it was before, and oddly enough, he finds that all the noise lifts his spirits.

The noise only increases as they pass, citizens pointing and chattering and brandishing their teleslates to photograph. Mydei gives a few awkward waves because Phainon insists, saying it will reassure them that all is well, though he's not sure his appearance is in any way reassuring. From the few glimpses of himself he's gotten in mirrors scattered about Janusopolis, he looks very much like a man that's been living in the wild.

He can only imagine how much of a stir his disappearance caused, and his return will only fuel more speculation. If the people's curiosity is to be sated, he'll have to come up with a good story, one that divulges just enough truth to keep it believable while keeping his own turmoil private. It's a tall order, but a necessary one. An unfortunate part of being a Chrysos Heir is that he must manage his image, lest he make the others of his rank look bad.

He can work it out later. His mind is too fried to conjure up that good story, or anything else, really. He'd love to march right back to his chambers and fall asleep within Phainon's embrace, but that will have to wait.

"Go tell Lady Aglaea that I'm back. I'll join you shortly, I just have to speak with Krateros first."

Phainon nods. "I believe she's at the Mamoreal Palace, but if not, I'll send you the meeting place... Do you have your teleslate with you?"

"I believe it's in my bag. Hand it over, let me check."

Mydei spent so much time with a non-functioning teleslate, stuck outside of the reaches of Aglaea's threads, that he almost forgot it existed. Indeed, it *is* buried at the bottom of his bag, almost out of charge, but with enough to make it to the end of the day, so long as he checks it sparingly. He ignores the wall of missed messages that greet him and pockets it before embarking on his mission to find Krateros.

At this hour, he's certain his master will be supervising the training grounds, and he's correct. He's leaning against a wall, arms crossed, watching as a line of soldiers practice footwork drills. His expression is as impassive as ever, until he notices Mydei's approach, of course.

"Young lord, you--!" He nearly chokes on his own words, and pauses to clear his throat forcefully, continuing with a bit more restraint. "You've returned to Okhema, I see. Welcome back, I'm pleased to see you in... what I hope is good health."

Mydei unconsciously reaches up to comb through his hair, cringing when his fingers catch on thick tangles. "I'm well. I haven't had access to a proper bath in a while, so excuse my appearance. Coming to see you felt more important than freshening up."

"It matters little to me, I only care to know where in the world you went."

"I was in Janusopolis of my own volition. Though it pains me to admit, I must confess that I was hiding... though not without reason. There is something I must tell you, if we can go somewhere more secluded."

Krateros turns to the soldiers, still practicing away and unaware of Mydei's presence. "Stand down, our prince has returned! You're dismissed for the day, vacate the training grounds posthaste."

Perhaps due to the fact that they're under the watchful eye of Krateros, the soldiers do not crowd around him, and obediently file out, though Mydei picks up their excited comments. The news will be spread through the entire district within a quint. He can already imagine the feast they'll throw in celebration; it will be a welcome affair to see his people so joyful.

He's confident that they did well without him, but he can't help but wonder exactly how well. Since the Kremnoan detachment was formed around him, he's always worried for them, as a prince and a person both. After all, there is much more to leadership than the diplomacy he carries out with the Council or his general commands. The detachment is far more than an army, it is a group of refugees foremost, and as well established as they may be in Okhema, prejudice haunts them still.

Over millennia, the Kremnoans have had a diverse line of rulers, an unfortunate number of them being infamous for their cruelty, so much so that *cruel* is the adjective most often associated with his people. Mydei's aware that his own efforts are little more than a drop in the ocean--culture and the perception of it are both difficult to change--but that doesn't stop him from trying to lead with kindness. He's learned enough history to recognize that, in the long run, it is much better to be loved than feared.

"What do you wish to discuss?" Krateros asks, tearing Mydei away from his thoughts. His voice and expression have softened, just enough to encourage some vulnerability.

"It is a somewhat complicated situation, and I hope you understand that I don't wish to divulge every detail. What matters most is that... Well, I am with child."

"You are--!"

Again, he clears his throat. "By Nikador, you've brought much excitement to my day. A child! What a blessing, indeed. How long until their birth?"

"I have recently passed the fifth month."

Without the himation on, Krateros could've likely discerned that himself. His pregnancy is obvious in his regular clothing worn underneath it, but not severe enough to make a bump in the heavy fabric.

"And this child was conceived from the union between you and Lord Phainon, yes?" he asks, then continues without waiting for an answer. "Perhaps I should've anticipated such an outcome. You two have already

devoted yourselves to each other, and strife has strengthened your bond over the years... All the greatest rulers of Kremnos have done the same.

"But you seem so troubled, young lord. Does this outcome not please you?"

"It isn't the child that troubles me--I am happy to bear them. It is the fact of fatherhood, the burden of having a family, the... the *fear* of what may come. I know you've long insisted I look past such worries, especially ones so trivial, but I couldn't. Instead, I took the coward's path, and fled."

The admission brings him much shame, and he expects Krateros's ire to be mercilessly brought upon him. However, no fury overtakes his master's expression--no, a great sadness does instead, one so profound that Mydei can only wait for him to finally break the long stretch of silence between them.

His voice is rough when he finally speaks. "Mydeimos, my boy... The things you have suffered in your short life are well beyond what I can fathom. It is partially my own fault that you were ripped from your mother's arms before you were even weaned--that such unimaginable cruelty was wrought upon a babe. And when you were liberated from the sea, I placed the charge of patricide upon your shoulders before your first decade of life. You couldn't have a normal childhood, despite your mother's wish for you to know peace... I failed her, in many ways, and I failed you.

"To think that somebody like you could ever be expected to forget their fear would be stupid, and I am no fool. You are braver than I have ever been, perhaps than any Kremnoan has ever been, in spite of all that darkness you face.

"If I were to call you a coward for fleeing, then so am I. Do you believe me to be one?"

"... No, I do not. You have always been brave in my eyes."

"Then you are brave too, and I cast no judgement upon you. Did you err? Perhaps, but you have returned, and your actions prove your determination to make things right. That is all I have to say on the matter, beyond my

congratulations for you and your mate. It pleases me greatly to know you'll have a family soon. Our people will certainly be overjoyed."

"Please do not inform them yet, I'd like to make a proper announcement myself," Mydei hurries to say.

And just like that, the tension dissipates. "You think I have loose lips? *Hmph,* of course none shall know unless you give the word, that goes without saying."

"The confirmation is only for my own peace of mind, I don't wish to butt heads with you. I've always seen you as a reliable confidant."

"As you should. Now, if this matter is settled, you should be off. I'm certain your mate wishes to spend time with you," he says, with a slight smile.

"You seem to have developed some fondness for Lord Phainon. You've always said he wastes my time, at least in the past."

Krateros breaks eye contact for a fraction of a second, almost as if he's embarrassed. "Ah, that was all a test to ensure you really were dedicated to him. A future king cannot pick their consort in haste. I'm quite certain now that you've chosen correctly, and he has proven himself worthy to stand beside you--his possessiveness over you is a very strong attribute."

"Possessive? I would not describe him as such."

"He's always by your side, is he not? He knows himself that he is the only one fit for that role, and he takes it seriously. Now, off you go, don't waste any more time. Your heart and body must both be awaiting his own."

"It's unnecessary to phrase it like that," Mydei mutters, feeling his face heat up. "But if you insist, I shall take my leave."

Despite Krateros's parting words, Mydei does not get to spend much time at all with Phainon for the rest of the day. They meet with Aglaea together, but Phainon says very little the whole time, as she's much more interested in

asking Mydei questions. She tries to keep it brief, though the nature of such a meeting means it unfortunately runs for two quints, and she only ends it because he begins to have trouble keeping his eyes open.

"I must apologize," he mutters, while rubbing his hands across his face. "I don't wish to insinuate I'm bored by our conversation."

"I should apologize for exhausting you. I'll be more considerate of your pregnancy going forward. I can't guarantee there won't be any more meetings with the council--even the Titans don't have the power to prevent those--but I'll lighten your workload. Make sure to get plenty of rest."

"... Thank you, Lady Aglaea."

Phainon takes him right to his own chambers after that, per Mydei's request. He wants to lie in a bed that smells like his alpha, preferably *with* his alpha, but Phainon doesn't have the time to spare.

"I'll be back by curtain-fall hour, I swear it. I've just got to talk to Castorice, and return these supplies... and help Theodoros since I *did* promise to do that before I dropped everything to go find you... *and--"*

"Just go do it, the less time you spend explaining the sooner you can return."

In the face of his impatience, Phainon all but sprints from the room with a rushed apology halfway off his lips. Mydei locks the door behind him, then turns to look at his room; somehow, it has gotten even messier since he last saw it. Books are piled up in the corners and his desk is heaped with scrolls. Mydei nearly trips on a massive, rolled-up map of Amphoreus left at the foot of the bed as he tries to make his way to the washroom.

The washroom itself, at least, is tidy. It's actually a bit sparse, as it always has been. Phainon doesn't have a varied collection of soaps and oils, which Mydei has spent much of their relationship lamenting. *After spending the night in your chambers, how am I meant to make myself presentable with only pine tar soap*--that was his most common complaint, repeated until he

finally got him to buy some proper hair products and moisturizer, though with only one choice for each.

It's better than nothing, and certainly enough for a proper bath. To wash in hot water again after so many dips in that cold creek is an almost unbelievable experience. He delights in scrubbing every centimeter of his body and carefully detangling his hair, uncaring of how long it takes.

The child seems to enjoy it too, since they actually cease their squirming for once, at least until he exits the tub. As he towels himself off, they start back up, and he can only sigh. He's so exhausted that he reckons he'll be able to sleep in spite of the disturbance.

Before he slips into Phainon's bed, he considers redressing, but decides against it. He wants to have the scent-soaked linens against his bare skin; hopefully, it will help to appease his instincts. Regardless, all his clean clothes are in his own chambers, and he's not interested in making the trip over, no matter how short.

So, he curls up underneath the sheets, pressing the upper edge of them against his nose as he drifts off to fill it with Phainon's scent, so fresh and strong and comforting. No other alpha has the same softness to theirs, that gentle undertone that has always caused Mydei to relax, unconsciously, into its embrace.

He's gone in an instant, lulled into a deep and dreamless sleep, though not so deep that he doesn't stir when the door is unlocked. Unsure of how much time has passed, he blinks his eyes open to watch Phainon step inside.

"I was trying to be quiet, did I wake you?" he asks, sheepish.

"You did, but it's alright," he says, then almost without thinking, continues, "I wished to speak with you anyway."

He can keep putting it off, but why not do it now? If he keeps waiting for a better time, then he may just keep running until it catches up with him for good.

So, in the comfort of a soft bed, with his lover beside him, Mydei finally begins to explain. His fears and doubts are laid bare, the things that drove him away, the darkness that has haunted him since his earliest memories of the sea, the story of the prophecy that doomed him at birth. Phainon knows some of it, but not all of it, not the sordid depths that until this point Mydei has preferred to ignore. He no longer wishes to pretend it doesn't affect him--if it didn't, he wouldn't have fled.

And that was the culmination of it all: his plan to birth the child in secret and return with them, and to raise them under the guise of them being an orphaned babe found out in the Evernight, thus preventing Phainon from feeling obligated to do anything.

It brings him great shame to say it aloud to the very person it insults, but he knows he must. Even if he didn't intend for it to cause harm, that doesn't change the reality of what happened, and he cannot take away the pain he made Phainon feel.

Phainon doesn't hold it against him. He seems eager to clear up every misunderstanding, explaining why he himself was so afraid of fatherhood, and why he chose avoidance over confrontation. When he speaks of the obsession that overtook him upon Mydei's disappearance, he reveals how he learned of the child he'd sired, how their bond ran so deep it ensnared their biology. Again, Mydei realizes he never had anything to fear; he isn't sure when his regret will fade, if ever.

Now, at least, the wounds can begin to heal. Once all is said, the relief is far stronger than any guilt, and Mydei basks in it.

All is said, perhaps, except for one thing.

"Let me see you, Mydei," Phainon says quietly, breaking the brief silence that had settled between them. Their entire conversation was conducted with Mydei still lying beneath the sheets and Phainon seated beside him on the edge of the mattress, and he hovers over him now, expression pleading.

It should be a simple request. Mydei can't recall ever feeling self-conscious in his life, at least over his physique. Perhaps when he was a teenager and

was awkwardly growing into his body there was a bit of discontentment, but he had far greater troubles than his lankiness or oily skin, and he quickly stopped caring.

But now, a new part of him worries that Phainon won't like what he sees, that he'll feel disgust at the softness of his body in his chest and hips, and the swell of his once-rigid abdomen. He knows he shouldn't be, but he hesitates anyway, leaving the sheets still drawn up, and Phainon notices, as he always does.

"What's wrong?"

"My body, it's... different," he says stupidly, because of course it is.

"You know I don't care, I'll think you're beautiful no matter how you look. And I know you're beautiful right now. You don't have to show me yet, but--"

Mydei pulls the sheets down. He watches Phainon expression change to something unreadable as his eyes wander across his exposed skin, repressing the urge to shiver. He doesn't think he's being scrutinized, but it almost feels like it, until Phainon's hands reach to trail down his sides, and he knows with certainty that he's being worshipped.

He's so careful with his touches, as if he fears Mydei might vanish. Even when he moves to straddle him, seated atop his thighs, his fingers continue their delicate mapping, making no move to do anything else. The only place he lingers is atop his abdomen, where he places both palms flat to cradle its swell, and Mydei feels as if he can't breathe.

"Have they moved yet?" he asks, voice shaky. He's crying, Mydei realizes belatedly, and he reaches up to wipe the tears rolling down his cheeks.

"They seem to move at all hours, but they're still right now. Perhaps you soothed them," he replies quietly.

Phainon laughs wetly. "Of course they're so active, of course our ch-child... they're... Gods, I can't... I can't believe we're having a baby, Mydei. I love

you so much."

"Are you going to be this sappy for the entire pregnancy?"

"Yes, I can't help it. You're so perfect, you deserve all the affection I can possibly give you. I'll make up for all the time we lost."

Mydei grabs his shirt collar and yanks him down for a desperate kiss, and holds him there until his chest burns. Phainon is the one to break it, gasping for air, a pathetic whine building in his throat, one muffled by Mydei's lips when he grabs the back of his head and pulls him in again.

"Then make up for it," he pants, "show me how good you can be. Give it all to me."

Despite his earlier plans, neither of them end up getting much sleep that curtain-fall hour.

Chapter End Notes

> posted just in time for the update. barely. i try so hard to post quickly but being a slow writer + engineering major means that is an unachievable dream. silksong release did not help with that. i don't like having more than a month between updates but it happens sometimes. at least the chapter was long to make up for it!! i was gonna have them fuck also but that would make it way too long and also it would've taken me like another three weeks to write. they'll do it in the next one i promise.
>
> also the chapter count is gonna increase again. i'm thinking 10 chapters but that still isn't set in stone, i do have an outline for this fic but i keep adding more stuff to it. phaidei is an endless fountain of ideas.

Chapter 8: larch

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Settling back into the routine of ordinary life is remarkably easy.

To have Mydei around again feels so natural that Phainon isn't at all disoriented when he wakes up next to him each morning. No matter the positions they fall asleep in, they always end up in a tangle, clinging with arms and legs, sharing in warmth and scent. The alpha in him is perfectly satisfied; the rest of him is delighted. Mydei's back, and the world is right once more.

Perhaps the only thing that's changed is how tightly Phainon holds onto him in those sleepy moments of dawn. He isn't something to be taken for granted. Everything in life is fleeting, but by the gods is Phainon going to try to make this last forever, in whatever way he can.

Their schedules are busy, even busier than before, but they still make time for each other. They sit together in shared meetings and read over Council decrees side by side. They train--only after Mydei assures him the exertion is not harmful--and get lunch when they have the time for it. They go on walks through the city and speak with passerbys as the day winds down.

All is as it once was--*almost,* anyway, because there is one glaring difference that *is* quite disorienting.

Phainon never truly imagined himself as a father; beyond the fear it brought him, he never thought he'd have the opportunity. Warriors as prolific as himself don't think of much beyond their duty. His body is branded with the gold of Flamechase, longing for the peace he was born into yet knowing battle much more intimately. It was always his destiny, he thought, to cast aside his own desires, his own self, to become a vessel for the world's hope.

But now, Mydei is pregnant. It's an unimaginable truth that cannot be denied. Phainon looks at him and can't possibly ignore the growing swell of his abdomen, can't ignore the faintest *tap-tap-tap* against his palms when he rests them against it, can't ignore the way Mydei instinctively guards it with his hands because he knows there's something inside to protect--and it's too much. Fatherhood is barreling towards them, and Mydei seems so well-adjusted while Phainon feels like he's drowning.

They're going to have a child. A precious, fragile life that is theirs to cherish. Phainon loves both them and their father so much that he wonders if his heart might collapse from the weight of it.

When they're apart, he worries. Every rational part of him knows that Mydei is more than capable of taking care of himself, but there's another part of him, something deeper and primal, that aches with fear. Once they part in the mornings, only the sight of Mydei, not even his scent, are enough to appease him. So, Phainon copes with this issue by not really coping at all, and instead drags Mydei to the baths as early in the evening as he can. He gets away with it, somehow. The mild waters in the Heroes' baths are safe for the babe, and Mydei occasionally mentions his aching joints, so the frequent trips are amenable to them both. They can spend parting hour just as they used to, lounging side-by-side and recounting the events of the day.

It is a week later, during one of these baths, that Mydei brings up the feast.

"The Kremnoans are hosting a celebration three days from now," he says, with his eyes still closed, as if he's half-asleep. Phainon, who *was* half-asleep, startles at his words.

"Uh... yeah, a celebration..." he mumbles, cutting himself off with a yawn. He really wants to pay attention to what Mydei's saying, but he's so pleasantly warm and sleepy, he might just drift back off--

"I'd like you to attend it with me. It's time I officially proclaim you as my partner and announce our coming child."

"Time to--but aren't you keeping them a secret?"

Though Mydei never explicitly mentioned any plan to hide the pregnancy, he's continued to wear a himation over his usual garb, so Phainon didn't know what to think. He's been meaning to ask, but he's been so busy, and so fixated on other matters, that it has continually slipped his mind.

"I have been, but it has been a month since the quickening, which means it's now the customary time to tell family and friends. Do you know *anything* about Kremnoan culture?" Mydei asks, cracking one eye open to glare at him.

"I do, you know I do! I just never researched anything in this *particular* area, since I never imagined it'd apply to me. I assumed you were hiding it so the Council wouldn't find out... which I feel seems fair. We both agreed we'd keep our relationship private for the same reason."

Through a rather unfortunate incident in the baths and Phainon accidentally running his mouth while tipsy, the other Chrysos Heirs know that they're lovers, but the general populace remains in the dark. He's heard plenty of speculation over the years, though with no hard evidence, the rumors have remained quiet enough to be ignored. It was never his preference to hide something like this--he's found it difficult to not proclaim his love from the rooftops--but it seemed to be Mydei's preference, and Phainon would do anything for him. If he wants to let the world know, he'll find no resistance from his lover.

Mydei shrugs in response to his words, sending ripples across the water's quiet surface. "They'll be bothersome, but they always are. It makes no difference to me. It is the right of my people to know of their heir... and royal consort, I suppose that's what you are... which is far more important than anything else. Do you not agree?"

"No, of course I agree. I've been wanting to tell other people myself, but I was waiting for your permission. After all, it's your body, at the end of the day. You're going to be the one getting all the attention once word spreads."

"Whatever form that attention takes, I can certainly handle it."

Phainon leans to the side enough to comfortably slip his arm across Mydei's shoulder, mostly as a reassurance for himself. "I'm sure you can, but let me know if anybody bothers you too much. You know I'll take care of them."

"Hmph, you really are protective, aren't you," he scoffs, with a fond smile.

"How could I not be? I love you, and you're carrying our child right now--there is much to be protected. You're the strongest person I've ever met, but even you are fallible. I'll always be here to watch your back if you stumble."

Mydei's features, already pink from the bath, flush darker, and he quickly looks away. Statements which feel so common to Phainon can be the things to fluster him the most. Usually, it's the cultural divide; it has never served as a real hindrance, but some words don't have the intended effect. This time, at least, Phainon doesn't see any issues with the results.

"You never answered my request. Will you come to the celebration or not?"

He accepts the change in subject without protest. "I certainly will--I wouldn't miss it for the world. Just tell me the time, I'll make sure my schedule's clear."

"The festivities will begin at the commencement of action hour. We'll go to the mess hall together, I need to ensure you're dressed properly beforehand. Only the Fates know what sort of outfit you'd conjure up if left to your own devices."

"If you insist," he says, knowing he doesn't have much of a defense. Aglaea's either designed or approved most of the clothes in his wardrobe, so he doesn't think he can make a fool of himself anymore, and yet he still isn't trusted.

Mydei seems content with his response, and they lapse back into silence once more; however, Phainon's mind doesn't quiet back down.

They'll be announcing their relationship in three short days. Gods, what will everyone think? He doesn't care much for their opinions of himself, but of *Mydei*, he cares much more. There are plenty of people who look down

upon pregnant, unmated omegas--as if the alpha or beta doesn't share just as much responsibility--and that compounds upon the existing contempt for Kremnoans. It's impossible to *not* worry about what sort of hatred will be lobbed his way.

Is there anything Phainon can do to prevent at least some of it? Of course, there certainly is, and it's something he's wanted to do since he and Mydei first laid together, before their relationship was defined and was instead a strange friendship with stilted, desperate tangles after sparring, when neither of them knew what to do about the tension that simmered between them, as two people so unexperienced in matters of romance. Phainon would look at the tantalizing skin on the sides of his neck and *imagine,* but he never *acted.* In the beginning, it wasn't realistic to dream of such a thing, and now--he doesn't know.

Is now the time to broach such a topic? Perhaps not, but if he keeps putting it off he'll never end up doing it, and that sounds worse than the alternative.

As they prepare for bed, he finally decides he'll ask.

"Do you think the Kremnoans will judge us?"

The moment the question leaves his mouth, he regrets it. Could he at least have waited until tomorrow, when he'll be dressed properly instead of wearing nothing but his boxers with little seals on them? Well, it's too late to take it back.

Mydei pauses in the middle of undoing his braid. "Judge us for what?"

"Having a child without being mated."

"You worry too much," he says in lieu of an answer, and Phainon huffs.

"Just answer the question, please?"

"I think it's something you can deduce on your own, but if you insist. The perception is the same as the perception of having a child out of wedlock. And you're aware of how common marriage is between Kremnoans?"

"Almost unheard of, yes, I know."

"Then you also understand the reason. Why form a bond even stronger than marriage, one carried for the rest of one's life, when your mate may die many years before you, leaving you burdened with untreatable phantom pain? To many, the choice is obvious.

"Though times have changed since we settled in Okhema, the custom still holds. A couple only chooses to bond when their love is strong beyond measure."

"That's good, then. At least you don't have to deal with your own people judging you."

"You really do worry too much. Whatever judgement I face has no bearing on my own thoughts."

"But Mydei, you know how a lot of the Okhemans will act when they find out. You're going to get hounded and I'm supposed to, what, just watch? You shouldn't have to endure any of that nonsense, no matter how much you think you can take."

"I understand, but I can't think of what you can do beyond watching. Some things are inevitable, and I'd rather not waste time considering what-ifs. Accepting reality is far easier in the long run."

"... Do you think we could bond?"

Mydei finishes letting down his hair before he responds. Phainon watches his deft fingers, so slim and nimble without the gauntlets, comb through the loose strands.

"We could," he answers simply. "The possibility exists."

"But--but Mydei, do you really want to? I want to, I really do," he confesses, no longer able to hold back. "I want to claim you, I want you to claim me, I want to know I'm yours and you're mine forever. Not just because the world expects it, but because I love you."

"All of this questioning was just your elaborate method to ask if you could bite me, wasn't it? I should've guessed from the beginning."

"I suppose it was..."

Mydei reaches out to grab his wrist, yanking him toward the bed in one swift motion. He stumbles, half-falling onto the mattress with only Mydei to support him, and before he can even react, he's already being flipped to face the ceiling, Mydei straddling him, seated firmly on his crotch. Phainon makes a strangled sound, a bit shocked but mostly aroused, because *gods* how can he not be?

"Then do it."

It's a simple command, in theory. If he were any other alpha, maybe he'd know exactly what bonding entailed, but he *doesn't.* There must be more to it than just biting a scent gland, right? Mydei definitely wants to have sex, and that must be part of it; should he just do what he always does, or be extra romantic, or more rough, or do something unique, or--

Before he can decide, Mydei's leaning down to kiss him while grinding down with his hips, and he loses his train of thought. What remains is a steadily mounting anxiety that makes it difficult to concentrate on what *should* be his focus.

"I know you're overthinking," Mydei pulls back to say just as Phainon's lungs are begging for air, and he whimpers when a hand palms his flaccid cock through his briefs. "You'll never be able to fuck me with this. You're usually so eager to be inside me."

Phainon would be embarrassed, but he's more affronted than anything. "Just give me a minute, can't we take it slow today?"

"Perhaps I'd have the patience to go slow if you hadn't gone and gotten me pregnant. I spend every waking moment tormented by thoughts of you, how... how *badly* my body desires you, and you're trying to make me *wait?"* he growls, real frustration bleeding into his words.

For some reason, that alone is enough to get his cock to stir, anxiety be damned. It's a bit mortifying, at least to the reasonable part of his brain; Mydei being pregnant shouldn't turn him on so much, but it *does*, and whatever part of his brain has those desires is a lot louder in this moment, because he's already pulling Mydei's briefs down without thinking about it.

"The things you say..." he mutters, mostly to himself.

"Have I finally managed to entice you?" Mydei asks, as he watches himself be undressed, shifting when necessary to facilitate the process.

"Of course I'm enticed, have you seen yourself? I just... I'm not exactly sure how to do this."

"I'm sure you can figure it out, just--*hah*, be quick."

His words falter when Phainon reaches his hand between his thighs, and dear gods, his impatience is understandable. Has he been this swollen and slick for the entire day, for *multiple days?*

"If you wanted me so much, you could've asked earlier," Phainon comments, easily slipping two fingers into his cunt, which is already relaxed enough for far more. "I don't want you to suffer when I'm right here."

"You wouldn't be able to keep up."

"Is that a challenge? I think you'll find that I can."

Mydei laughs at that, actually *laughs*, as he begins to fuck himself on Phainon's hand. "You're already failing. The gall of you to make me do all the work while I'm pregnant is pathetic."

This man knows exactly what he's doing, Phainon thinks, *to get what he wants.* He wants Phainon to get competitive, to fight back, to be *rough,* and of course he'll get that. His pleasure comes first, always.

Phainon flips their positions in an instant, pinning Mydei beneath him. He's aware he hasn't gained any control--if Mydei didn't allow it, he wouldn't

have been able to do manage such a clean maneuver--but there's an illusion of power, and gods, Phainon will never get over the thrill of looking down at *the* Kremnoan crown prince, made pliant by desire and trust. He seems more radiant than ever, pregnancy softening him in just the right places to activate some primal instinct in Phainon's hindbrain. His cock has never gotten so hard so quickly in all his life, and he's immediately undoing his boxers because he'll definitely explode if he doesn't do something about it. He can't think about teasing, or foreplay, or edging, he can only listen to the rhythmic demand of *'mate mate mate'* pounding relentlessly in his skull.

Why he was so anxious about this, he's not sure. Now that he's here, he knows exactly what needs to happen.

He slides in with only the slightest bit of initial resistance from the outer muscles, effortlessly bottoming out on the first thrust. Mydei lets out a choked gasp and scrambles to brace his hands against Phainon's back, clearly not expecting such enthusiasm, but he doesn't scold him. Any initial shock is replaced with eagerness, as he moves with each subsequent thrust, pushing Phainon's cock as deep as it can possibly go, and Titans, it feels so impossibly good.

What really makes him unravel is the way Mydei responds, with quiet grunts and curses, face slack with pleasure, and beautifully flushed all over. Only Phainon can make him feel like this; knowing that is a high like nothing else. He has to give more, give *everything* to Mydei, even if he himself is run ragged.

Tonight, he doesn't think it'll take much for either of them. He doesn't want to come early but *goddamnit* it's hard not to when this man is involved. Phainon's hands grip the bony jut of Mydei's hips out of some futile attempt at restraint, certainly too hard, but Mydei tightens around his cock with a low groan, goading him to go further. Faster, sharper, with enough force to rock the bed and knock the headboard against the wall, and in this moment Phainon doesn't give a shit if other people can hear them because Mydei's blunt nails are clawing down his shoulders and he's kissing him frantically, needing to touch him in every place he can.

"I love you, love you so much," he babbles, when he's forced to pull back to breathe. He feels untethered. All of Mydei is so overwhelming, and the only reason he hasn't come already is because his knot is preparing to swell, tightening up like a bowstring ready to snap. His thrusts get less controlled as his concentration strains, and slower when Mydei suddenly comes, cunt seizing up like a vice around him, though he never stops moving entirely. He has to keep going--once he reaches his peak, once his knot locks them together, he'll finally mark him.

Maybe alphas aren't supposed to knot as often as he does, but for Mydei, he can't stop himself. He thinks a part of him has always wanted to breed him, no matter how hard he's tried to suppress those unruly thoughts. Successfully acting on them hasn't gotten rid of them, either.

"Gonna get you pregnant again," he says aloud, which he'll later blame on a fit of passion in the heat of the moment, "gonna put--... put another in you right now."

And Mydei, who will later laugh at him for speaking nonsense, tells him, "do it, keep going, *fuck*."

Having already come once, he acts just as desperately as if he hadn't. He's goading Phainon back into a regular rhythm despite the near unbearable tension building at the base of his cock, making every movement feel like an electric shock.

"More, harder," Mydei demands, when Phainon falters. He shouldn't listen, he should keep it slow, but he's desperate too. The peak is right ahead, just a bit more and it will overwhelm him, he'll finally--

Running on pure instinct, he leans down as his knot properly pops, teeth finding the lower right side of Mydei's neck like they were always meant to mark it. He doesn't hesitate to bite down, knowing exactly how much pressure will mold his skin with a perfect scar--hard enough to hurt, but not badly, just enough to make it stay.

For an infinitesimal moment, he gets to savor it, the feeling of breaking that delicate skin and the bitter tang of ichor that wells up against his tongue--

and then Mydei's biting him, and his mind goes blank.

It feels *too* good. He's careening down from the top and it's as if he's in free-fall. His heartbeat drums against his skull, his blood roars in his ears, his eyes burn with tears, his throat chokes on a ruined moan--so much, and yet his own body barely seems to register any of it. Even the most powerful of sensations are a whisper. He'd almost forgotten he was coming but he is, or maybe he already finished and he's coming again, and Titans, he's completely lost himself. Nothing else matters but the pure, molten heat stemming from the wound in his neck, searing a course through each of his nerves, drowning him in intoxicating warmth.

And yet, despite the mess of sensations clouding his mind, he knows one thing with startling clarity--that he loves Mydei more than he even thought possible. His heart is full of love for so many things and still it manages to find more room. He feared it had died that day when his world burnt to ash, but it bloomed again, and learned to beat more fiercely, enough to live in spite of the eternal burden of grief.

Fuck, he thinks he's forgetting to breathe. He clings to Mydei, trying to anchor himself against something real. He's warm, and trembling, and gasping for air. His arms wrap tight around Phainon, holding him back, and his hips buck upward, shifting the knot in a way that makes him lightheaded.

If they could stay here forever, it would be close enough to heaven.

Of course, that's a silly wish to have. Eventually, when his knot wanes and his mind is clear enough to form reasonable thoughts again, Phainon pulls away. He moves with care, avoiding any extra stimulation, until he's lying supine beside Mydei. The scratches sting as they brush against the sheets, but they don't bother him much. They show just how much his mate--what a thrill it is to finally call him that--enjoyed himself. Every ache in his body adds up to perfect satisfaction.

"... Wow," he says, deciding he'll break the silence out of a compulsion to express himself.

"Do you have anything to add beyond that?" Mydei asks, sounding unimpressed, though his grin is audible.

"What is there to say? That was... incredible, really. I didn't know it would feel so good."

"Seems you don't have any regrets, then. If you did, I'd have to kill you."

Knowing Mydei, that isn't a joke, but Phainon laughs anyway. "As if I'd ever regret this. We're mates now, actually mates. I only wish I could do it again, just to feel... but wait, won't your bite heal? Your body--all your wounds heal without scars. It's going to go away, right?"

His blissful happiness is crushed in an instant at the thought. Is fate really so cruel that it would deny them something so simple? Mydei's curse is the only reason that he's here now for Phainon to love, but it may be the thing to keep them apart in the ways that hurt the most.

"You, of all people, should know how quickly I heal. Such a minor injury would have already vanished, but it hasn't, has it?"

Indeed, when Phainon looks over at him, he sees the mark of his teeth, which no longer bleeds but is still clearly outlined. "So...?"

"My body wishes for the mark to remain, of course. It'll scar over like anybody else's, and you don't need to fret about your claim disappearing."

He sighs in relief as he cuddles up to Mydei's side, getting close enough to nose at his scent gland. Both of their scents will change with time, signifying their new status, but for now, Mydei's is the same, sweetly spiced and with the rich undertone of pregnancy. He's aware he's biased, but he still thinks nobody else has smelled better.

"Aren't you dramatic," Mydei mutters, voice fond, as he leans into Phainon's touch. "My heart is yours, no matter what happens. Now, calm down and let me go to sleep, you tired me out."

"It looks like I managed to keep up with you tonight, huh? You said I couldn't," he goads, unable to resist. Personally, he thinks he did an excellent job, and he deserves a bit of recognition for his hard work.

Mydei scoffs. "Ridiculous. It's only because we mated--you'd be done long before I was satisfied in normal circumstances. You'll see next time."

"I can't wait."

"I'm sure you won't be able to wait, you're so impatient. But you have no choice. Goodnight."

And so they fall asleep side by side, with Phainon's arm slung across his chest and head nestled in the crook of his neck, proudly marked by his new mate.

When Phainon wakes up, the bed is empty. Mydei's warmth lingers in the sheets, but the man himself is absent, he finds, when his eyes flick open.

His mind, slow from drowsiness, struggles to figure out what's happened. This doesn't make any sense to him. They always wake up together with Mydei's early alarm. He doesn't *think* he'd sleep through it, but he must have. When he looks around the room, he finds that the night-curtains are still drawn--that puts a dent in his theory. Mydei always opens them right when he gets out of bed, uncaring of how Phainon complains about the brightness most days.

What he *does* notice is that the bathroom door is ajar, and the light is on inside. *He just got up to relieve himself,* Phainon thinks, already closing his eyes again. There must be a few hours left before dawn, he can get a bit more sleep before it's time for their morning spar.

And then, he hears a violent, wet gag, followed by retching.

With his groginess dispelled in an instant, he's on his feet and rushing to the bathroom, nearly tripping over his own feet in his hurry. There, he finds Mydei hunched over the toilet, head hanging into the bowl, heaving.

Phainon crouches down to his level, gathering up his hair to hold it away from his mouth with one hand while the other rests on his back, between his shoulders, rubbing circles as he continues to choke up watery bile.

Phainon's done this for other people while they've been sick, but never Mydei. It's only natural, of course, though that doesn't stop him from feeling guilty. This is partially his fault, after all.

He diligently tends to Mydei until his vomiting turns to dry heaving, and then stops altogether. They both wait for it to start back up, but it doesn't; eventually, Mydei lifts his head to appraise Phainon with tired eyes, a quiet sigh crossing his lips.

"I thought I was over this part," he mutters, voice weak in a way that makes Phainon's chest hurt.

"Morning sickness can last the whole pregnancy, I've heard..."

"Master told me my own mother was that way, but I was taking a medicine from Lady Hyacine that alleviated most of the nausea, so I believed I wouldn't have to go through it again. I'm not sure why... *ugh*, I think I've been forgetting to take the medicine since my return."

"Has the mental fog been bad?" he asks, immediately assuming his forgetfulness to be caused by his pregnancy. Mydei is many things, but he's not forgetful; in fact, he has the uncanny ability to remember *everything*, down to the smallest of details.

"No, it's just an inconvenience. Besides this blasted sickness, none of the symptoms bother me much."

Phainon lets go of his hair to grab his hand, wincing at how clammy it is. "But it still isn't easy, even so. I'm here for you now. Tell me how to help and I'll do it."

"... Get me a cup of water."

As he speaks, he slumps over, enough to rest his forehead against the toilet's rim. Phainon does exactly as requested, and even holds the cup for him while he drinks. He must be exhausted, since he'd protest profusely at this treatment in any other situation. When Phainon gathers him into his arms and carries him to the bed, he still remains silent, and even lets himself be tucked under the covers like a child.

As nice as it is to care for him, it's sad, in a sense, to know that he went without aid for so many weeks. Phainon can't stop himself from whispering an apology as he lays down beside him, though it goes unhead, as Mydei's already fallen asleep, curled up on his side with an arm guarding his abdomen.

Don't give your other father too much trouble, Phainon thinks, as he slips a hand over Mydei's flank to rest it against the gentle swell. He wishes he could alleviate more of the burden of carrying a child, though he's well aware there's a limit to what he can do. Mydei hates being coddled, and he won't kick back while Phainon does all the work.

He'll try his damndest not to be too overbearing. His only wish is that Mydei will realize it's okay for him to relax sometimes, especially while his body is in the process of growing an entire baby. They're both stubborn people, but Phainon is especially determined on this matter. This should be a good experience for both of them, not a grueling one, and he wants them both to look back on this time with fondness.

Hopefully, now that they've been reunited, the greatest hardship is over.

Chapter End Notes

> phainon is a giver.... so eager to please... he makes me so sad sometimes. i love you phainon!! i appreciate you!! please don't die i'll cry really hard!!
>
> i got the flu while writing the last part of this chapter/editing the whole thing so if parts of it don't make sense i'm sorry, i was simply too eager to write even in my delirium. it just made it take longer which pissed me off a bit. i think i might be working on this fic for the rest of my

life if this keeps up. the universe is trying to stop me from completing it but i will persevere.

also ty for 1k kudos ilove you

Chapter 9: lion's ear

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In Mydei's youth, when he was a fresh rescue from the Sea of Souls and still learning to speak, Krateros would spend hours regaling him with Kremnoan legends, teaching him both language and history in one fell swoop.

One of the more interesting stories was of Queen Colubra, who ruled soon after the great King Gorgo when the kingdom of Kremnos was still in its infancy. As a young child, she--through some means--imbibed the golden blood of Nikador, granting her unparalleled strength. An unintended consequence of her skill was that no one was able to match her in a courting duel, meaning that, for many years, the people believed she would never have a consort. Her advisors requested that she take a spouse to continue Gorgo's bloodline, but she adamantly refused.

Then, on a perfectly ordinary day, Colubra vanished. The Kremnoans, as a strong and resourceful people, did not allow their society to collapse without their queen, and instated one of her guards as acting ruler while they attempted to locate her, to no avail. In fact, she did not want to be found. Ten months later, she returned upon her own volition, strolling back through the palace gates as if nothing at all had happened, cradling a newborn babe against her chest.

"I found my equal", she declared, *"and sired a child with her."*

The child was no ordinary child, having the ears of a fawn and a tiny set of antlers atop their head. Their mother was a forest nymph; indeed, no mortal could hope to match the strength of Queen Colubra. It was a strange outcome, but the Kremnoans were overjoyed nonetheless, and hosted a grand feast to celebrate.

Mydei always liked this particular legend. It was a celebration of life, not death, and to a child who'd experienced much of the latter, a happy ending was a novel, but welcome, reprieve. So, though it isn't a tale of much historical significance, it's always been one that Mydei has remembered.

Today, history repeats itself. He's preparing to go to a feast held to celebrate his return after an unexplained absence--and once he announces their existence, it will be celebrating Kremnos's new heir.

With the event upon him, he does find himself saddled with a bit of trepidation. Why, he can't say. The Kremnoans have always been fiercely loyal to their rulers, even to their own detriment. And that's not the problem.

It pains him to admit even to himself, but he wasn't telling Phainon the truth. He *does* concern himself with what the Okhemans will think. A part of him does, anyway--the covetous part of him that spends every waking moment fixated on the child.

He's never minded his secondary gender much until the past few months, when it began overwhelming him with instincts too powerful to ignore. He's sick of it, of being so unsettled. The luxury of living in the city has made him accustomed to being comfortable, something he wouldn't have been able to imagine in his youth, as being *unsettled* was just a fact of life.

"Uh, Mydei? I think I might've put the jewelry on wrong, can you check it for me?"

He's brought back to reality by the sound of Phainon's voice calling to him from the washroom. With less than a quint left until the feast, they're both getting dressed for the occasion. Of course, Phainon wished to wear traditional Kremnoan garb, as he insisted on being as respectful as possible. Nobody would've cared, Mydei's certain--but when he gets a proper look at Phainon, he realizes it would have been a loss had he not. Dressed in a light chiton which exposes his well-muscled physique, with a crimson drape pinned at his shoulder, and golden jewelry adorning his collar and arms, he is a sight for sore eyes.

Mydei swallows thickly. "It looks fine."

"Okay... but why are you staring at the necklace? Did I really put it on right?"

"You did, it's not the sort of thing you can put on wrong," he insists, forcing himself to look up at Phainon's eyes. "I was--*ahem.* I was not looking at the necklace."

"Oh, so you *like* it. You think I look extra handsome in these clothes... And you're the one who said it didn't matter if I dressed nicely..." he lilts in a tone that makes Mydei consider punching him.

"It's perfectly acceptable to change one's opinion when presented with new information."

Phainon slinks forward, gently pushing Mydei back against the bed. "But do you think I look good in this outfit, or would I look even better if I took it all off?"

He laughs sharply. "This is the worst attempt at seduction you've managed so far. We have to leave soon, let me finish getting ready."

While Mydei dons the last of his accessories, Phainon mopes by the window, forlornly staring off at the cityscape beneath them. Typical. He acts like a kicked chimera when he's down, though he always tries to hide it.

"My other attempts at seduction have been good, right?" he asks sadly, just as Mydei is putting on a set of rose gold earrings.

"We're *mated*, you fool."

"Yeah, but all my practice means I should be great at flirting by now! I'm not going to rest on my laurels, what sort of mate would that make me?"

"If you're patient, you can try some more lines on me tonight, and I have an inkling that it might work. Only *after* this event, though. If I can have patience, so can you."

Mydei offers him a chaste kiss to placate him before pulling him to the door. If they leave now, they'll be a fair bit early, but if they linger in the bedroom any longer, Phainon just might manage to tempt him into doing something more than a kiss. For whatever reason, they always lose their restraint around each other. As Chrysos Heirs, they are meant to be level-headed, rational, and responsible, but together, they turn into fools, racing to the bottom of the barrel. Mydei has never minded this dynamic; in fact, he relishes it. Around Phainon, he doesn't have to be anything at all.

But there is more to his life than just Phainon. He needs to keep up appearances for his people, and that means not allowing himself to be goaded into making stupid decisions, no matter how tempting they may be.

The walk to the Kremnoan district is mostly quiet. Uncharacteristically, Phainon seems to have nothing to say, in sharp contrast to his blabbering just minutes before. Mydei assumes he's finally got the memo and has decided to behave himself--an incorrect assumption, he finds, when Phainon reaches for his hand and Mydei feels how clammy his palm is. It seems the nerves have set in.

"... What if the Kremnoans suddenly decide they don't like me?" he eventually asks, confirming Mydei's suspicions. He's smiling, as if he's not being serious, but it's hollow. That question is genuine. His vulnerabilities always linger beneath the surface, never quite healing with the passage of time, just controlled well enough to keep most people from noticing the cracks.

Mydei knows how it feels. They may have lived very different lives, but the world imparted similar lessons upon them, and showed them much of the same cruelty.

"That's not going to happen," Mydei reassures him, "at this point, there are few things you could do to ruin your reputation, and being my mate is not one of them."

You are good enough, regardless of their opinions, he thinks, though he keeps it to himself. His multiple attempts to get that idea through Phainon's thick skull have failed, and he can't imagine this time will be any different.

"If you're certain."

"I always am, and it would do you well to not doubt me."

He's not sure if Phainon's fears have been assuaged, but his smile now reaches his eyes. The remainder of their walk is conducted in much more comfortable silence, fingers lightly interlocked, only separating once they reach the doors of the mess hall.

The structure was originally built inside of the Kremnoan barracks, as the very first construction project undertaken by the detachment in their Council-alloted land. It was far from luxurious--it was so cramped and unpleasant that the soldiers preferred to eat outside instead. It wasn't necessarily a problem, but when their numbers grew over the coming months, and the district developed into a proper community, Mydei realized some changes needed to be made. Not only did the mess hall go unused, but the Kremnoans moved from the barracks into houses, leaving the entire complex abandoned. They had very little land to work with, they couldn't afford this waste of space. So, he suggested that the mess hall be expanded, replacing the structure with a grand feast hall, to mirror the one in Castrum Kremnos.

It took much hard work, but with enough time and plenty of enthusiasm, the mess hall has become quite the sight. Expertly carved columns reach up to the vaulted ceilings, tapestries and war-banners adorn every wall, scones cast the room in a warm, comforting glow, and the feast table spans its length, its lacquered wood shining in the candlelight. It isn't much of a mess hall anymore, and yet, all the Kremnoans refer to it as such; nobody wishes to forget its humble beginning.

Like any mess hall, seating is not assigned. Mydei rarely chooses to sit at the table's head, even for important occasions, and today isn't the day he'll stray from his routine. He notices a young girl eyeing the king's chair as he surveys the room, and offers it to her. The Kremnoan children love to boast about who gets the seat of honor at the last feast, so she'll have bragging rights for the next few months. He can see her excitement as she hops up into the chair.

Phainon smiles at him as they go to take their own seats, with a look in his eyes Mydei can't quite name. "You're going to be such a good father."

"Don't speak of that right now, somebody could overhear us," he grouses. "I informed you how the announcement will go, and I will not allow your loose lips to ruin my plan."

His plan, in all honesty, wasn't the most well thought-out, mostly due to the fact that he chose to wear the same style of traditional chiton as Phainon. The fabric doesn't hide his pregnancy, instead accentuating it. He can only hope that the dim lighting obscures him somewhat.

"It's so loud in here, I can barely make out what *you're* saying, much less anybody else. But I'll do my best to keep quiet."

"I'm sure it will be an immense struggle for you."

"You think I became a debate champion by keeping my mouth shut? Being so taciturn isn't always an attribute, Mydeimos."

"... If you'd like to avoid getting thrown across the hall, you should learn some restraint."

"Don't threaten me with a good time," Phainon says, his grin sharpening. Mydei decides to ignore him, and greets the group that just sat to his left, composed of a few young warriors. He saw them earlier in the day at the training grounds, as he was running drills for the new recruits--a job he can still handle even as his pregnancy progresses, though not as frequently. Even standing around and shouting orders is enough to exhaust him.

The warriors must be wondering why he's mostly absent from the training grounds, but they don't mention it. Instead, they rush to tell him how hard they worked in the interim preceding his return. He's glad to hear it; if his weakness leads him to an early grave, the Kremnoans will not fall to ruin without their prince, they will keep pushing ahead.

And yet, as that thought crosses his mind, he shudders.

Such a thought would have previously been fleeting. Dying so many times made the whole thing feel entirely mundane. A part of him knows it's not a healthy way to think, but with his curse, he finds it hard to think any other way.

Now, even recalling the path to the Netherworld, so well-trodden by his boots, makes his stomach churn. Temporary or not, he doesn't wish to see those gates again, hear how they whisper to him, feel how they tug at him, almost tempting. To consider giving up--even if it is Death's Hand forcing that consideration into his mind--is a betrayal.

But he shouldn't be thinking about such dour things. This is an eve for celebration. His body is home to a life he dearly cherishes, and of that, the world shall know.

The influx of guests has slowed to a trickle; it's time for the feast to begin, and that means a raring speech from the prince to kick off the festivities. Usually, he feels he ends up repeating the same things at every celebration and it isn't actually *raring*, but that won't be the case today. He bothered to practice his speech for once--a rarity for him, since he prefers to speak from the heart.

"Is it time?" Phainon asks, noticing the shift in his demeanor.

"Yes, so long as you remember what you're meant to do."

"Stand when you say my name, of course. I'd never forget such simple instructions."

"I'd think not, but you always manage to surprise me."

Mydei doesn't linger to see if Phainon is affronted by the comment, instead pushing his chair back and rising to his feet. Immediately, the room quiets, conversation falling to hushed whispers and exclamations of excitement.

"It is a pleasure to stand before you, my people" he begins, voice easily carrying through the hall, "as it has been far too many months since we last

came together in celebration. A mere week ago, you wondered why I had vanished, and if I would ever return.

"As I struggled outside the city walls, I imagined all your restless thoughts, and how you must be soldiering on in spite of them. It gave me strength--I'd return to you soon enough, I vowed. I had not anticipated that I'd find myself in such dire straits when I departed Okhema for a routine mission--let this serve as a reminder to never underestimate the Evernight, no matter your skill.

"I fought through legions of Titankin, my every waking hour spent in vicious combat. They threatened to overwhelm me at times, so great were their numbers, but not once did I falter. When my body ached with exhaustion, when my mind went numb from the repetition of slaughter, when the chance of escape from the hordes seemed slim to none--I did not lose my determination."

The Kremnoans cheer. It does little to ease the guilt that he feels, having lied to them so blatantly. Knowing that the truth of their prince's weakness would be too much for them, he falsified a version of the events, then asked Phainon to write them into a segment of his speech. Dishonesty, no matter how kind, is far from being one of his strengths. To be frank, Phainon isn't always the greatest liar, but when it matters, he does it very well.

It seems his lie was suitable this time, and was sold by Mydei's delivery. He waits for the cheering to quiet before continuing.

"For Kremnoans, our greatest source of determination is each other. Our community is strong, and the principles of honor and virtue we follow have kept us together for millenia. With our own hands, we have forged a place for ourselves. I take great pride in every one of you, for the business, homes, and families you have built here in spite of it all.

"As your prince, I have been a spectator to your lives, to the extent that I, for many years, did not think much of my own. The work I had to do was all-consuming, and I hadn't a moment of peace for myself. But now... Seeing you all thrive in the face of hardship, I realized my work wasn't all-consuming anymore.

"Though this feast was not thrown in anticipation for any announcement, it is as good a time as any for me to make two. First, it is my great pleasure to present my mate, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae."

This round of cheering is almost deafening. Phainon's all smiles as he stands beside Mydei, shining in the face of such immediate enthusiasm. The response is just as he anticipated; most everyone loves the Deliverer, with the Kremnoans being no exception. He's helped many members of the detachment since their arrival in the city, has advocated for them despite the stigma that came with it, and--perhaps most significantly--is an extremely competent warrior.

"He has been my partner for multiple years, but until recently, I did not wish to speak about the depth of our relationship. Our bond is precious, why should I invite public scrutiny upon it? However, I've come to realize that hiding this is simply impossible. We have made a permanent promise to each other, branding skin with teeth for the world to see. If anybody wishes to judge, so be it.

"We have also made a decision even more meaningful, the consequences of which are... Even more difficult to hide. So, I have another announcement--one that I thought I would never have the chance to make. It seems fate has spared us some kindness, and with nothing but joy in my heart, I can proclaim that I am with child."

Mydei thought he was prepared for the reaction his words would elicit. Excitement is understandable, but the celebration which erupts is so overwhelming that even *he* feels nervous. It's as if he proclaimed that the Era Nova was upon them.

He can't fully process what happens next; he says something to finish off his speech that he's not sure makes sense and nobody heard anyway, sits back down, and then zones out as he's bombarded by congratulations from every direction.

The thing that grounds him, some indeterminate amount of time later, is Phainon shaking his shoulder and asking him if he'd like some pomegranate juice. He gratefully accepts the offered glass before quickly emptying it.

His stomach has been touchy even with Hyacine's medicine, but at least his favorite drink remains untainted by his new sensitivities.

"You doing okay?" Phainon asks, almost having to shout over the noise, which has scarcely died down.

"I'm perfectly alright, just... taken off guard, I suppose. But an heir for our people is the greatest gift many of them think I can give, so I can understand."

"And they care about you as a person too! They know how much you love kids, of course they'd assume you're excited to have your own."

"That too... though how do you know that?"

"I, uh, have had some conversations in the past," Phainon says, with a nervous laugh, "where I maybe said a bit too much. About *myself,* not you, exactly... I just found it cute how you'd play with the Kremnoan children in the square, and maybe asked some weird questions, but don't worry, I found the answers very endearing!"

"Hmm. Endearing." Mydei narrows his eyes. "How much of the concept of me wanting to have children is endearing to you? When you told me you were 'going to get me pregnant again' was that a part of--"

"Do *not* bring that up right now!" he cries, burying his head in his hands.

"You said yourself that nobody can overhear us in here, what's the matter?" he asks innocently, enjoying the strangled, pained sound that Phainon produces.

"It's not that, it's... Damnit... I just said it in the heat of the moment, okay? I wasn't thinking straight."

"So, you didn't mean it?"

Phainon lifts his head to give him a pleading look. "I didn't... I meant it a *little,* but--but no, I... Is this payback for all the times I flirted with you in the public baths?"

Mydei smirks, unable to keep up his facade. "Perhaps. I now understand why you did that, it's quite fun. Everyone can see how easy it is for me to fluster you."

"At least one of us is having fun," he sighs. "Can't we just enjoy dinner in peace?"

"We can, but you're correct, I'm *not* letting that comment go, so we'll be discussing it more afterward. In private this time."

He leaves Phainon to mull over his words while he turns to speak with the soldiers next to him once more, who are now offering to be a part of his child's personal guard. It's not necessary, but he thanks them for their willingness. As he's come to understand, many of them feel they owe him for what he's done, though he's never wanted anything from his people. Seeing them prosper is plenty enough.

And after an evening filled with laughter, joy, and celebration, he's more than fulfilled.

By the next entry hour, the entire city seems to have heard the news.

Upon opening his teleslate, the first thing he sees is a post about it on the world wound web, which makes him frown. Are there not more interesting going-ons than the relationships of the Chrysos Heirs? Perhaps it seems mundane from his own perspective, but even so, it doesn't make much sense to him.

He already knows he's going to get accosted if he leaves the Mamoreal Palace. Hell, he'll probably end up getting accosted here as well. The staff like to gossip just as much as everyone else.

"What have I done to upset you this time?" Phainon asks the moment he notices Mydei's discontentment. It's a solid assumption to make; he'll admit he's been a bit more sensitive for obvious reasons, and prone to being irritated by the smallest of things, like Phainon snoring too loudly, or moving too much in his sleep.

Mydei casts his teleslate aside with a sigh. "It's not you. It's the news, which you can certainly imagine. The moment I step foot out of this room, I'll be expected to *explain* things... as if there's anything more to explain. I said it all yesterday."

"Just stick by my side and let me field their questions," is Phainon's over-confident reply, delivered with a smile. He's so full of himself sometimes. Mydei can't resist leaning over to kiss his stupid lips.

"Don't make me look like an idiot, not like you do for yourself."

"How rude of you to insult my skills after I so kindly offered them! I declare your punishment: a trip to the baths with me, with no complaints about the early hour."

"How barbaric," he mutters. He does end up humoring Phainon, even though he's still tired enough to prefer staying in bed for at least another quint. Before his pregnancy, he'd never consider sleeping in, but it's now normal for him to forego his morning bath with his mate. Though Phainon never protested his absence, Mydei knows he's missed having him along.

Aglaea is already at the Heroes' Baths when they arrive, as always. They both strip and settle down beside her to exchange their usual pleasantries. As he already informed the Chrysos Heirs of his pregnancy a few days prior, and she knew even before that, she has little to say on the matter other than a question about how his morning sickness has been.

The announcement had gone just as he imagined it would, at least in terms of their reactions. He was aware he didn't pick the most ideal time to bring it up, as the mood in their highly important meeting was far from celebratory, but realistically, he didn't think there was a better opportunity.

In their previous discussions of Black Tide containment, he and Phainon were always on the front lines, without question. Now, they'd be stepping back--a move they couldn't make without reason. They'd discussed it already with Aglaea, and she, anticipating their decision, already had a solution in mind.

"Can you tell me why you dragged me in here?" Cipher had asked, during a lull in their discussion. She was more on edge than usual, liable to bolt from the meeting room at any moment. Mydei was surprised she accepted Aglaea's invitation in the first place.

"Aglaea invited you at my behest," Mydei said, hoping to placate her, which seemed to work. *"I have a request to make of you. For at least the next few months, Phainon and I will not be able to defend the areas outside of Okhema's walls. To spare Lady Castorice from being the only Chrysos Heir tasked with such difficult work, we were hoping you could do it in our stead."*

"W-what? Why?" she asked, for once appearing caught off-guard.

"I am with child, and neither of us wish to be put in any unnecessary danger."

The ensuing silence was broken, surprisingly, by Cipher's cackling laughter. *"Oh my gods, I should've guessed that ages ago! No wonder you've been acting so weird! Of course! Just for satiating my curiosity, I'll pick up both your shifts--so long as Princess Homebody's there to keep me company."*

"Um, I'll be there," Castorice said quietly, then with more enthusiasm, *"and congratulations to you two! Please let me know if you'd like me to make anything for the baby."*

"Wait, De, you're having a baby? Really?" Trianne interjected, before either of them could accept the offer.

Mydei nodded, and opened his mouth to respond, but she started cheering before he got the chance. There wasn't much hope of returning to the previous topic of conversation at that point, so he fielded a few questions before excusing himself, hoping that they might be able to get back on track with him absent.

Since then, he's spent most of his time with the Tribios and Castorice in the Garden of Life, listening to their surprisingly detailed parenting advice;

upon reflection, it shouldn't be too shocking, considering their collective thousands of years of experience.

After this bath, he'll be meeting with Castorice to continue their knitting lesson, which ended prematurely due to the feast. She said he's done good work so far, and he should be able to make some simple clothes for the baby if he sticks with it, though he can't imagine that they'll be necessary, considering the amount of gifts they've already received. Between the Chrysos Heirs and the Kremnoans, they have enough supplies to swaddle a small army of infants.

Phainon would probably like it if he *did* choose to make something, he muses. His mate has been oddly emotional about things of that manner; perhaps some of Mydei's hormones are affecting him.

He's also been so particular about scenting him. The moment they're out of the bath, Phainon's all over him. Since their only spectator is Aglaea--who seems unbothered by almost everything--Mydei lets it happen. He himself doesn't mind some public displays of affection, at least not in theory, but Okhemans can be either very prudish or gossipy, so he's become much more reserved over the years.

Clearly, Phainon doesn't care nearly as much. He's so beloved that he can get away with anything, should he choose to go against the grain.

He pouts as Mydei begins to walk away from him, now dry and redressed. "Where are you going?"

"To the Garden of Life, I told you I was knitting with Castorice again. What, do you want to join?"

"Well, um... I don't want to be too clingy, so..."

"You *are* too clingy," Mydei states, which elicits a stifled laugh from Aglaea, "but I like that about you. If you want to come along, your company would be welcome, and the chimeras would be happy to see you."

"I'm not sure if I'll be any good at knitting, but I'll try if there's an extra pair of needles. With enough practice, I might be better than you, even."

"Impossible. You lack the finesse," he retorts immediately.

"I guess I'll have to surprise you, then."

They may not be able to compete on the battlefield for the foreseeable future, but it seems there's still ample room for competition in their lives.

Chapter End Notes

> adhd is such a stupid disorder what do you mean i put off writing something i WANTED to write for four months for no reason? i'm on a new medication now so maybe that'll fix me and i'll stop doing stuff that pisses myself off. we'll see.
>
> if there are extra spelling mistakes in this chapter ignore them something is wrong with google docs and it doesn't point out like half of the errors. that's all i have for an editor besides myself when i read over my published chapter in a week and freak out. it's a great system ❤
>
> thanks for sticking with me! next chapter should be the last one ??but i might have to add one extra. i didn't write an outline for this fic after chapter 9. i honestly don't know why but it's not like i'm writing one now.

Chapter 10: melianthus (honeyflower)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The world is burning.

Hellfire rains down upon Okhema, brought by the legions of the Black Tide. Their ranks decimated the walls and the guards with ease, almost as if they weren't there at all. Forward they marched, with relentless surety and perfect brutality, ignorant of humanity's attempts at resistance.

The stench of smoke and burning flesh mix in a nauseating perfume that fills the nose and sours the tongue. People scream for their families and children sob for their parents, all dying, all dead. The earth shakes as the city collapses, piece by piece, gilded marble and coated plaster buckling under the endless barrage. There's nowhere to run. Everywhere is fire and desecrated corpses and twisted monstrosities.

It's the end.

The Black Tide has come, and Phainon can't do anything to stop it. He never got a Coreflame, he's just a useless mortal man with ichor in his veins. A lifetime spent training, molded into a hero meant to carry the weight of the world--a waste. He failed, because he always does, because he's never going to be good enough no matter what he does.

In front of him is Mydei, collapsed to his knees, curled around a small figure he's desperately trying to protect from the coming Tide. It's a child with white hair and blue eyes and blood on their face and it's *his* child, he knows. Phainon can't move. Mydei's yelling at him to do something but he *can't move,* his feet are rooted to the ground by pillars of marble, like Kephale's own stone legs, dormant.

Gods, it's happening again. He's watching his family die in front of him and he's powerless to stop it. He knows he can't survive the grief again, it's

going to break him, he's going to die too. It's not fair. None of them deserve this. None of them did anything wrong, but that doesn't seem to matter, does it? The Titans abandoned them a long, long time ago. They all knew it, but maybe, they thought, they could do it without them, and what ridiculous hubris that was, to pursue godhood. But whether they gave up or resisted--nothing would have changed this outcome.

All he can really ask is *why.*

His child looks at him, with eyes a mirror of his own. They're so innocent, so precious, completely undeserving of catastrophe. He can't save them from fate. The Tide's closing it, about to consume their tiny body and Mydei too, and--

"Phainon! Open your eyes, *look at me!"*

Suddenly, Mydei's looming over him, very much alive and unharmed, but with a face tight with worry. Phainon makes a noise like a dying animal, a horrible rasping wail that wheezes from his lungs. One of his arms jerks forward without his input, striking Mydei on the shoulder, which feels more like hitting a solid rock wall. Mydei immediately seizes his wrist and squeezes it tight, almost too tight. Phainon struggles in his hold, though he's not sure why he wants to get away.

"Phainon, look at me," Mydei orders, and he obeys. "You're awake now, whatever happened wasn't real."

It was all a dream. It was all just a horrible fucking dream. He knows that. But he can't stop seeing it and he doesn't know how to make it go away.

Remember what Hyacine told you about flashbacks. It's the same. Ground yourself, breathe.

The sheets are soft. Mydei is warm. The room smells like soap. A lone dove sings outside. Phainon forces air into his body even though it hurts. His mouth tastes like iron. He feels like vomiting but it doesn't happen. He listens to the dove and smells the soap instead.

It takes a long time before he begins to relax. Slowly, gradually, the tension loosens, until his ribcage doesn't feel like a vice and his jaw unclenches and his eyes can properly focus on Mydei, who hasn't moved an inch and has Phainon's wrist still secured tight. He must sense that the worst of it is over, since he finally lets go. For a second, it seems like he wants to say something, but he only sighs, before clambering off to lay back down beside him.

He always knows exactly what Phainon needs, he's so kind and considerate and gentle and every other good thing that he feels like doesn't deserve. In this moment, he kind of hates it, and hates that he does. Why is he so cruel to the person who loves him the most?

"... How do you feel?" Mydei asks him quietly, after the silence between them has stretched on unbearably long. Phainon can't find an answer. Instead, he presses his palms against his eyes and weeps.

"I'm sorry," he manages to choke out. It doesn't do anything to the nauseating tangle of guilt trapped in his gut, and he's not really sure why he said it.

"Stop apologizing. Do you think I should apologize when *I* have nightmares? Show yourself the same grace," Mydei scolds, though not unkindly.

"I-It's too hard... I don't want to... to feel like this anymore, I hate it. It's been so many years but it still hurts so bad, it won't stop hurting and I don't understand."

"Grief is not so clear-cut. It seems to lessen over time, and yet returns anew at the strangest times. The happiest times in my life are the ones where it seems most liable to return... Why, I can't say, but it never lingers for long. It's a part of me as much as any other part, and so, I must accept it, even if I, too, wish I could be rid of it. You'll survive, just as you have, just I as have. That is life."

Mydei reaches out to cradle his cheek, and Phainon exhales shakily, doing his best to relax into the touch. His hands are so soft, protected from

callouses by rapid regeneration. Phainon's are brutish in comparison, all scarred and wrinkled and a bit crooked in places from a dozen improperly healed fractures over the years.

"Do you want me to do anything for you?"

"I don't know."

"I'll get you some water, then," he replies, already heaving himself off the bed before Phainon can protest, which he *does* want to do. His mate is eight months pregnant and he's doing something that he could easily do himself. He knows Mydei hates to be coddled, and he's always liked to take care of others, but it's impossible not to feel guilty.

Phainon drinks the water in small sips, staring down at the cup with a furrow in his brow. He can feel the weight of Mydei's gaze on him, silently spectating. He's probably going to be like this the rest of the day, so quiet and cautious, to make sure he doesn't do something to set Phainon off. Is that worse than him being his usual self and acting like there isn't a problem? Gods, Phainon doesn't even know anymore. His thoughts are all disjointed, it'll be days before he feels like himself again.

At least neither of them have to perform their regular duties; if he had to go fight the Black Tide right now, he'd probably end up getting killed. Even the thought of having to see those disgusting beasts makes him want to vomit. He really should try to think of something else, though. This isn't making him feel any better.

"I have an appointment with Hyacine today, I'll have to go soon," Mydei says, after glancing at his teleslate, "unless you want me to stay with you."

"You didn't mention this before, is this not a prenatal appointment?" Phainon asks, immediately on edge again.

"It's not, but it's okay, nothing's the matter with the baby. Don't start panicking over nothing. I just haven't started producing colostrum yet, and she said she'd give some advice. Before you ask, I don't think you need to come along."

"I suppose I don't... But you'll tell what she tells you, if there's anything wrong or if I can do anything to stimulate production or--"

"Of course I will. By Nikador, is there anything I can do to convince you not to worry so much? I think the alpha in you has partnered up with your overbearing self to make a new sort of monster," Mydei says, sounding exasperated, though he's smiling.

Phainon manages to smile in turn. "No, unfortunately. My hormones will do what they please. But go off to your appointment, and make sure you eat something afterwards."

"As if I could ever put off eating when this child demands so much sustenance. The person I'm concerned about is *you.* Take care of yourself, do something to take your mind off your nightmare."

He does try. While Mydei is gone, he reads through the informational books Hyacine recommended, even though he's already read them cover to cover multiple times. He goes to get some breakfast for himself, and he's able to stomach most of it. He takes a quick soak in the baths to help clear his head a bit more, then goes back to the books to clutter it up anew. But then, two quints have passed, Mydei still hasn't returned, and he begins to worry anew.

Back in their room, he stares at his teleslate, debating just how overbearing he should be. Should he send a message asking if he'll be back soon, or call him? Mydei probably wouldn't mind the former too much, but he really does want to call--

Before he can decide, Mydei returns. Phainon's relieved until he gets a good look at him. He seems... *off,* in a way that's hard to pin down. If his nose were sharper, he might be able to pick up on the change in his scent, but all he can go off of is the tension in his shoulders and jaw.

"Was something the matter?" Phainon asks immediately, fearing the worst, though the logical part of his brain catches up a moment later to rationalize that, if there really was a serious problem, Mydei would be much more upset.

"What?" he replies, confused, in a manner that suggests he wasn't listening. Phainon doesn't know what to make of that. Mydei's unbelievably attentive, and he hasn't suffered from any pregnancy-induced brain fog up until this point.

"At the appointment, was anything wrong?"

"Oh, it was..." he trails off, before shaking his head. "I don't think you'll believe any lie I tell you, there's no point in trying."

Mydei sits down heavily on the bench near the window, a hand instantly moving to rest atop his pronounced bump. He's been struggling with the changes in his body, though he's not talked about it much beyond grumbling about his altered gait and center of gravity. Phainon has only seen the extent of his dissatisfaction by observation.

He considers joining Mydei on the bench to perhaps give him a massage, but opts to stay at the desk instead, after closing his book to give him his full attention.

"You shouldn't feel a need to lie," he says plainly, because it *does* hurt to hear, especially after all they've endured.

"I shouldn't, you're correct, but frankly, I don't believe you're in a headspace to receive troublesome news."

"Isn't it about you? You said something about milk production, right?"

Mydei sighs, while pinching the bridge of his nose with his free hand. "You're too astute of a listener for your own good."

"You can tell me right now, you've already told me enough."

"I suppose I have. But I can assure you, it's not something that needs to be said urgently, it can wait until you've had ample time to recover."

"If something's the matter with you, I want to know. I want to take care of you, no matter the state I'm in. It'll make me feel better, you know that."

"It's not something you can take care of, or anybody can."

"Really?"

"Yes. When Hyacine examined me. she determined I'm unable to lactate. My body has resisted the hormones that would have developed my breast tissue during puberty. This is apparently quite common in male omegas due to the differences in our development from females," he explains flatly, almost robotically, though he fails to hide his disappointment in his expression.

"But isn't this treatable? People can take hormones to alter their primary sex, doesn't that develop breast tissue as well?"

"It does, but..." he pauses to make a frustrated noise. "I can't take hormone treatments right now, it could harm the baby. Even if I weren't, my body may not even respond to the hormones, my immortality has altered my biology in unpredictable ways."

"Well, then we'll just feed the child formula, it's perfectly fine that you can't. I've known plenty of people of all sexes who did that for a bunch of different reasons--"

"I'm very much aware that formula exists, I'm not a fool," Mydei snaps, then immediately deflates. "I know we'll be able to feed them, I just feel as if... I've failed. My body should be able to provide for them. It is meant to be infallible, it should *work."*

"No part of you is infalliable, you're a human being, not a Titan. I don't like when you talk about yourself like that, it's not good for you."

Mydei makes a face. "That is quite similar to what Lady Hyacine said. It may be the truth in theory, but in practice, I have far too many burdens to bear. My people require my perfection."

"But our baby does not. They just want food, they don't care where it comes from."

He doesn't respond to that, instead breaking eye contact to look out the window. Gods, they're both so stubborn, though Phainon can't say he doesn't understand his pain. His own physical limitations have caused him much grief over the years.

"Mydei, come on, please don't beat yourself up over this. It's not what you wanted, but it's not your fault. Like you said, it's not something anybody can change, so we just have to accept it."

"Don't use my own words against me," he mutters, barely audible.

"You've told me you're always right, so..."

"If I weren't somewhat incapacitated, I'd suggest we settle this argument in the arena... but I suppose I'll acquiesce to you this once."

Phainon grins. "Hah, another win for the debate champion--"

"Don't push your luck, and don't say idiotic things until after I've given birth. It's harder to resist the urge to punch you."

"Yes, Lord Mydeimos."

He rolls his eyes. "Don't overcompensate, either. Take a nap with me and I'll forgive you."

The thought of going to sleep and risking another nightmare makes him uncomfortable, but he's tired. Mydei can certainly see it on his face and won't take no for an answer. So, they lay beside each other as they did that morning, with hopes of sweeter dreams.

"Are you alright?"

Phainon startles at the question, dropping the fork he was idly spinning onto his plate with a loud clank and making Castorice flinch.

"Perfectly so," he says automatically. She seems to believe him even less than she did the first time she asked twenty minutes ago. She invited him to

this diner to have a nice chat and he hasn't been a great conversation partner; he's aware he's spent most of the meal spacing out, but he can't really help it.

"You're rather... high-strung today."

"Just thinking about the baby," he answers vaguely, hoping that explains it, because it *is* the truth.

The last few months of Mydei's pregnancy have been miraculously calm. He's been in perfect health and has been in relatively good spirits despite some aches and pains. There isn't anything to worry about; his immortality all but ensures that the birth will be a smooth process. Phainon isn't sure why he's so stressed other than some nebulous concern that *something* will go wrong. His recent nightmares have not helped in that regard.

Castorice nods sagely, understanding. "Lord Mydei is due very soon, yes?"

"Four weeks now... I can't believe it's happening so soon, I didn't think... I mean, I never thought this was going to happen in the first place, and now..."

"No matter what may happen, you're going to be an excellent father," she assures him, "so try not to fret too much. This is an exciting time!"

"Exciting is one word..." Beyond the stress, he's gotten to indulge in Mydei's heightened libido, which has only seemed to increase in the third trimester, but Castorice doesn't need to know all the details. She's put up with enough of his oversharing in the past, and he has the hindsight to recognize he's a bit *too* forthcoming at times.

It's hard not to think about, though. Mydei just looks so *good* right now, and Phainon loves to tell him all about it in all sorts of circumstances.

"Have you come up with any names? I would imagine that's quite exciting," Castorice asks, perhaps sensing that his mind is wandering away again.

"I know Mydei has. I haven't been able to think of any good names so far. I feel like he deserves the honor of naming them, anyway, since he's doing the hard work. All I've been doing is getting on his nerves by worrying all the time."

"I'm sure he's touched by your concern."

"Maybe he was at first, but definitely not anymore. I've been way too overbearing, I know I have... but Titans, these instincts I have, they're crazy. Alphas never talk about feeling this way, I don't know if it's normal or if I'm actually losing it."

Castorice hums. "Perhaps you should talk to Lady Hyacine. I can't offer you any advice, it has been hundreds of years since I felt any instincts related to my secondary sex."

"I probably should, but don't you think she's busy? I mean, whenever she comes to Okhema, she's always swamped. And I've bothered her so much these past few months..."

Unlike Mydei, Phainon has approached her with nonsensical concerns and baseless worries that she always dismisses. He cringes when he recalls the last thing he asked her, which was if they'd hurt the baby by having too much sex, the nth iteration of this same question. She was definitely fed up with having to give the same answer, he could see it in her expression.

"Well, we can go to the Twilight Courtyard just to see. It's an odd hour, there may not be too many patients waiting."

Somehow, despite his protests, they end up going. As they wait in the clinic--which is actually empty--Phainon decides he'll blame Castorice if Hyacine gets cross with him. It's not fair, but he has to absolve himself of some guilt or it's going to eat him alive.

"Oh, hello!" Hyacine greets, breathless, emerging from the back. "Sorry for the wait, there was a chimera I had to wrangle, they're a lot faster than you'd imagine... What brings you two here?"

"Lord Phainon has a question for you," Castoric says, before he can speak for himself.

Damnit. He swears he sees Hyacine's eyelid twitch.

"It's a normal question," he explains, hoping it'll convince her.

"You can ask me any questions you wish, normal or not. It's my job as your physician."

It's not about whether he *can* but if he *should*, but that's not pertinent, he hopes. As he explains his current inability to think about anything other than Mydei and his wellbeing, she relaxes, and gives him an encouraging smile whenever he falters. He still finds it a bit embarrassing.

"I feel like I'm going through puberty again with all these crazy instincts I can't control, but it's worse, somehow...y'know?" he finishes lamely.

Hyacine, at least, does know. "Considering how intensely Mydei's pheromones have affected you in the past, I'm not surprised to hear this. Your own hormones are very sensitive to external influence. Most alphas experience an increase in protective instincts brought on by the chemical change in their mate's scent, even if they can't consciously detect them, and you're just experiencing a more extreme version of that."

"So, I'll go back to normal when the baby's born?" he asks, momentarily relieved, until Hyacine shakes her head.

"It will probably take a few months, since Mydei's scent will take a while to return to its baseline, and the baby will also affect you. A parental bond forms in the first week or so of life, and they will rely on smell and sound to recognize you, as newborns have very poor eyesight. Your body recognizes this, and your scent will greatly increase in strength. This inevitably causes side effects, similar to the ones you're already experiencing."

"But how am I supposed to parent when I can't think clearly?"

"If these feelings are genuinely disruptive, there *is* a medicine I have that could help... It's for those who overexpress secondary sex hormones, but it doesn't always work."

Are his instincts truly disruptive? If he's being honest with himself, they aren't. He just doesn't appreciate the loss of control over something that he once managed without issue. And maybe that's worth examining, but it's a lot easier to pick this solution, and he doesn't really have the bandwidth for introspection.

"Let me try it, I mean, what's the worst it can do?"

"It doesn't have many side effects, though it can cause drowsiness and muscle aches. You should probably tolerate it well, but please tell me if it doesn't work, and I'll try to figure something else out."

With a bottle of pills in hand, they leave the clinic. Castorice seems rather pleased with herself. Maybe it was her plan all along to get him to come here; she can be awfully conniving when she puts her mind to it. Or maybe he shouldn't question it, and should just appreciate the benefits of her wisdom.

"I guess I should go home to take these," he says, while inspecting the bottle. "Thanks for coming with me."

"It's always a pleasure to spend time with you. I'm going to see Mydei tomorrow to do some more knitting, would you like to join us?"

"Uh... I think I'll pass, Mydei could use some time away from me," he mutters, unwilling to admit that he'd rather not attempt to knit ever again.

"If you're certain. Just make sure you get time to relax and unwind. You won't have as much time for yourself once the baby comes along."

"I'd ought to make the most of this month. I'll go to the baths after this, that should... Hold on, I think I'm getting a call..."

He pulls his teleslate out of his pocket to see it's Mydei, and he swears he can feel the blood drain from his face. He doesn't think Mydei has ever called him before, he only texts. Is Phainon overreacting? He might be, but his hands are already shaking when accepts the call.

"Phainon, where are you?" Mydei asks, tone indistinct and unreadable through the speaker. At least he's alive, Phainon thinks, and tries to feel relieved, but he *knows* something's wrong.

"Uh, I'm out with Castorice, I told you before I left," he replies. His voice sounds about an octave higher than usual in his ears and he doesn't even care if he's embarrassing himself. If the people walking by see their Deliverer having a breakdown in the middle of the road, they can think whatever they want.

"You should come back to our chambers, I-I... uh..." he stammers, and shit, Phainon doesn't think he's ever heard him stammer before either.

"What's wrong?"

"I believe I'm in labor?"

"What."

Something rustles. "I don't think I pissed myself, there... appears to be a lot of blood--"

"Your water broke? Actually?" His voice, somehow, goes higher. Castorice gasps. The sound seems to come from a thousand miles away.

"Yes, it did--" he says, sounding more certain this time, but it doesn't really matter, because suddenly, everything goes dark.

It feels like a prolonged blink--he's standing in the street one instant, and the next, he's on the ground, and Hyacine and Castorice are both leaning over him. His teleslate is still in his hand, but Hyacine takes it from him and he doesn't try to stop her.

"... passed out, he's... I'll be there..." she says into it, though he can't hear past the ringing in his ears. His head hurts so badly all of a sudden and it's not really making sense.

Mydei's in labor? But he can't be, it's a month early, they were supposed to have another month to prepare. He's not ready, neither of them are ready.

"This is some sort of joke, right?" he mumbles.

"No, Mydei seems quite serious. But how do *you* feel? I'm guessing the shock made you briefly pass out, which is benign on its own, but you may have injured yourself when you fell."

"My head feels... um... weird."

"Does it hurt?" she asks, already bending down to inspect him.

"It's pounding, but I don't think I hit it?"

"Then that's probably because of the sudden blood pressure change. I don't see any scrapes or wounds, I think you escaped unscathed. Do you think you can stand? I need to go to Mydei, and I'm sure you would like to accompany me."

Oh, right. Phainon feels woozy again, but pushes past it and manages to get up with Hyacine's aid. He can't be fainting right now, there isn't time for that. Mydei's waiting for both of them.

"Is there anything you'd like for me to do?" Castorice pipes up. "I don't think my presence in the delivery room would be safe, but if you wish for me to fetch anyone or anything, I certainly will."

"I need my tools, I didn't grab them on the way out, I was in a rush because of Phainon. Little Ica, can you lead her to the supply room and show her the right bag? I'll give you a treat if you do."

The memosprite immediately perks up at the mention of food, and whizzes from Hyacine's side to Castorice with a happy trill. When it seems certain

she's paying attention, it starts off down the road, fast enough for her to have to jog along. Hyacine calls for it to slow down, but to no avail.

"I need a better assistant," she mutters under her breath, before turning to Phainon. "Let's go, time is of the essence."

Unfortunately, Phainon's not very steady on his feet, and it takes all of his focus just to not fall back over. The trip to the Mamoreal Palace seems to take an eon. By the time they actually make it to their chambers, he can't do anything other than stumble over to the desk chair to sit down.

"By Nikador, you actually passed out," Mydei comments. Now that Phainon's vision isn't vignetting, he looks up to find his mate seeming quite relaxed, in contrast to how he sounded on the call. He's laid on the bed with the sheets removed, replaced by a few towels.

"It can't be that obvious," he protests weakly.

"You're paler than the day you accidentally fell into the river outside Okhema and almost drowned. You're not even actively suffocating this time."

"I did not accidentally fall in, I was trying to escape a swarm of harpies, and also--... Okay, we can discuss this later, how are you doing?"

"As well as I can be, considering the circumstances... I'm not sure why I've gone into labor so early, I believed my body was incapable of encountering these kinds of issues."

"I would concur," Hyacine says, "but since this *has* happened, I would guess that the stress you've endured over the course of your pregnancy, and the injuries you sustained, might've had some effect on you. Try not to worry about it, though. You're late preterm, right on the edge of being unremarkable, so I don't anticipate that there will be any long-term issues with your baby, or short-term, for that matter. I'll be here to take care of anything that does crop up."

Mydei's expression sours, and Phainon already knows what he's thinking. He feels the same way, though he's blaming himself instead. It was his lack of willingness to communicate that led to Mydei putting himself through all that stress--

But no, now's certainly not the time to play this game.

"Neither of us can change the past," he says, because they both know it's true, even though he thinks they've both failed to internalize it. Maybe if he repeats it enough times, they'll finally stop trying to blame themselves for things that don't matter anymore.

Mydei doesn't say anything. He sighs heavily before motioning for Phainon to join him on the bed, which he does immediately, dizziness forgotten. They didn't get a chance to fully discuss how Mydei wanted this to go, so he'll just do whatever is asked of him. That's the important part, right?

The labor is long. Phainon wishes it wasn't, for Mydei's sake and his own. The minutes crawl by in agonizing silence. Mydei doesn't speak much at all, and doesn't make any sound, either, despite the pain he must be in. He just lays on his side, eyes closed, breathing steadily, for the rest of the day.

Phainon doesn't know what to do with himself. He wants to be helpful, but Mydei doesn't ask anything of him, so he just sits there and watches him bleed. Titans, there's so much blood. They've already had to replace the towels a few times and the freshest set is already stained gold. Hyacine was concerned initially, but after confirming the baby wasn't in distress, determined it was alright. Mydei's body can easily handle this level of blood loss, but that doesn't mean Phainon likes watching it.

"Premature births are quite unpredictable," she says, perhaps hoping to make him feel better. He's not really sure if it does. He feels like he's wading through molasses with each step he paces across the room. With Kephale's light perpetually shining, it's easy to lose track of time, and Phainon no longer cares to know the hour.

He doesn't quite return to reality when labor progresses. Sitting next to Mydei, letting him squeeze his hand until the bones feel like they're going to shatter, he can almost believe he's dreaming. It's happening *now,* and he's still not ready. He wasn't going to be ready even if the baby wasn't pre-term, but he wanted more time.

"Take this baby out of me right now," Mydei hisses under his breath. A part of Phainon agrees, and a part of him wants to run away. He doesn't, of course. He sits and lets Mydei break his hand and finds himself following along to Hyacine's breathing instructions.

And then Mydei makes a final, strangled sound of exertion, and then there's crying, and then Hyacine's wiping the ichor off of a beautiful baby girl with a relieved smile on her face.

Their daughter looks impossibly small rested against Mydei's chest. Phainon can't see her very well past the tears in his eyes. He tries to say something but it comes out as a garbled mess instead, and maybe that expresses his feelings well enough.

Hyacine says something about her body temperature being a bit low as she rests a blanket over her. Phainon only kind of listens. He can't stop staring at his daughter, *his and Mydei's* daughter. How did he contribute to making such a perfect little thing?

"Phainon, you should hold her too," Mydei insists, and all of a sudden, he finds her bundled up in his arms.

She's so small. He must've said that out loud, because Hyacine assures him her birth weight is very close to normal, and she'll catch up quickly. But that doesn't change her in this moment, and Phainon worries about how fragile she looks. He doesn't want to put her down, though. She seems so comfortable nestled against him and--and gods, when she opens her bleary eyes, they're blue, just like his own.

"Hi there," he manages to choke out. He's smiling so wide his cheeks are starting to hurt.

"I want to name her Anemone," Mydei says softly, "I know we didn't get to discuss it much, but... I like that name."

Phainon nods vigorously, not sure if he can speak anymore than he just did.

Anemone. It's perfect. He's going to do all he can to be the best father for her, she deserves everything he can give.

Three years later, Anemone is old enough to run confidently around the Mamoreal Palace under Aglaea's watch, her still-clumsy fingers can put together crafts with Castorice's guidance, and she can speak in sentences clear enough for her new friends at daycare to understand her. Mydei and Phainon have long since returned to their regular duties, and she loves to hear the stories of all their heroic battles, of course watered down to be appropriate for a young child.

Her blood runs gold, just like theirs. She wants to be a hero too, she proclaims, while swinging around sticks with reckless abandon, though she also wants to be an artist, a doctor, a seamstress, and a hundred other things. They encourage her to follow her heart. Neither of them want her to be forced down the same path they were. Her future should be free of the burden of the Flamechase.

But life is comfortable, even if it's not always peaceful. Neither of them would have it any other way.

And then, two outlanders arrive in Okhema.

Chapter End Notes

> that's a wrap! this fic was a lot longer than i originally planned since i kept getting ideas but im finally happy with it. yes their child has the same name as in my other fic bc i made mydei and phainon miis in tomodachi life and i named their kid anemone and made a design for her so it's kind of canon to me now that this is their daughter.

thank you so much for reading to the end, i had a lot of fun with this one and i hope you all liked it!!

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